THE GOBLIN WARS

The Ledger of Ashes

BOOK ONE

UNOFFICIAL FAN FICTION

About this edition

This is unofficial fan fiction set in the Harry Potter and Wizarding World setting. It is not an official or endorsed publication. Harry Potter and the Wizarding World are properties of their respective rights holders. This free fan work is not authorised, endorsed or sponsored by them, and no official status is claimed.

The story follows original characters in an imagined account of the goblin rebellions. The edition contains twenty-two chapters. Narration, where published, is a separate performance and is not embedded in this book.

Published by the author as a free fan work. No endorsement, licence or affiliation is implied.

Contents

Chapter One: The Audit 4

Chapter Two: The Household 14

Chapter Three: Blackwater 27

Chapter Four: The Accommodation 40

Chapter Five: The Weigh House 52

Chapter Six: The Dispatch Clerk 62

Chapter Seven: The Source Column 74

Chapter Eight: The Back Room 86

Chapter Nine: The Abstract 97

Chapter Ten: The Doorway 108

Chapter Eleven: The Package 119

Chapter Twelve: The Agreed Balance 130

Chapter Thirteen: The Maker's Mark 141

Chapter Fourteen: The Outer Stores 153

Chapter Fifteen: The Lower Gate 164

Chapter Sixteen: The Part Left Out 176

Chapter Seventeen: A Visit Allowed 187

Chapter Eighteen: The Second Cart 197

Chapter Nineteen: What They Can Stop 206

Chapter Twenty: The Transfer 215

Chapter Twenty-One: Two Signatures 227

Chapter Twenty-Two: The Work of Keeping 238

Chapter One: The Audit

The first body arrived with the morning accounts.

It lay on a handcart beneath a wool blanket, its feet sticking out where the cloth had been pulled over its face. One boot was polished. The other had a split sole, and each time the porter negotiated a bend in the passage, the sole opened and shut as if the dead man were trying to speak.

Ragna let the cart pass before she went into the counting room. The porter was a goblin she recognised from the lower furnaces. Soot had settled in the creases around his eyes.

“Who is it?” she asked.

“Dorrik.”

She had seen him two nights ago, arguing over the price of onions in the market. “What happened?”

“He fell.”

The porter said it with the careful patience of someone who had given the same answer to several people already. He moved on. Ragna watched the boot open and shut until the cart vanished around the corner.

Inside, the counting room smelled of hot metal and wet coats. Six clerks sat at their desks beneath lamps that burned without oil. Their pens moved in the quick, neat strokes of people who wanted their work finished before anyone important arrived.

Ragna hung her coat and took the leather pouch from her belt. The key inside was cold against her palm. She unlocked her desk, removed the previous day's balance, and laid it beside a clean sheet of parchment. It was the last morning of the quarter, and the accounts had to close before noon. There were families whose wages depended on the figures agreeing.

Her apprentice, Tavin, slipped into the chair opposite her. His hair had been cut short in patches, as though someone had attempted the job in poor light.

“Your mother did that?” Ragna asked.

“She was angry.”

“I can see that. What did you do?”

“Asked her to stop.”

He gave her the grin he used when he hoped to escape a question, and she let him. He was nineteen and had joined the counting house six months earlier. He could add a column twice as fast as she could, and he still believed the people who signed the accounts read them.

Ragna gave him the wage books. “Check the furnace deductions. Every one.”

“Again?”

“The numbers changed between Tuesday and yesterday.”

“I checked yesterday.”

“And today we'll know whether you were right.”

Tavin opened the first book with an exaggerated sigh. The metal clasp had been bent back and forth so often

that the hinge was white. It would break soon. Ragna made a note to have it repaired, then crossed the note out. Repairs came from the counting room allowance, and the allowance was already spent.

At the far end of the room, the outer door opened. Conversation ceased. Ragna heard a lamp hiss.

A wizard entered in a dark travelling cloak, followed by two goblins from the bank's upper offices. The wizard had a long, narrow face and the expression of a man who had been kept waiting for something he considered his. He carried no case. His wand was tucked into a silver clip at his wrist.

Ragna stood. She knew the two goblins, though not well: Merrok, who managed the London accounts, and Ilva, a senior examiner. Merrok had a way of holding his hands behind his back that made his fingers look broken. Ilva met Ragna's eyes and looked away.

“This is Mr Harrow,” Merrok said. “He has authority from the Ministry to examine the special accounts.”

“We have no special accounts,” Ragna said.

Harrow took in the desks, the clerks, the books. “Then I imagine the examination will be brief.”

Tavin was still seated. Ragna touched the edge of his desk and he stood so quickly that his chair scraped the floor.

Merrok drew a folded paper from his coat. It bore a red seal. “The order is for the iron ledger.”

Ragna did not reach for it. “The iron ledger belongs to the signatories.”

“It belongs to the bank.”

“The bank holds it for them.”

“Those are not the instructions I have.”

She looked at Ilva. The examiner's face remained still. There was a small burn on the cuff of her jacket, a black circle no wider than a knuckle. Ragna remembered her at a supper three years ago, laughing with a glass in her hand. She had not expected help from her then, either.

Harrow stepped closer. “The Ministry is investigating the movement of restricted metal. We have reason to believe the ledger records certain transactions.”

“What metal?”

“That is part of the investigation.”

“And which transactions?”

“If you produce the ledger, we can establish that.”

Ragna held out her hand. Merrok gave her the order. The paper was thick and expensive, the Ministry seal pressed deep enough to show through. She read it twice, more slowly the second time. The order named the ledger and required the bank to surrender it. At the bottom were two signatures, one from the Ministry and one from the bank.

She knew the second hand. She had balanced its owner's private accounts for four years.

“The signatories haven't been consulted,” she said.

“They needn't be,” said Merrok.

“They paid to keep the record under seal.”

“They paid the bank. The bank has made a decision.”

One of the clerks shifted behind her. Ragna folded the paper carefully along its existing crease. Dorrik's name was in the ledger. So were the names of three hundred others: craftsmen who pooled their earnings to buy metal and tools, widows who held shares for children too young to sign, a dozen small workshops whose debts were recorded beside their savings. The record could tell Harrow who had bought a quantity of iron. It could also tell him who owed money, who had fallen ill, who had quietly sent wages to a brother in hiding.

“What happens to the quarter's wages?” she asked.

Harrow looked at her as if she had changed the subject.

“We close at noon,” Ragna said. “The ledger carries the signed balances. The wage books show what each workshop earned, but not what it has already drawn. Without the balances we cannot authorise payment.”

Merrok's mouth tightened. “Make a copy of the totals.”

“That will take time.”

“Then begin.”

She could have refused. The thought came to her cleanly and passed. Merrok had signed the order; Harrow had his wand; every clerk in the room was listening. A refusal would cost her the ledger and her position before she had learned what they wanted from either. It might cost the wages too.

“Two hours,” she said.

“One,” said Harrow.

She looked at the clock. “One hour, then.”

Merrok gave her the key to the strongroom. It was attached to a chain which he unwound from his wrist with a little ceremony. Ragna took it, aware of Tavin watching her. She had taught him that an account was a promise to the person whose name it carried. Now she was going to open that account for a stranger.

“Come with me,” she told him.

The strongroom was across the passage and down a short flight of steps. Ilva took a lamp from its bracket and followed them, her shoes making no sound on the stone. The door was iron-bound oak, its lock shaped like a closed eye. Ragna put the key in and turned it twice. The eye opened; she felt the familiar pressure against her thoughts, the lock searching for a name it knew. Then the bolts drew back.

The room beyond was cool and dry. Chests lined the walls. At the centre stood a stone table, and on it the iron ledger, its cover dark and dull as river water. It was too large for one goblin to carry comfortably, which was one reason it had survived so many attempts to move it.

Tavin put his hands beneath the book. Ragna stopped him.

“Bring the stool,” she said.

He fetched it from the corner. She sat and opened the ledger to the wages, finding the page by touch before Ilva brought the lamp closer. Columns filled the paper in a dozen hands. Some entries had been amended, the old figures struck through but still legible. A good account

showed its corrections.

Ragna set a blank sheet over the opposite page. Tavin opened his ink.

“Read them to me,” he said.

She read the first ten totals. He wrote quickly. At the eleventh she paused.

Dorrik's workshop had been charged for forty bars of iron. The entry was in her own hand, made a fortnight ago from a delivery note brought up from the furnaces. Beneath it was a second charge for the same amount, entered yesterday. The hand was unfamiliar.

“Forty bars,” she said. “Twice.”

Tavin leaned over the page. “That's wrong. I checked the deductions.”

“When?”

“Yesterday morning. It wasn't there.”

Ilva came to the table. “Is there a problem?”

“A duplicated entry.” Ragna kept her finger on the figures. “It changes the balance.”

“Correct it on the copy.”

“I need the delivery note.”

“You don't have time.”

“Then I won't know which entry is right.”

Ilva glanced toward the open door. “Write down the total as it stands. You can make an adjustment next quarter.”

Dorrik's widow would have to wait three months for the money. Perhaps longer, if the ledger was still in Ministry hands. Ragna looked at the entry again. It had been made in black ink, but the iron nib had caught on a rough patch of paper. Under the final stroke, a faint red line showed through.

Someone had written over something else.

She put the tip of her nail beneath the page. A corner lifted, just enough to show the edge of another sheet. Two pages had been stuck together.

Ilva put her hand on the book. “Leave it.”

Ragna looked up. “You knew.”

“I know we have less than an hour.”

Tavin's pen hovered over the parchment. “What should I write?”

For a moment nobody answered. From above came the muted drag of furniture across the counting room floor. Harrow had grown tired of waiting. Or he had started searching without the ledger.

Ragna took the small knife from her belt. Ilva caught her wrist.

“Think carefully,” Ilva said.

Ragna did. She thought of Dorrik's split boot and the porter who had said he fell. She thought of the extra charge, which would take nearly all the wages owed to his workshop. None of it proved a murder, or even a theft. It was enough to make her want to see the page.

She pulled her wrist free and slid the knife between the sheets. The adhesive crackled. Tavin held his breath as she worked down the margin. When the pages came apart, a narrow strip of parchment tore away and clung to the back of the upper sheet.

There was a list underneath. Not names this time, but quantities and destinations, each marked with a date. Beside the most recent entry was a familiar signature: Merrok's.

The door at the top of the stairs opened.

Ilva swore quietly. She snatched the loose strip from Ragna's hand, folded it into her palm and closed the ledger.

“Carry it up,” she said.

Ragna stared at her.

“Now.”

Footsteps descended. Tavin lifted one end of the book; Ragna took the other. Harrow appeared at the bottom of the stairs just as they reached the door. His eyes went to the knife in Ragna's hand, then to Ilva.

“Is there a difficulty?”

“No,” Ilva said. “The ledger is ready.”

Harrow held out his hand for the knife. Ragna gave it to him, handle first. He examined the blade and wiped it on his cuff before returning it.

“Bring the book.”

They carried it upstairs. The clerks had been moved away from their desks and stood together by the wall.

Merrok watched Ragna as she set the ledger down in front of the wizard. She could not tell whether he knew what she had seen.

Harrow opened the cover. The pages turned of their own accord, one after another, until they stopped at the wages. He inspected the figures, then the damp sheet in Tavin's hand.

“You haven't finished.”

“No,” Ragna said.

“Pity.” He closed the book. “You'll have to make other arrangements.”

He placed two fingers on the cover, and the ledger shrank until it was small enough to slip into his cloak. Ragna felt a sharp, unreasonable need to ask whether he had folded any of the pages. She kept her mouth shut.

Merrok told the clerks to return to work. They went back to their desks without speaking. Harrow left with him; Ilva followed last. At the door she stopped and held out her hand to Ragna.

“The strongroom key.”

Ragna gave it to her. Ilva's fingers closed around it, and something small and dry pressed into Ragna's palm.

When the door had shut, Ragna opened her hand beneath the desk. The torn strip lay across her skin. It held only part of a line: a date, the number forty, and the end of a place name.

She knew the place. It was Blackwater shaft, where Dorrik had fallen.

Chapter Two: The Household

By noon the counting room had acquired a queue.

Ragna could see the first three people through the half-open door. A woman held a broken lantern, though it was broad daylight above ground. Behind her a furnace worker was eating something from a cloth, slowly, to make it last. The third person was Sella, Dorrik's wife. She had brought a basket.

Tavin stood beside Ragna's desk with the unfinished copy of the balances.

“We could pay the first ten,” he said.

“And the eleventh?”

“They would have something.”

“The first ten would. Tell the others why they came too late.”

He looked down at his sheet. So much for teaching him something useful. She had made him ashamed of trying.

“Bring the withdrawal slips,” she said. “We may be able to reconstruct more of it.”

“May?”

“Yes. May.”

Sella came in without being called. She set the basket on the desk and took out a folded coat, a packet of needles, and a small blue cup with its handle wrapped in string. Finally she removed a wooden box and put everything else away.

“These are his day tallies,” she said. “The workshop ones are downstairs. I thought you'd want both.”

Ragna stood.

Sella's hair was bound back so tightly that the skin at her temples shone. One cuff was damp, and there was a crescent of pale dust on her shoulder. Whatever she had been doing when the news came, she had not changed.

“I was going to come to you,” Ragna said.

“I need his balance. There are people waiting to be paid.”

“Sella, the ledger has been taken.”

“By whom?”

“The Ministry. With the bank's agreement.”

“Does the Ministry intend to pay our people?”

“No arrangement has been made.”

Sella looked at the box, then at Tavin. “Then we'd better make one.”

She slid the lid back. Inside, tally sticks had been tied in bundles with red thread. Each stick carried a workshop mark, a date and notches showing the hours worked. Dorrik had been a fitter, but he had done the household's deliveries as well. Ragna knew the long, sloping cut he used for seven. It had irritated her for years because it looked like a damaged nine.

“I have what he earned,” she said. “What I need is the signed balance after the advances.”

“He took no advance this quarter.”

“Against his own wages?”

“Against anyone's. We sold a set of hinges to a Muggle carrier in February and kept enough from that. I can show you.”

Tavin opened his mouth, then thought better of it.

“Good,” Ragna said. “I will need to see it.”

“You can see it at our table.”

“The office closes at four.”

“Your office can do as it likes. Our men finish at three, and they expect money.”

She put the lid on the box. The blue cup showed through the top of the basket. Ragna recognised it as the one Dorrik brought to work. He had mended the handle badly, which had been a standing joke among the fitters. A man who could set a gate so true that it closed under its own weight had tied his cup together with string.

Ragna took her coat.

“Tavin, gather every slip we have. Keep them here. Nobody takes an original.”

“Are we open?” he asked.

She looked past Sella at the people in the passage.

“Tell them where I am.”

Sella picked up the basket and went first.

The family's workshop stood in a row of vaulted rooms beneath a yard near the river. Ragna had passed the yard a hundred times without entering. Above ground a carter was swearing at a wheel; below, someone was

practising a tune on a pipe and missing the same note each time. The passage smelled of coal, cabbage and damp stone.

Four names stood on the brass doorplate. Dorrik's was second; Sella's came first.

Inside, six small bells hung on a wooden frame. As Ragna crossed the threshold, one gave a low, displeased note.

“Mind the sill,” Sella said.

Ragna stepped back. The loose nail that had caught her coat sank into the wood as Sella pressed it with a thumb.

“It ought to do that before you arrive,” she said. “Neri has been improving it.”

“It's meant to keep strangers out,” said a young woman from the workbench. “If you keep telling them where to step, it cannot learn.”

She was filing a thin metal tongue. The bench held pieces of hinges, a half-assembled latch and three mugs of cold tea. A boy sat beneath it, sorting rivets into a tray with ten compartments.

“This is Ragna,” Sella said. “She has come about the wages.”

The young woman put down her file. “Has she brought them?”

“No.”

“Then she can have the other stool.”

The stool rocked beneath Ragna. She moved it half a hand's breadth to the left. It rocked there too.

Neri watched her with an expression much like her father's. Dorrik had once looked at a charge of three sickles for replacing a lock and asked whether the new one could sing.

“Orren,” Sella said to the boy, “put the kettle on.”

“I sorted these already.”

“Then they'll be there when you return.”

He climbed out, keeping one hand closed. Sella caught his wrist and held it until he dropped four rivets into the right compartment.

“For your boat?” she asked.

He nodded.

“Ask.”

He went to the little stove without asking.

Ragna kept her hands flat on her knees. There ought to have been something she could say in a room like this. She had known Dorrik for sixteen years. She had never known that his son was building a boat.

“I am sorry,” she said.

Sella turned a mug upright. “So am I.”

The kettle began to shiver. Orren pressed two fingers to a round stone set beside the stove. The shivering ceased, and a thin thread of steam climbed from the spout.

“We were told he fell,” Ragna said.

“He did fall,” Neri said. “Everybody seems satisfied with that.”

“Do you know what happened before?”

Sella poured water over the leaves in the pot. “They brought him at ten. Brann brought him. There was a man with him from the bank who said Dorrik had no business in the lower shaft after the shift bell.”

“Which man?”

“I don't know. He had a red waistcoat and a paper for me to sign.”

“Did you sign it?”

“No.”

Ragna looked at Neri.

“My mother can refuse a paper without assistance,” Neri said.

“I didn't mean that.”

“People have been arriving all morning meaning things.”

Sella set the teapot down hard enough to interrupt them both. “The paper is over there.”

It lay beneath a weight on the end of the bench. Ragna lifted it. A receipt for the return of a body, it said. In smaller writing below, it acknowledged the deceased's presence outside his assigned working area. Below that was a sentence stating that the household held no claim against the carrier.

“Who was the carrier?” she asked.

“He said it meant Brann,” Sella said.

“Did Brann say that?”

“Brann said nothing.”

The porter from the morning. Ragna could still see him pushing the cart, exhausted by questions. She read the sentence again. A carrier could be a man, or a business, or the party responsible for a load. The paper did not say.

“Keep this,” she said.

“I was going to.”

“I mean, don't give it back if they ask.”

Sella poured a cup of tea and pushed it towards her. “Now the wages.”

The household books occupied a drawer beneath the bench. They were wrapped in an old apron, with a bundle of bills pressed between them. Ragna opened the cash book. Sella's hand was small and upright. There was no empty space at the end of a page; when she reached the bottom, she turned the book sideways and finished along the margin.

Ragna followed the entries from the hinge sale through coal, food, materials and the wages already paid. She checked the arithmetic twice. It was right.

“You have enough for two days,” she said.

“One,” Sella said. “We owe for the moulding sand. The bill arrived this morning.”

“I could speak to the supplier.”

“I already did. She can wait until Friday. What she cannot do is give us another load while we owe for the first.”

Neri picked up a hinge and worked it open with her thumb. “We have enough metal to finish the school order. If we finish it, we can ask for payment early.”

“Would they agree?”

“They may. If they don't, I shall have spent an afternoon doing the job I had to do anyway.”

Ragna turned another page. “These forty bars. You received them a fortnight ago?”

Sella looked at the entry. “We received twenty.”

“The delivery note says forty.”

“Then the note is wrong.”

“Dorrik brought it himself.”

Neri stopped moving the hinge.

“He brought it to you?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“And you entered forty.”

“It had been signed.”

“By whom?”

Ragna remembered the paper less clearly than she wanted to. The date, the weight, the rate. A signature beneath each of the two columns. One from the works, one from the household.

“Your father,” she said.

Neri put the hinge down. “Then he signed for iron we never had.”

Ragna waited. Sella lifted the teapot, found it empty and set it back.

“That is what you think?” she asked her daughter.

“I think she has his signature and we have twenty bars.”

“Could they have been delivered elsewhere?” Ragna asked.

“Our store is the cupboard behind you,” Sella said. “If you can find twenty bars in it that I have overlooked, you may keep one.”

Orren came back to the bench. “He went to ask about it.”

All three women turned towards him.

“About what?” Sella asked.

“The other iron. He said Neri had counted twice and she was too tiresome to be wrong twice.”

“When did he say that?”

“Yesterday. He said he'd find the man with the other cart.”

Neri looked at the floor. “I told him to take it back. The signed note. I told him if he signed for forty, we would pay for forty.”

“Why didn't you bring it to me?” Ragna asked.

“Because he said he would sort it out,” Sella said. “And because I had a houseful of people asking him about forty things a day. You knew what he was like.”

At her desk, Dorrik apologised for wet boots and argued about charges. She had not known what he carried

home.

She took the torn strip from her pocket and laid it on the table.

“This came from the ledger. A page had been covered over. I don't know what the entry meant, but there were quantities and places on it.”

Sella leaned close. Neri did not touch it.

“Blackwater,” she said.

“That's what I thought.”

“It is. We have done enough of their gate fittings.”

Ragna had meant to withhold Merrok's signature until she knew more. Neri was waiting, and Sella had stopped pouring the tea.

“The page was signed by Merrok.”

“The bank man?” Sella asked.

“Yes.”

“Does that mean he ordered it?”

“I don't know.”

“Does it mean Dorrik was carrying something for him?”

“I don't know that either.”

“Then what have you brought us?”

The boy had gone very still beside the rivets. Ragna folded the strip once along its crease.

“A reason to ask for the delivery records,” she said. “And a problem with the charge against your wages. That I can prove. There are two entries for the same forty

bars.”

Neri gave a short laugh with no pleasure in it. “Eighty, then. We ought to be building a bridge.”

Sella opened her hand. Ragna hesitated, then put the strip in it. She watched Sella turn it to the light, read it, and place it on the bench beside the unsigned receipt.

“We need a copy,” Sella said.

“Yes.”

“Two. One for us, one for you.”

“I'll bring paper.”

“We have paper.”

Neri took a sheet from a shelf. It was an old bill with the back unused. She cut it into three pieces and passed two to Ragna. The third she kept. They made separate copies of the fragment and compared them letter by letter. Ragna gave the original back to Sella.

“Keep it dry.”

“I make door fittings. My house has a roof.”

For the first time that day, Ragna nearly smiled.

They spent the next hour listing what was owed to each worker. When the fitters came in, Sella explained what she could pay and what she could not. One left to ask a cousin for work. Another agreed to finish the school hinges for half his usual daily payment, with the rest owed. The third said he would not lend the workshop money by working for less, and Neri told him she understood. He stayed long enough to show her where a pin on the largest hinge would bind.

Ragna wrote each agreement down. She did not ask anyone to make a speech about loyalty.

When the room was quiet again, Sella took Dorrik's coat out of the basket and hung it on the peg beside the door. She put the blue cup on the shelf. The needles went into a jar.

“Neri will go with you tomorrow,” she said.

Ragna looked up from the last note. “To the counting house?”

“To Blackwater.”

“I haven't said I was going.”

“No. You haven't.”

Neri was wrapping a tool roll. She had added a narrow rule, a small hammer and a pair of gloves patched at the fingers.

“We have a latch to fit at the works,” she said. “They ordered it last month. If we arrive to ask questions, somebody will decide we need permission. If we arrive to finish their door, somebody may let us finish it.”

“I will need the delivery records,” Ragna said.

“Then bring something to write on.”

Sella picked up the two pieces of paper, the unsigned receipt and the ledger fragment, and folded them inside her cash book.

“I'll ask Brann to come tonight. He carried Dorrik. He can tell me who told him to.”

Ragna put her own copy in the leather pouch that had held her desk key that morning. The key was still there. It seemed an absurdly small instrument for everything she had thought it protected.

At the threshold the warning bell gave its low note again. Orren, back under the bench, reached out with his file.

“It's her own coat,” he told the bell. “Let go.”

Chapter Three: Blackwater

Neri arrived at the counting house before the lamps were lit. She carried the latch in a sack and wore her father's leather apron folded twice at the waist.

In the night Ragna had dreamed that the wage slips were leaves and somebody had opened a window. She had checked the bundle on her desk three times already and could not put it down.

“You're bringing those?” Neri asked.

“No.”

“Good. I don't want to carry you if you drop them in the river.”

Ragna locked the drawer. Tavin was already at the back table, sorting withdrawal slips into piles. He had brought bread and a jar of pickled cabbage for his breakfast. The smell occupied the room.

“Work from the signatures,” Ragna told him. “If the amounts differ, set them aside. Don't choose the one you like.”

“I know.”

“I know you know.”

He looked at Neri's sack. “Would you like me to come?”

“No,” Ragna said. “I would like you to stay where somebody knows how much we owe.”

That pleased him for a moment. Then he remembered it was a reason to leave him behind.

They took a carrier's cart along the river road. Neri paid the fare before Ragna could find her purse and sat with the latch between her boots. Dawn showed the colour of the fields and very little else. At the edge of a wood, the carrier touched a knot tied into his reins. The horse turned down a lane Ragna would have sworn ended at a hedge.

Blackwater stood beyond it: a low yard, a row of brick sheds and a head frame rising above the trees. Steam escaped from a pipe near the ground. Somewhere underneath them a great weight moved, stopped and moved again.

The carrier unloaded two sacks of coke. Neri slid off the cart and took her sack to the gate.

A goblin in a patched coat came out of the gatehouse. One of his ears was folded at the tip.

“Repairs,” Neri said.

“We sent for your father.”

“Yes.”

The man looked past her, first at Ragna, then at the cart. “They've stopped visitors.”

“We're not visiting.”

He rubbed his hands together. Ragna could see the calculation: let them in and be blamed, keep them out and spend another day taking deliveries through a gate that would not stay shut. Neri waited without helping him.

“Fit it and go,” he said at last.

The latch belonged on a side door used by the handcarts. It had been held closed with rope. Neri cut the rope and set to work removing the old screws. Ragna stood with the tool roll, feeling an urgency that was of no use to either of them.

“You can look after those,” Neri said, giving her the screws.

“Where are the accounts kept?”

“Usually somewhere dry.”

“Neri.”

The young woman put down her hammer. “If they throw us out before this is fitted, they'll say we didn't finish and refuse to pay. Give me ten minutes.”

Ragna gave her ten minutes. Men passed them carrying tools or empty buckets. Nobody stopped. Several looked at Neri, looked again, and moved on without speaking. In a shed opposite, a pair of goblins were testing a length of chain, link by link. Each time they struck it, a small red light ran into the metal and faded.

One of them said something Ragna could not hear. The other laughed. Neri's hand slipped on the screwdriver.

“It's all right,” she said, though nobody had asked.

Ragna crouched and held the latch steady. Together they tightened the last two screws.

Neri tested it six times. On the seventh, she pressed a finger to the metal, and the tongue drew back before she touched the handle.

“It will need their keeper's hand,” she said. “I can leave it open until he comes.”

The gatekeeper accepted the new latch without praising it. He signed the repair bill on top of the gatepost.

“Where's the tally office?” Ragna asked him.

He looked at the bill as if it might answer for him. “Why?”

“I keep the workshop accounts. There's a delivery note I need to compare with yours.”

“What workshop?”

Neri gave the family name from the brass plate. His gaze dropped to her apron. At last he understood who she was.

“Past the boiler shed. Second door.” He lowered his voice. “Don't ask the wizard. Ask Hessa.”

The tally office contained a narrow desk and a stove too large for it. Hessa was a thickset goblin woman with a pencil tucked into her collar. She stood when she saw Neri, then sat again.

“You should have sent word,” she said.

“We brought the latch.”

“How's your mother?”

“Working.”

Hessa nodded as if it were the only possible answer. She shifted a pile of dispatch cards away from the wet patch beneath the window.

Ragna introduced herself and described the disputed delivery. She did not mention the concealed page.

“Forty bars on the twelfth,” Hessa said. “I remember. He came back about it.”

“When?”

“Day before yesterday.”

“Did you find the other twenty?” Neri asked.

Hessa put her hands under the desk. “Not here.”

“Where, then?”

“I don't know where.”

Ragna took out her paper. “What do your records show?”

Hessa looked towards the window. A wizard in a brown coat was crossing the yard with a roll of parchment under his arm.

“My records show forty,” she said.

“Sent to us?”

“Released for delivery.”

“That isn't the same thing.”

“No,” Hessa said. “It isn't.”

She pulled a wooden tray towards her. Small cards stood upright in it, divided by pieces of scrap tin. She found the twelfth and laid it on the desk. Two entries shared a destination. Each was for twenty bars. Dorrik's workshop was named at the top, but the second entry had a line across it and two letters written in the margin. The ink was the same shade as the original

figures. Ragna could not tell which had been made first.

“May I copy it?”

“Names and quantities. Not the marks.”

“Why not?”

“Because I know how many people have seen that card, and so do they.”

Ragna put down her pen.

“If this is used, someone will ask you about it.”

“Someone is already asking.”

For the first time Hessa looked angry. She pushed the card back into its place.

“You may write that there were two loads. You saw that. You may write that I showed you. Don't write down a guess about where the second went and call it my words.”

“I won't.”

Neri had her arms folded tightly. “My father signed for both.”

“Your father signed a release at the top. The drivers signed their loads out at the gate. If a man takes a receipt to the bank, it does not mean he drove both carts.”

“Who drove the second?”

Hessa shook her head. Whether she did not know or would not say, Ragna could not tell.

Outside, the brown-coated wizard stopped a worker. He unrolled his parchment. The worker pointed towards the

shaft.

Hessa closed the tray.

“I have to work.”

Ragna wrote two sentences while Hessa watched. She read them aloud. Hessa changed “delivered” to “released” and made her cross out “to the household” in the second sentence.

Then she said, “I never saw him come up.”

Nobody answered.

“People keep saying I did,” she said. “They see an office, they think we see everything from it.”

Ragna put the paper away. “Thank you.”

“Don't thank me yet.”

Brann was at the boiler shed, dragging a length of hose into a coil. He straightened when Neri approached. In daylight he looked younger than he had behind the handcart, with pale lines running through the soot at his throat.

“I went to your house,” he said.

“My mother said.”

“She asked me to come back tonight.”

“Will you?”

He worked one boot beneath the hose to stop it springing free. “If they let me finish.”

Ragna waited until two workers had passed. “I saw you yesterday morning.”

“I remember.”

“You told me he fell.”

Brann kept his eyes on the hose. “He did.”

“Were you there?”

“At the bottom.”

Neri made a small sound. Brann stopped coiling.

“I was at the bottom,” he repeated. “The lift came down wrong. One corner caught. I went around to see what was holding it, and he was there.”

“Was he alive?” Neri asked.

Brann's mouth moved before he spoke. “No.”

She turned away. Ragna let her go a few paces. There was a stack of empty crates by the wall; Neri put her hand on one and stood looking at the grain of the wood.

“Where did he fall from?” Ragna asked.

Brann glanced at the yard. “You should leave before Pell sees you.”

“The wizard?”

“He's taking statements. He likes them to agree.”

“Show me the place.”

“No.”

Ragna stepped back.

“My sister works the chain test,” he said. “My rooms belong to the works. You can come and ask a question, and then you can go home. I cannot.”

Ragna looked at the chain shed. Which one was his sister? She had not thought to ask.

“What can I ask you?” she said.

He stared at her. Then he pointed at the hose beneath his boot.

“Give me that end.”

She helped him lift it over a hook on the wall. He reached past her, pushed the coil flat and said, so quietly that she barely heard, “Count the empty holes. Left of the lift.”

Neri had returned. Brann picked up a bucket and went through the boiler shed without looking at either of them.

The lift stood in a fenced enclosure at the far end of the yard. A platform hung over a black opening, suspended on four chains. There was no wall to keep them from looking. A rope across the entrance carried a board: NO ADMITTANCE DURING EXAMINATION.

Neri stopped well short of it.

“Don't cross,” Ragna said.

“I wasn't going to.”

The platform was broad enough for a loaded cart. On either side, rails guided its wheels. Along the left edge of the shaft, a wooden barrier ran from a post near them to a second post beyond the opening. Another length should have met it at a right angle. Instead there were two empty sockets in the paving and four bolt holes in the adjacent upright. A beam lay against a wall ten feet

away.

Neri crouched on their side of the rope.

“The corner rail,” she said.

“Can you tell when it was moved?”

“From here? No.”

She shifted to see past the platform. A dark scrape ran across the paving towards the edge. The stone around one socket was lighter than the rest.

“It hasn't been exposed to much dirt,” she said. “But it could have been under a cloth. Or scraped clean. I can tell you someone took it apart with tools.”

“Could a load have knocked it down?”

“Not and taken the bolts out whole.”

The bolts lay in a shallow tin beside the beam. Ragna counted four. She wrote the count, the sockets and the position of the beam. She drew the platform badly, then asked Neri to correct it.

“You cannot be here.”

Pell stood behind them. He had a square face, a narrow strip of beard and a wand in his hand. He did not raise it. He did not need to.

“We haven't crossed the rope,” Ragna said.

“The works are under examination.”

“We fitted a latch.”

“Then you may leave.”

Neri held up the signed bill. Pell took it, read it and gave it back. He looked at her apron.

“Your name?”

She told him.

“Ah,” he said.

Ragna disliked him for that more than she had expected.

“We need the delivery records,” she said. “A charge has been made against her household for materials they haven't received.”

“You may submit a request through the proper office.”

“Which office?”

“The bank will advise you.”

“Did you examine the rail before it was moved?”

He looked at her paper.

“Give me that.”

“It is my working note.”

“It concerns an examination in progress.”

“Then take a copy.”

He held out his hand. Behind him Brann appeared at the boiler shed door. Pell did not see him, but Ragna did. She could keep the paper for another ten seconds, perhaps. She could argue until Pell used his wand. Neither would keep Brann's whispered words off the page if he took it.

They were not on it. She had written only what she had seen.

She gave him the sheet.

He read it without moving his lips, folded it and put it in his pocket.

“The gate,” he said.

Neri gathered her tools. Ragna walked beside her, feeling the absence of the note more acutely than she had felt the weight of the whole ledger. At the gate, two men were fastening a notice to the post. Hessa stood outside her office with her arms at her sides. One of the chain testers swore and was told to lower his voice.

Pell called across the yard. “Until the material inquiry is concluded, no persons employed here may remove tools, records or stores without written authority.”

The gatekeeper looked at Neri's sack.

“Ours,” she said. “We brought them.”

He glanced at Pell, then opened the gate just wide enough for them to pass.

On the road, Neri stopped and unrolled her apron. Ragna thought she meant to take it off. Instead she held up the inside flap. In the dust on the leather she had traced four circles and two short lines.

“Four bolts,” she said. “Two sockets.”

“Yes.”

“Left of the lift. Beam against the wall.”

“Yes.”

Neri folded it inward carefully.

“You have paper?”

Ragna took out the last piece Sella had cut for her. They sat on a fallen trunk. Ragna redrew the platform while Neri watched each stroke.

“We have to get Brann out,” she said.

“He has a sister.”

“Then both.”

Ragna put the pen cap on. Beyond the hedge, a hammer began striking the gate as the men fixed the last corner of the notice. She could not see the yard now, or the people in it.

“We will have to ask them,” she said.

Chapter Four: The Accommodation

They reached the counting house after three, carrying a drawing they had made twice and a question nobody had answered.

Tavin had cleared Ragna's desk. On it lay six packets of slips, each weighted with a clean stone. Beside them he had put a plate with half a loaf on it.

“Your mother sent that?” Ragna asked.

“I bought it. You may have some, though.”

She broke off a piece. The first stale mouthful made her ravenous.

Neri laid the drawing beside the plate. Tavin bent over it.

“Where was he standing?”

“We don't know,” Ragna said.

“And that was gone?”

“It was gone when we saw it. We don't know when it was removed.”

Neri took the bread Ragna offered her but did not eat it. “There was a notice about the tools. Brann may not be able to take his own out.”

“Brann?”

“The porter,” Ragna said. “His sister works there. They have rooms belonging to the works.”

Tavin straightened. “They can stay with us.”

“Have you asked your mother?”

“She won't mind.”

“Ask her.”

He opened his mouth, then thought better of it. Ragna wished she could do that more often.

Neri took out the signed repair bill. “Can you enter this? They can't say it wasn't finished.”

Ragna recorded it and gave her a receipt. Neri checked the amount. Before she left, she put the untouched bread in her sack.

“Orren will want it,” she said. “He has decided eating is his work.”

When she had gone, Tavin showed Ragna the packets. Each represented a household or a workshop. Where the withdrawal slips agreed with the wage books, he had made a provisional balance. Where they did not, he had written both sums in the margin.

“We can get signatures for these,” he said, pointing to three of the packets. “They kept their own tallies.”

“Signatures from whom?”

“The people they paid.”

“It would take days.”

“We have days. We have no ledger.”

She looked at the careful stones. He had marked the doubtful amounts with scraps of red thread rather than ink so that nobody could mistake them for charges.

“All right,” she said. “We begin with those. But write provisional at the top.”

“It's already there.”

Of course it was. She ate another piece of bread and began to read.

The door opened before she finished the first packet. The clerk nearest it stood so abruptly that Ragna thought Harrow had returned. Instead Merrok entered alone. Mud had dried on the edge of his coat, and there was a tear at the seam below one pocket. He noticed her noticing it and pulled the coat straight.

“Send the others home,” he said.

“We close at four.”

“It is ten minutes to four.”

Ragna set down the packet. “Tavin stays.”

Merrok looked at him.

“He heard the charge when I did. He has been reconstructing the balances. If you wish to discuss the accounts, he needs to hear it.”

“Does he speak for you now?”

“No. I do.”

Merrok took a chair and waited while the other clerks put away their work. Ragna could hear their coats being shaken out. Nobody said good night. When the door shut, the room seemed much larger.

“I hear you have been at Blackwater,” Merrok said.

“I went with a fitter. There is a disputed delivery.”

“There is an inquiry.”

“Whose?”

“The Ministry's.”

“And the Ministry has taken the only book that will show what our people are owed.”

He rubbed a thumb across the seam of his pocket. “Which is why I am here.”

From inside his coat he took a leather case and two folded sheets. He placed the case on the desk. It made a soft, substantial sound.

Ragna did not touch it.

“I have arranged an accommodation,” he said. “For the households affected by the suspension. A payment now, to be taken into account when the balances are settled.”

“From which fund?”

“The source need not concern them.”

“It concerns me.”

“Then call it my undertaking.”

Tavin leaned forward. Ragna could almost feel his desire to open the case.

“How much?” she asked.

Merrok gave her a schedule. It allowed a payment equal to roughly a week's ordinary earnings for each registered worker, with a smaller amount for dependants. For some households it was more than they needed immediately. For others it would cover food and nothing else. It was the first useful sum anyone had put

on her desk since the seizure.

She read the second sheet.

The heading called it a receipt. Under the spaces for names and amounts, the household would acknowledge lawful custody of the records and accept the bank's determination of any disputed charges. It also released claims arising from the removal of materials under the current inquiry.

“What materials?” she asked.

“Those under examination.”

“Does this include the twenty bars Sella's workshop never received?”

Merrok looked up sharply.

“I cannot answer a question about an unverified assertion.”

“Then take that sentence out.”

“The form has been agreed.”

“By the households?”

“By the people providing the money.”

Ragna ran a finger under the release. “This says they accept a determination that hasn't been made. What is the payment for?”

“To keep them fed.”

“Then why does it speak about materials?”

“Because no one will provide relief indefinitely while claims remain without limit.”

Tavin made a sound. Merrok turned to him.

“You have something to contribute?”

“He isn't asking you to provide it indefinitely,” Tavin said. “He isn't asking you anything. He's dead.”

Ragna closed her eyes for a moment.

Merrok put the schedule flat on the desk. “I have twenty-seven households in difficulty, a Ministry order that I cannot dismiss by wishing it away, and three partners who will not advance reserve funds against balances they cannot verify. If you can find an arrangement acceptable to all of them by morning, I will gladly withdraw mine.”

“Three partners?” Ragna asked.

“The reserve requires two signatures. Neither of the two I approached would put a name to it without the underlying record.”

“Did you show them the wage books?”

“I showed them what I had.”

She looked at the packets beneath their stones. He saw where she was looking and said nothing.

“Leave the form,” she said.

“And the money?”

“Take it with you.”

Tavin turned towards her, furious.

“I haven't refused it,” she said. “It is not mine to refuse. The people whose names go on this should read it.”

Merrok sat back. The tightness at his mouth eased.

“Tomorrow,” he said. “In the old weigh house. I will explain the terms myself.”

“At two. Sella is burying her husband in the morning.”

He looked down at his hands.

“Yes,” he said. “At two.”

He took the case and left both sheets. At the door he paused.

“You have worked here for eleven years, Ragna. I know what that has cost you. Be careful whose anger you borrow.”

After the door closed, Tavin walked to it and slid the bolt.

“You could have kept it until they decided.”

“It came with a form.”

“We could have put the form in a drawer.”

“And when somebody was hungry tonight?”

He said nothing.

She pushed the schedule towards him. “Copy it. All of it, including the part that looks dull.”

“Is there another kind?”

“The dull part is where he put the claims.”

Tavin sat. His pen moved hard enough to scratch. Ragna began a second copy beside him.

Sella was at the workshop, wrapping the finished school hinges in sacking. Brann stood by the bench with a folded coat under his arm. His sister had come with him,

still wearing the leather gloves Ragna had seen at the chain shed.

Ragna stopped in the doorway. Brann saw the copied form in her hand and stepped away from the bench.

“It is an offer,” she said. “Not an order.”

His sister took it from her. She read the first paragraph and gave it back.

“They've put the gatekeeper's son on the night watch,” she said. “He's never worked a winch in his life. They told us we may take a day away if we put it in writing.”

“Did you?”

“No. I came home at the end of my shift.”

She flexed her hands inside the gloves. The left one did not open fully.

“Tavin's mother has room,” Ragna said. “He was going to ask her. You would need to speak to her yourselves.”

Brann shook his head. “We have a room.”

“At the works,” Neri said.

“Yes. At the works. With our clothes and our mother's plates in it.”

“Then fetch them.”

“Her plates fill a chest.”

Neri looked at the little handcart under the bench. Sella followed her eyes, then looked at Ragna.

“You can take it,” she told Brann. “It has to be back before the school collection tomorrow.”

Brann put down the coat. “They'll see us.”

“Then they will know you took your plates,” his sister said. “I'm not leaving them to the gatekeeper's boy.”

They argued quietly over what could fit on the cart. A blanket, the chest, two bundles of clothes. Brann wanted to leave the chest and carry the plates wrapped in shirts. His sister said she had wrapped them once to bring them here from their mother's house and would not do it again while a cart was available.

Ragna left them arguing and went back to the counting room. Tavin was still there, finishing the schedule. She told him what his mother was being asked to consider.

He washed his pen at once. “I'll take them to her.”

“You don't have to move them tonight.”

“No,” he said. “They do.”

Outside the workshop, he took one handle of the cart. Neri took the other. Brann's sister told them to leave room by the wheel for a sack of coal she had paid for, and Ragna found herself holding a lamp while four people settled how to move a life in one journey.

By the time she reached her own room, the lamps in the passage had dimmed. A neighbour's door stood open, letting out the smell of fried onions. Ragna had meant to buy some two nights earlier and had decided they could wait. Now she found herself standing still in the passage, remembering Dorrik arguing over them, refusing to pay for the green shoots as if they were part of the bulb.

Her room held a bed, a table and the narrow shelves she had paid a carpenter to fit around a crooked chimney breast. The carpenter had been a witch with a squint and a tendency to sing when she worked. Ragna had kept her bill for seven years because the shelves were the best thing in the room.

She put her bag on the table and lit the stove. There was soup enough for one person and bread enough for none. She ate the soup from the pan, washed it, and sat down to write out the names of the reserve partners.

She knew two of them professionally. One had once returned an account because a clerk had abbreviated a workshop's name. The other had approved a furnace repair after three men had suffered burns, then asked why nobody had applied before anyone was hurt.

Ragna had not applied. The foreman had told her repairs belonged in next year's estimate. She had accepted that answer and entered the burns under relief.

She put down her pen.

There was a knock. Before she could rise, Tavin called through the door.

“They're in. My mother says if either of them snores, they can negotiate.”

Ragna opened the door. He held a covered bowl.

“She also said you won't have eaten.”

“I have.”

“She said you'd say that.”

He put the bowl on the table. Inside were potatoes, cabbage and a piece of smoked fish. Ragna had not realised he knew where she lived.

“Thank her,” she said.

“She made them agree to share the fuel before she helped unload. She won't have strangers moved into her house as if they were furniture.”

“Quite right.”

He stayed standing by the table. “Could we pay something ourselves?”

“How much have you got?”

“Not just me. People.”

“Some people are waiting for their wages.”

“Some aren't.”

Ragna took her purse out of the bag. There were coins for rent, coal, food and an amount she had been saving to replace the lenses in her reading frame. She sorted them into four small piles. Tavin watched but did not offer an opinion.

“This won't cover a workshop,” she said.

“It might cover a person.”

“And next week?”

He looked at the wall, then back at her. “We work on next week.”

She pushed two of the piles together. A few meals, perhaps. She left the other two piles where they were.

“We need rules,” she said. “People must know whether it's a gift or a debt. They must know who decides.”

“Then write them.”

“No. I'll bring paper tomorrow. They can tell us what to write.”

Tavin looked at the coins for a long time. “I'll ask my mother.”

When he had gone, Ragna uncovered the bowl again. The fish was nearly all bone. She ate slowly, picking each one out with her fingers, and wrote the three partner names on a fresh sheet before she let herself go to bed.

Chapter Five: The Weigh House

Sella had asked for no singing.

Some of the mourners clasped their hands; others held their hats or stared at the ground. A few were still wearing work aprons. One woman had come from the furnaces without washing, and sweat had made little white channels through the dust on her face.

Ragna stood at the back. She had brought flowers from a stall and felt foolish holding them. The stallholder had asked what they were for, then charged her less. She had accepted the kindness and hated the question.

Sella spoke for less than a minute. She said Dorrik had been difficult about getting out of bed and careless with good clothes. He had remembered what people drank. He had once spent six days fitting a gate because the man who ordered it had a bad hand and could not work an ordinary catch.

“He wasn't paid for the extra days,” she said. “I was angry about that at the time.”

She stopped. Neri took her hand, but Sella shook her head and let it go. Orren stood between them with his coat buttoned wrong. He had brought the little wooden boat. He held it throughout the burial and took it home again.

When the earth had been put back, Ragna set her flowers at the edge with the others. Neri was speaking to two of the fitters. Sella had already begun thanking people for coming. She accepted a loaf from the woman

in the furnace apron and put it in her basket as if it were something she had bought.

At the path, Brann waited for Ragna. His sister stood a little way off, talking to Tavin's mother. They had not gone back to work that morning.

“Vessa told me to take a day,” he said. “She says if they want a notice about it, they may come and ask her.”

“She's your older sister?”

“By thirteen minutes. She counts them whenever necessary.”

He looked towards the fresh earth.

“The report says he went down alone. I didn't know what they put in it until last night.”

“Who showed it to you?”

“Pell read it. He asked if I would confirm it.”

“Did you?”

“No.” He scraped mud from his boot with the edge of a stone. “I told him I was at the bottom. I couldn't say how Dorrik got there.”

“That is what you should say.”

“It's what I've said.”

Ragna stepped aside to let him join his sister.

The old weigh house had not weighed anything in eleven years. Its beam still hung above the central table, one pan lower than the other, though both were empty. Children had discovered that a whisper into the left pan came out of the right one twice as loud. When Ragna

arrived, Orren was testing whether it would work for a whistle.

Sella told him once to stop. He stopped.

The room filled slowly. People came in pairs from workshops, or alone with someone else's name folded in a pocket. The woman with the broken lantern had brought it again; Ragna recognised her now as Edda, who worked on the small furnace. She needed a new wick collar and refused to throw away a lantern her aunt had made.

Fenn, a glassworker whose fingers were thickened by old burns, arrived carrying two stools. He had been told there might not be enough seats and took such predictions personally.

Merrok came at two exactly, with a bank clerk and the leather case. He put the case beneath the hanging pan.

“There is no need for speeches,” he said.

“Then you won't need long,” Sella said.

Ragna sat beside Tavin, who had copied the schedule six times. They passed the sheets along the benches. She watched people read, mouth a word, turn a page back. A man near the door held his copy upside down until Edda moved beside him and read it quietly to him.

Merrok explained the payments. A week's ordinary earnings, adjusted for the registered household. No interest. Any amount eventually proved due would be credited, less the payment already received.

“And if the bank finds nothing due?” Fenn asked.

“The payment will not be recovered.”

Several people looked up.

“Put that on the paper,” Sella said.

The bank clerk began to object. Merrok held up a hand. After a moment he nodded, and the clerk made the addition on the receipt form. He read it aloud. Tavin copied the words.

“Can we take the money today?” asked a fitter who had left Sella's workshop to find work with his cousin.

“Yes,” Merrok said.

“And go back tomorrow if more of our wages are due?”

“Your household's account will be settled through the bank.”

The fitter, Brelk, rubbed the back of his neck. “Does that mean yes?”

Ragna pointed to the release clause on her copy. “It means you accept that determination. The form doesn't give you another way to challenge it.”

Merrok looked at her. “If the charges are correct, what would you challenge?”

“If they're wrong?” Brelk asked.

“We will correct them.”

“Who is we?”

“The bank,” Merrok said.

Brelk looked at Sella, who said nothing. His boots were wet and poorly repaired. He had taken two days' extra work in another shop. What could she tell him the right

to challenge a charge was worth?

“What happens if I don't sign?” he asked.

“The inquiry continues,” Merrok said. “And your payment waits on the balances.”

Edda put down her sheet. “That sounds like paying us to stop asking.”

“It sounds like a week's food,” said the woman beside her.

“So does a week's wages.”

“Can you put those on the table?”

Edda looked away. The woman picked up the form again.

Sella raised her voice over them. “Nobody is deciding for anyone else's household. If you want the payment, read what you are giving for it. If you want help reading, ask. Don't put your name down because somebody has looked at you.”

“Does that include you?” Merrok asked.

“Yes.”

He waited as if there ought to have been more. Sella folded her hands.

Brelk was first to the table. He asked the clerk to read the form, including the addition. Then he signed. The case opened with two clicks, and the clerk counted money into his hand.

Brelk put it in a pouch. “My son has a cough that keeps him awake. The room by the stove costs more. That's

what I am buying.”

Nobody had asked him to explain. Ragna wished she could tell him that without making it another public judgement.

He went back to his place. Two other people rose, then a third. The clerk found a rhythm: name, amount, form, signature. Each receipt went into a flat box beside the case. Ragna watched the clerk stack the receipts, their edges square.

When the last of the four sat down, Merrok closed the case.

“The offer remains open until tomorrow evening. The bank clerk will attend here between noon and two.”

“Not at the counting house?” Ragna asked.

“It is better not to confuse the arrangements.”

She heard the warning in that. The money had come with its own office.

Merrok gathered the unsigned forms. Sella asked for one and he left it with her. At the door he turned back.

“I know some of you think a refusal will improve your position. It may. It will not improve your position tonight.”

He went out before anyone answered.

For a while the only sound was Orren turning the little boat over in his hands. Then Fenn picked up one of his stools and set it in front of the table.

“Now,” he said, “what about tonight?”

Tavin stood so quickly that he caught his knee on the bench. He put a folded cloth on the table and opened it. Coins lay inside, mixed with a button he had mistaken for a knut.

“Some of us thought we could put something together.”

“Who is some of us?” Edda asked.

“Me. My mother. Ragna.”

Ragna put her purse beside the cloth. She had left the rent money at home. She told them what she was offering, and that it was a gift.

“It won't pay everybody,” she said. “I don't want anyone to think it will.”

“It won't pay this room,” Fenn said. “But I have flour. It was delivered before the wages stopped.”

“Flour isn't free just because it's been delivered,” the moulding-sand supplier said from the door.

Her name was Hirk. She had come in late and stood holding her cap against her stomach.

“No,” Fenn said. “Mine is paid for.”

“I can let Sella wait until Friday. I cannot let every workshop wait until Friday. I owe the man who brings the sand, and his mule eats whether we have wages or not.”

Sella nodded. “I told you I understood.”

“I'm telling them.”

Ragna picked up her pen. “We need to know what we have, and what people need first.”

“Who sees the needs?” Vessa asked.

“Who do you want?”

“Not everybody in this room.”

They argued. A man wanted each household given the same amount. Edda said a single worker and a household of six could not eat the same money. Fenn offered to divide by children, then was reminded that several old people lived with their families and did not become cheaper because they were older. Someone proposed loans, recoverable when the bank paid. Brelk asked what would happen if the bank never paid.

At that, the room became quiet again.

“Then a loan is a bill for being hungry,” Vessa said.

“Gifts run out,” Hirk answered.

“So do loans. They just leave something behind.”

They settled on food for the next two days, and fuel where there was none. No promise beyond that. Anyone could give food or money; anyone could ask for food or fuel. Three people would hold the list of needs and decide together: Sella, Fenn and Vessa. Ragna would keep the receipts and count the fund in front of them. If they disagreed, they would tell the next meeting rather than settle it by lending secretly.

“It ought to have a name,” Tavin said.

“It has flour,” Fenn said. “Start with that.”

Brelk came to the table while Ragna was adding the coins. He put down two sickles.

“You don't have to,” she said.

“I know what I have to do. Put it with the rest.”

She did. He went to help Fenn carry the flour.

By four, seven households had an arrangement for the evening. Others had agreed to share meals or wait until tomorrow. Ragna could not check all those promises. She watched a woman who had arrived with an empty coal bag leave with it heavy against her leg.

Sella asked Neri to take Orren home. When they had gone, she put the unsigned receipt in front of Ragna.

“I want a way to ask for our balance without signing this.”

“A petition,” Fenn said.

“To whom?”

“The bank partners. And the Ministry for the inquiry.”

“Not one petition,” Ragna said. “They'll each say it's the other's business.”

“Then two.”

She drew two headings. To the bank: verified payment against wages and access to a certified copy of the relevant account. To the Ministry: preservation of the delivery records and a hearing on the circumstances of Dorrik's death. Sella made her add the right to bring someone to read any paper a family was asked to sign.

Brann stood at the edge of the table.

“I didn't see the top of the shaft,” he said.

“You won't be asked to say you did,” Sella replied.

He stayed while they wrote. He did not sign until she read his statement aloud: he had been below when the lift came down at an angle; he had found Dorrik there. Nothing about a push, nothing about who gave an order. He crossed out one word himself and put his name beneath the correction.

Tavin asked how many copies were needed.

“One for each recipient,” Ragna said. “One for us.”

“And everyone who came?”

“Let us see who agrees to have their names copied first.”

He put down the blank sheets. “It's our claim.”

“It is. Every person's name on it is their own.”

Brelk returned with flour on his coat and read the petition over Fenn's shoulder. “Can I sign, even after taking his money?”

Ragna turned the receipt until she could see the exact words again.

“The Ministry petition asks about the death,” she said. “The materials release may affect the bank claim. I can't promise what they'll say about it.”

He considered that, then signed the Ministry petition and left the bank claim untouched.

When the room had emptied, the weighing pan still hung lower on the left. Orren had left a single rivet inside it. Ragna took it out and laid it by the door, where he would see it next time.

Chapter Six: The Dispatch Clerk

The bank accepted its petition at nine. The Ministry accepted its petition at ten, after Ragna had corrected the heading twice and paid for a copy she had not asked to have made.

The receiving clerk pressed a seal into the receipt.

“When will it be answered?” she asked.

“When it has been considered.”

“By whom?”

“The appropriate officer.”

“Put the officer's name on the receipt.”

He looked at her over the top of his spectacles. Behind her, Fenn shifted the bundle of papers from one arm to the other. They had come together because the meeting had agreed that no one should carry both petitions alone.

“I cannot put a name down before the referral,” the clerk said.

“Then write that.”

He sighed, but wrote it. Ragna waited until the ink was dry before she accepted the receipt.

Outside, Fenn bought a hot pie from a woman whose stall stood on the boundary between the visible street and the little court where the Ministry kept its provincial office. When a Muggle cart passed, the court showed only a disused archway. The stallholder fed the archway a scrap of pie crust as casually as she fed the birds.

“For the rats,” she told Fenn when he stared.

“I wasn't asking.”

“They're the only ones who pay attention to the sign.”

Fenn divided the pie with his knife. The filling was mostly potato. Ragna took her half and ate while he held the receipts, the first useful thing they had received that morning.

Ilva was waiting at the counting house.

She had taken the chair facing the door, not the one beside Ragna's desk. The blackened mark on her cuff had been cut away and the edge turned under with small, uneven stitches.

“I need to speak to you,” she said.

“You can.”

“Elsewhere.”

Ragna put her bag down. “These are working hours.”

“I know what hours they are.”

Tavin watched them from the table. Ragna had given him the Ministry receipt. He read the sentence about the officer whose name was not yet known, then turned the paper over as if there might be a better answer on the back.

Ilva lowered her voice. “There is someone you should meet.”

“Who?”

“A Ministry dispatch clerk.”

“What does he want?”

“To be certain he is not the only person left with his name on an instruction.”

Ragna took off her coat slowly. She could still feel the strongroom key passing between them, the dry strip hidden beneath it. She had been waiting for Ilva to explain that moment. Now she did not trust the relief it offered her.

“Why did you give me the fragment?”

Ilva glanced at Tavin.

“He was there,” Ragna said.

“I saw you open the page. If Harrow had found the strip, he would have asked why you had it.”

“So you took it and gave it back where he couldn't see.”

Ilva pressed her hands together. “I had already done enough.”

“What had you done?”

“The page was covered at my direction.”

Tavin put down the receipt.

Ragna had suspected it. Now Ilva sat in front of her admitting she had ordered it done.

“What was on it?”

“A reconciliation.”

“Between what?”

“Accounts that should not have been combined.”

Ragna waited. Ilva looked at the door, then at the open wage books.

“I will tell you what I can prove. Not here.”

“Dorrik's family hears it too.”

“I did not come to arrange a meeting.”

“Then you came to the wrong person.”

Ilva stood. For a moment Ragna thought she would leave. Instead she picked up her coat.

“His name is Daniel Venn. He has asked me not to bring a crowd.”

“Two people is not a crowd.”

“Sometimes it is.”

Ragna went to Sella's workshop and put the choice to her. Neri was shaping the last of the school fittings. The carrier had failed to collect them on the promised day; the school had sent word that he would come tomorrow instead. She listened without taking her hands from the vice.

“I'll stay,” she said. “We promised these for collection. But I want to know what he says.”

“You will,” Sella said.

“Not just what they think it means.”

“All of it.”

Sella put on her coat. She did not take the cash book containing the original fragment. Ragna did not ask where she left it.

Ilva led them to a street above the river where the houses leaned towards one another. At the end was a shop selling ink, sealing wax and paper in small

quantities. The glass in its door had a crack repaired with strips of copper. Inside, a woman was cutting a sheet of paper into quarters while she argued with a customer about the price of the offcuts.

Daniel Venn sat at a table behind the counter. He was a thin wizard with a sunken chin and cuffs polished by years of desk work. A wand lay beside his penknife. He covered both with a sheet when Sella looked at them.

“I don't work here,” he said. “My aunt owns the shop.”

The woman at the counter called, “He pays for what he uses.”

“I told you there would be two,” Ilva said.

“You said one and perhaps another.”

“Here is another,” Sella said.

Venn drew a chair out from under the table. It was too high for her. He began to apologise; she put her foot on the lower rung and climbed up before he finished. Ragna took the stool.

On the wall hung a Ministry calendar. Albert Boot's name appeared in elaborate lettering beneath an engraving of the Ministry seal. Someone had pinned a list of household purchases over the lower part of the page. Ink, onions, lamp oil, two yards of flannel. The flannel had been crossed out.

Venn followed her glance and stood in front of the calendar.

“What has Ilva told you?”

“That you have put your name on something.”

“I put it on hundreds of things.”

“Then start with the one that brought you here.”

He rubbed a thumb along the edge of the table. Under the thin skin of his wrist, a pulse beat visibly.

“There are dispatch instructions for materials leaving Blackwater. I copy them into the Ministry schedule. The works keeps the release card. The receiving depot signs its own counterfoil. Usually the three agree.”

“Usually?”

“If a load changes destination, the instruction is amended. It should be amended on each copy.”

Sella leaned forward. “Twenty bars meant for our workshop.”

Venn looked at Ilva.

“She knows about the two loads,” Ragna said. “She hasn't been told where the second went.”

“It went to Ministry stores.”

“Which stores?”

He put his hand inside his coat, stopped and took it out empty.

“What happens when I tell you?”

“We ask for the receiving record,” Ragna said.

“You won't be given it.”

“Then we will know who refused.”

“You talk as if they mind.”

Sella spoke before Ragna could answer. “What do you want us to do?”

Venn looked towards the counter. His aunt was wrapping the customer's paper in old newspaper, her fingers quick on the fold.

“My mother lives with me. She cannot manage the stairs without help. My sister comes twice a week. Neither of them works for the Ministry. Neither of them knows what I changed.”

“Did someone threaten them?” Ragna asked.

“Not in those words.”

“Which words?”

“He asked whether I still lived over the baker's. Said the steps would be difficult for my mother in winter. We have never discussed my mother.”

“Harrow?”

Venn nodded.

Sella put her hands on the edge of the table. “I cannot promise he won't come to your door.”

“I was told you had helped people leave the works.”

“Two people asked somewhere to sleep,” she said. “We found a room. It has a door. It isn't a fortress.”

“If I testify, they can take my post. They can say I altered the records.”

“Did you?”

He looked at her.

“Did you?” Sella asked again.

“Yes.”

The answer seemed to cost him more than the account of Harrow's visit. He sat back and pulled at one cuff.

“Then I won't say you didn't,” she said.

“I need protection.”

“We can ask about a room for your family. We can bring someone to hear your statement. We can't decide what happens to you for what you've done.”

Ilva had not spoken for some time. Now she said, “That applies to me as well.”

Venn turned on her. “You said it would be held inside the bank.”

“I was wrong.”

“What else were you wrong about?”

She took the question without looking away. “More than I have told them.”

Sella went still beside her. Ragna wanted to demand the rest from Ilva, but Venn was reaching into his coat. She let him.

He laid a folded sheet on the table.

“This is my dispatch duplicate. It records the altered destination and the instruction under which I made the change. The other twenty bars went to the Thorn depot. Stores number three.”

Ragna did not touch it until he pushed it towards her. The paper carried the Blackwater release date, the quantity twenty, and Sella's workshop name struck

through with a single line. Below was a new destination, written in a different hand. At the bottom Venn had initialled it. Beside his initials was a reference to a separate order.

“Whose writing?” she asked.

“Mine. All of the alteration.”

“Was the instruction Harrow's?”

“Through his office. His name is on the order. It is not on this copy.”

Ragna read the distinction aloud, then wrote it on a separate sheet. Sella watched her pen.

“Did you know we hadn't agreed?” she asked.

Venn said nothing.

“Not when you received the instruction. When you copied it.”

“There should have been a notice to your workshop.”

“Was there?”

“I didn't send one.”

“That wasn't what I asked.”

“No. There wasn't.”

Outside, someone called to the baker across the street. Venn flinched. His aunt opened the door and told the caller he was at the wrong number. The door shut again.

“I kept this because there was another order,” Venn said. “A larger procurement. Forty bars, separately paid. I was told to enter both consignments under security stores and leave the source column blank on the public

schedule.”

“Separately paid by whom?” Ragna asked.

“I don't have that voucher. I handle dispatches, not payment.”

She copied the second order number and boxed the reference. Forty-bar orders were common at the works; the quantity alone proved nothing.

“Is the duplicate yours to keep?” she asked.

“It's the Ministry's.”

“Then why do you have it?”

“Because when the inquiry began, the copies were called in. I said this one had been spoiled.”

“You lied.”

“Yes.”

He looked exhausted by the word. Sella turned the sheet over, examining the blank back, then laid it down again.

“Why now?”

Venn looked at Ilva. “She told me a man had died.”

“People had been waiting for wages before he died,” Sella said.

“I didn't know about the wages.”

“You knew whose iron it was.”

He did not deny it.

Ragna put the duplicate between them. “Will you sign what you've told us?”

“Where will it go?”

“To the inquiry, if it opens. To the people whose accounts are affected, if you agree. We won't add your family's address.”

“And if I don't?”

“We have seen the paper. We can say that. We can say what we saw written on it. Without you, we cannot prove who changed it or why.”

He took his wand from under the covering sheet. Ragna held still. He used its tip to light the little lamp at his elbow, then set it down and picked up his pen.

“Write the words as I say them,” he told her. “Not what you think I ought to have said.”

She did.

His statement took less than a page. He corrected a date and crossed out “ordered” in favour of “instructed in writing”. When it was finished, he signed each of the two sheets. Ilva signed beneath as witness. Sella signed after her.

Venn kept the dispatch duplicate. He let them make two copies and wrote across both that they had been compared with the paper in his possession. He did not agree to come to a public meeting. He did agree to speak again after his mother had decided whether to leave the rooms above the baker's.

At the door, his aunt put a small parcel in his hand.

“Flannel,” she said. “I had some in the back.”

He looked at her as if she had offered him something unbearable. She pushed him out of the way and served

the next customer.

They walked back along the river with Ilva between them. Sella carried one signed copy. Ragna carried the other.

“You said more than you have told us,” Ragna said.

Ilva kept walking. “Yes.”

“Tomorrow morning. At the workshop. You explain the page you hid.”

“I have work.”

“So do we.”

Ilva stopped where the path narrowed around a tree root. She looked older in the open light. There were seams in her collar that someone had mended carefully, unlike the cuff.

“If I tell you, I cannot put it back.”

Sella moved past her. “We have a shovel at home with earth still on it. Think about what you can put back.”

Ragna waited until Ilva began to walk again. The copied dispatch in her pouch had lost the warmth of the shop. She kept one hand over it on the way home.

Chapter Seven: The Source Column

Ilva came at seven, before the workshop door had been unbarred. Neri let her wait in the passage while she finished setting a pin in the vice.

Ragna was already inside. Sella had made tea but poured only three cups. The fourth stood empty on the shelf. It was not Dorrik's cup, and Ragna was grateful for that small absence of ceremony.

When Neri opened the door, Ilva stepped over the sill without catching her coat. She noticed the warning bell and looked away from it. Under her arm she carried a flat case wrapped in oilcloth.

“Before you begin,” Sella said, “Neri hears all of it.”

Ilva sat. “I assumed she would.”

“Good. We can agree on something.”

The case contained a narrow control book and a folded authority for an advance. Ilva laid them apart rather than one on top of the other.

“This is my examiner's record,” she said, touching the book. “It records a payment from the pooled workshop reserve. The authority is a copy. My endorsement on it is original.”

Ragna looked at the signatures. Merrok had signed for the advance; Ilva had certified that the authorised amount agreed with the payment entry. The sum was the price of forty bars, at the same rate as the household

charge.

Sella stared at the amount. “Again?”

“Not the same iron,” Ragna said. “Not necessarily.”

Ilva shook her head. “A separate purchase. The order number is here.”

Ragna took out the copy made in Venn's aunt's shop. The references agreed.

“And the Ministry was the buyer?”

“The intended recipient.”

“Who was supposed to pay the reserve back?”

“The Ministry.”

“Then why did the money come from us?” Sella asked.

Ilva kept her eyes on the authority. “It was described as short-term finance. Merrok had an undertaking that the Ministry would settle when its stores allocation was released. He said refusing would bring a wider examination of the bank's metal business.”

“By Harrow?”

“Yes.”

“And you believed him.”

“I believed he could make the examination happen.”

Sella pushed the tea away. “So you gave him our money.”

“I certified the advance. I did not authorise it.”

“That distinction mattered to you?”

“It mattered to my duties.”

“What do your duties call the money?”

For a moment Ilva did not answer. The stove clicked as its little stone cooled.

“Reserve funds belonging to the contributing workshops,” she said.

Neri turned from the bench. “Which workshops agreed?”

“None was asked individually.”

“Which workshops agreed?”

“None.”

Sella gripped the cup in both hands, her knuckles pale. Yesterday it had been Venn explaining why she had not been told.

Ragna opened the control book. A red entry recorded the advance and the intended debtor. A later line transferred its recovery to the iron ledger. Beneath it Ilva had put a small tick.

“You examined the transfer.”

“Yes.”

“To our account?” Sella asked.

Ilva looked at her. “To the ledger holding the workshop accounts.”

“Mine has forty bars charged twice,” Ragna said. “Was the second charge the transfer?”

“That is what Merrok instructed.”

“Did you enter it?”

“No.”

“Did you see it after it was entered?”

“Yes.”

“And you left it.”

“I was told it would be reversed when the Ministry paid.”

The control entry named the Ministry as debtor. Ilva's tick confirmed she had checked the transfer; it did not show who had entered the charge under Dorrik's name. For that, they had Ilva's testimony and a ledger they could no longer inspect.

“What did you cover?” she asked.

“The reconciliation showing the advance beside the workshop posting.”

“Why?”

“Merrok said if Harrow saw a Ministry debt recorded against the reserve, he would widen the seizure. He told me the concealed page would protect the other books.”

“Did you expect the wages to be stopped?”

“I expected the totals to be copied.”

Ragna remembered standing with the knife between the pages, asking for two hours. Ilva had been in the room when Harrow granted one. He had taken even that away.

“You expected me to make a clean copy of the false charge.”

Ilva closed her eyes, then opened them.

“Yes.”

Neri picked up her hammer and set it down again. Its little knock sounded louder than it should have.

Ragna braced her hands on either side of the control book and wanted to shut it on Ilva's fingers.

Sella spoke very evenly. “Was Dorrik working on this purchase?”

“I don't know.”

“Did you know he was dead when you covered the page?”

“No. I heard before we went to the counting room.”

“And went anyway.”

“Yes.”

The kettle began its small ticking complaint. Ragna took it off the stove and set it on the hearth. She stayed there until her hands were steady enough for the cups.

“We have three quantities,” she said. “Twenty bars you say arrived here. Forty released from Blackwater under the first note. Another forty paid for out of the reserve.”

Neri nodded.

“The household was charged for forty, then forty again. We have a dispatch copy saying half the first release was redirected. We haven't seen the depot's receipt. We have a purchase authority and the control entry for a separate advance. We haven't seen the supplier's account or the receipt for those bars either.”

“You don't believe her?” Sella asked.

“Believing her is not enough to make the bank pay.”

Ilva's mouth tightened. Ragna let it.

“If both deliveries went where the dispatches say, the Ministry has twenty from the first and forty from the second. Sixty. You have twenty. Your account has eighty.”

Neri put her hand on the edge of the open control book.

“I understand the sum.”

“I know. I need to know which parts we can prove.”

Ilva turned the copy of the authority. “The supplier's bill is held with the payment voucher in the central cash file. This shows the authority, not final receipt. I can ask for the voucher.”

“Will they give it to you?”

“Not if Merrok has already told them not to.”

“Then ask in writing.”

Ilva looked down at her book. “He will know.”

“He knows we went to Blackwater,” Neri said. “You told him where to find our money.”

Ilva looked to Ragna. Ragna said nothing.

They copied the advance authority and the relevant lines of the control book. Sella insisted on including the dates of the later transfer and Ilva's examining tick. Ilva initialled the copies and wrote a statement of what she had seen and certified. She kept the control book; the others kept copies.

Before Ilva put the book away, Ragna asked about the reserve partners.

“Can they authorise payment from another reserve without the ledger?”

“They can authorise an advance against a liability they are prepared to recognise.”

“Then Merrok was wrong to say they couldn't.”

“He said they wouldn't.”

Ragna remembered the words exactly. Three partners, two approached, no underlying record. She disliked Merrok the more for having left himself room to be accurate.

“The reconstructed wages,” she said. “The withdrawal slips, the household tallies, workers willing to acknowledge what they've already received. They could be examined separately.”

“Yes.”

“And paid, with disputed materials held out until examined.”

Ilva looked at Sella. “It would mean someone standing behind the reconstructed balances.”

“I will stand behind mine,” Sella said. “But they don't get to pay only the difference on the iron. There are wages owing on top of that.”

“Exactly,” Ragna said. “The whole verified balance after the materials you actually received. The claim against the Ministry belongs elsewhere.”

For the first time since she arrived, Ilva took her own pen out. She wrote the proposal on a clean sheet and gave it to Ragna to correct.

“You should send it to Issa,” she said. “She is one of the partners. She is staying at the bank house for the quarter inspection. Halrik is expected tomorrow. You need both names.”

“Will you bring it?”

“I can put it before her. I cannot make her read it.”

“You can tell her why it matters.”

Ilva folded the statement she had signed. “She'll ask why I did not tell her earlier.”

Sella lifted her cup at last. “You appear to have the answer.”

After Ilva left, Neri shut the door and stood with her hand on the latch. Ragna waited while Sella rinsed the cups. The work seemed to require all her attention.

“I was angry with you for entering forty,” she said at last.

“You had reason.”

“You had a signed note.”

“I still didn't ask what the signature meant.”

Neri turned. “Neither did he.”

Sella set the cups upside down. She did not answer for her husband.

A cart arrived for the school hinges before noon. The carrier checked each bundle against the bill and gave

Sella a purse with the payment. She counted it at the bench while he waited. It was less than the full price. The school had agreed to pay early in return for a discount, and she had accepted.

Neri said something under her breath.

“It pays Hirk,” Sella said. “It buys the next sand. We finish the other order.”

“And pays us less for being poor.”

“Yes,” her mother said. “Today it does.”

She put the supplier's money in one envelope and the wages in another. Ragna watched her pay the fitter who had stayed and write down what was still owed. There was no ledger from the bank, no red seal and no senior examiner. The man counted his coins and went back to the bench.

At the counting house that afternoon, Tavin brought the first three reconstructed balances for Ragna to check. Each had a household signature and the witnesses' names. One person had refused to sign because he was not sure about a small advance taken in the winter. Tavin had set the whole balance aside.

“Leave the doubtful sum aside,” Ragna said. “Not everything he earned.”

“He didn't agree to the total.”

“He agreed to the rest?”

“Yes.”

“Then write what he agrees to. We have been letting one doubtful number hold every other number prisoner.”

Tavin looked at her for a moment, then drew a line through the provisional heading and wrote two: agreed and disputed.

Edda brought her own tally near the end of the afternoon. The broken lantern was still hanging from her wrist.

“I took the bank money,” she said before Ragna could offer a chair.

“All right.”

“It isn't all right. It is what I did.”

She put the receipt on the desk. This one had the addition made at the meeting about the payment not being recovered. Beneath her signature, the clerk had drawn a line through the space left for dependants.

“He says I can't add my aunt now.”

“Does she live with you?”

“Since the cold weather. Her rooms have water in the wall. He says she wasn't registered before the offer.”

Ragna read the schedule. Dependants were calculated from the register, just as Merrok had said. It did not mean Edda's aunt had stopped eating.

“I can write to the clerk,” she said.

“He told me you'd say that.”

Ragna put the pen down. “What would help tonight?”

“Coal. I have food.”

“Tell Vessa. She holds that list with Sella and Fenn.”

“I signed his form.”

“The fund didn't ask you not to.”

Edda sat at last. She unclipped the lantern and stood it beside the tally. In the counting room's steady lamplight, its dented glass looked grey.

“He said the money was for the people on the register. I kept thinking I should have put her name down in the winter.”

“He did not ask what you were thinking. He asked who was on the register.”

Ragna put a clean sheet beside the receipt, copied the stated condition, and wrote a request for review. Before Edda left, she asked if she wanted a copy for the petition. Edda said yes to the rejected addition, no to the household's other figures. Ragna put only the first sheet in the public bundle.

They worked until the lamps burned brighter than the light from the passage. When Fenn arrived to count the fund, Ragna showed him Ilva's statement. She had left Venn's statement in a separate bundle until he agreed to its use. Fenn read slowly, touching the line of figures with his smallest finger.

“How many other accounts?” he asked.

“We don't know.”

“Then put that on the copy.”

She did. He put two more sickles into the fund, which now held enough for tomorrow's bread and not tomorrow's coal.

Ragna closed the lid over the coins. At the bottom of the reserve request, beneath her description of the agreed balances, she wrote her own name. She blotted the signature before closing the request.

Chapter Eight: The Back Room

Daniel Venn's mother wanted her own chair.

It stood beside the window above the baker's shop, with a cushion held together by twenty years of mending. The window looked into a wall. Ragna could see no reason to prefer it to any other window, but Mrs Venn rested one hand on the arm of the chair as if she expected someone to steal it while they spoke.

“My daughter has three chairs,” she said. “All too low. If you put me in one of them, she'll spend half her day pulling me out.”

Venn stood beside the packing case. “I'll send this after you.”

“You'll forget.”

“I won't forget a chair.”

“You forgot the winter curtains.”

“That was six years ago.”

“They were winter curtains six years ago as well.”

Sella looked at the doorway. “It will fit if the arms come off.”

“They don't,” Mrs Venn said.

“They do. I can see the joint.”

The old woman examined her. “Can you put them back on?”

“Yes.”

“Then you may.”

Ragna stepped aside while Sella crouched to examine the pegs. They had come to discuss a statement. Now the chair had to get downstairs.

Venn's sister, Ruth, arrived with a hired cart and no patience for the stairs. She was a witch of about fifty, broad through the shoulders, with her hair escaping its pins. She kissed her mother and asked whether she had packed her medicines.

“I have packed what I take.”

“That isn't always the same thing.”

Ruth checked the packet without waiting for permission. Ragna moved towards the little shelf by the door, uncertain whether to withdraw. Mrs Venn saw her.

“You're the one who knows about the iron.”

“I know some of it.”

“Daniel tells me he put it in the wrong place.”

“He changed the destination in the record.”

“Did the people who owned it say he could?”

“No.”

Mrs Venn looked at her son. He was wrapping plates in paper, holding each one as if it might break from the pressure of his fingers.

“You let me go on thinking you were in trouble for finding it out.”

“I said I'd changed an instruction.”

“You said it very quietly.”

Ruth took the plates from him and packed them herself.

“I am going to Ruth's because the stairs are too much,” Mrs Venn said to Ragna. “And because I don't want the gentleman who asked after me coming back. I'm not going because I have agreed to anything about the iron.”

“You don't have to.”

“Good.”

Sella knocked the first peg free. The chair arm came off cleanly. Mrs Venn watched her with a professional interest that made Ragna wonder what work she had done when she could move without help.

“Don't lose the little wedge,” she said. “It's been there since my husband had it repaired.”

Sella put it into an envelope and wrote on the front. Ruth said she would keep it with the chair, and her mother said she might as well, since none of them appeared to have a better system.

They took the chair down first. The aunt from the paper shop came with them and used her wand to keep its weight clear of the narrow stair. Sella guided the exposed joint past the banister. Then Ruth brought her mother down in a plain kitchen chair, the floating seat moving so steadily that the old woman continued a complaint about the baker's habit of burning the first batch.

On the pavement, Ruth gave Venn a sheet folded around an address.

“You know it. Write it down anyway,” she said. “You'll keep too much in your head and lose something.”

“I may come in a few days.”

“Send word before you arrive. We have one back room. Mother has taken it.”

Mrs Venn reached from the cart and caught his sleeve.

“Say it so they hear you,” she told him.

He bent towards her.

“I mean what you did. Don't make them ask three times.”

When the cart had gone, he remained on the pavement. Ragna let him watch until the wheels vanished around the corner.

“She could have stayed here,” he said. “They haven't done anything.”

“You can ask her to come back,” Sella said.

He looked at her, then shook his head.

Back in the empty room, he made tea in three cups that had not been packed. He had forgotten to leave spoons. They stirred it with the end of his penknife, rinsing it between cups.

“I'll speak to the officer considering your petition,” he said.

“We haven't been given a name. Whom do you intend to speak to?”

He put his cup down. “I'll put my statement through the receiving office, under my own name. They will have to enter it.”

“They will enter it,” Ragna said. “I can't promise they'll read it.”

He sat for a moment, then took the dispatch duplicate from inside his coat. He had wrapped it in an old envelope and written a date on the outside.

“I want it copied again. With a witness who does not work for the bank.”

Sella said, “Fenn.”

“Does he read?”

“He reads.”

“Then I want him to see the original before I lodge my statement. And I agree to people being told what it says. Not my mother's address.”

“It isn't in the statement.”

“Nor which baker.”

“Nor which baker,” she said.

They met Fenn at the weigh house after noon. He had brought the receipts for the flour and fuel, and two small panes of glass wrapped in cloth. He had found a spare piece that would fit Edda's lantern. He said he had not come for thanks; he wanted her to stop carrying it past his workshop with the crack facing him.

He read the dispatch duplicate and both copies. He asked Venn to point to the altered destination. Then he asked whether the initials were his, and made him say yes in front of the others.

“If they say it was copied wrongly,” Fenn said, “I can answer that part. If they say you were told something different, that's your part.”

Venn signed a short permission for the dispatch details to be included in the renewed request. He agreed that his name could be given as its witness when the statement was lodged. He did not agree to have the paper displayed at the street door with his name on it. Ragna wrote the distinction down and read it to him.

Sella rubbed at a dried spot of tea on the table while Ragna finished.

By agreement, Venn left with his original and one witnessed copy of the statement. Fenn kept the other comparison record in his own workshop, away from the counting house.

The Ministry answer arrived in the afternoon.

It had no officer's name at the top. The signature at the bottom belonged to Harrow.

Ragna read it standing in the passage outside the counting room. The existing inquiry already covered the matters raised, it said. Separate inspection of the records would prejudice that inquiry. Witnesses could be called as required. There would be no independent hearing while the investigation into missing materials remained open.

Missing materials. Not redirected materials, not unpaid materials. She read the phrase twice.

Tavin came out to find her.

“Is that the answer?”

She gave it to him.

“It's his own inquiry.”

“Yes.”

“So we ask him if he did something wrong, and he tells us he's looking into it.”

“We asked the Ministry. The Ministry sent it to him.”

Tavin read the page again. “At least put his name at the top.”

The bank's answer waited on her desk. It was shorter and, for a moment, more useful. Issa had received the request for a reserve advance. She would examine verified balances with Halrik when he arrived. They required the wage books, withdrawal slips, supporting household records, and a list separating agreed from disputed sums. No payment was promised.

Ragna dropped into the chair. They had most of those records already.

Then she saw the third letter.

Merrok had put her on temporary suspension from duties involving certification. She was to retain no authority to approve payments or to represent provisional balances as bank accounts. Her ordinary wages would continue for three days pending review. There was no accusation she could answer, only a phrase about safeguarding confidence during an inquiry.

Tavin stood very still beside the desk.

“Does that mean you have to go?”

“It means I cannot sign for the bank.”

“You haven't been signing for the bank.”

“I have been signing things he doesn't like.”

She folded the suspension letter. The packets of wage slips sat under their stones. Her first instinct was to put them in her bag. They belonged to the bank's files, though the money described in them belonged to other people. Taking the originals would give Merrok a simple allegation to put beside the complicated ones she was making.

“Call the senior clerk,” she told Tavin.

“He'll tell Merrok.”

“Yes. He should know what we do.”

The senior clerk, Arven, came from the back office. He had worked with Ragna for eight years and had never once asked her to eat with his family. She had never asked him. Now he looked at the letter and sat down without being offered a chair.

“They should have told me first,” he said.

“I'm asking you to hold the original slips. We need certified copies for the partners.”

“I cannot certify a balance that hasn't been closed.”

“I'm asking you to certify that the copies agree with these papers. Not that the household owes the amount.”

He picked up a packet and checked the first withdrawal against the copy. It took him a long time. Ragna waited, her hands in her lap.

“What do they say is disputed?” he asked.

She showed him the separate headings.

He read through three pages. Tavin shifted his weight, then stood still again.

“I will compare them,” Arven said. “I will not give you the originals. I want that understood.”

He made them wait while he fetched his own ink. For an hour the room contained nothing but the sound of pages being turned and Arven's occasional request that somebody stop standing in the light. He signed the copies in the presence of two clerks. Ragna put them in a new wrapper labelled as copies of working records, not certified balances.

She left the original packets on the desk. The key stayed in the lock until Arven had checked the drawer and taken charge of it. Then she put her empty hand in her pocket and walked out with Tavin.

“You can stay,” she said at the door.

“I finish at four.”

“It is half past.”

“Then I can go.”

She let him hold the door for her.

At Sella's workshop, they spread the papers on the cleared table. Neri had been making a new pin for the warning bell. She put the tools away and read the suspension letter first.

“How much did you put in the fund?” she asked.

“Enough.”

“That isn't a number.”

Ragna gave her the amount. Neri looked at Sella, who shook her head once.

“The gift stays a gift,” Sella said. “But you need feeding like anyone else.”

“I have rent money.”

“Good. Don't eat it.”

She set out four bowls. Bread thickened the thin soup. Ragna sat on the rocking stool, put one boot against its short leg, and read Issa's letter aloud while the others ate.

“People should hear that,” Tavin said when she finished. “About the partners. About Harrow.”

“Bring the letters tomorrow,” Sella said. “They can hear the words.”

“Will you bring the other papers?” he asked Ragna.

“The consented copies. Not every household account.”

“If the partners have them, why not the meeting?”

“Because one household has an advance for a funeral and another has a debt to a sister they are not speaking to. Neither belongs on a wall.”

“Then leave that part off.”

“Yes. That is what we need to do.”

Neri wiped her bowl with the heel of the bread. “And put what we know about the rail in a separate statement. I don't want someone reading a sum and deciding it proves what happened to my father.”

Ragna took a clean sheet. Neri dictated what they had seen: the beam, the bolts, the empty sockets, the rope. At each place Ragna had to ask where an object stood in

relation to another. Neri fetched a pencil and corrected the drawing again. She drew the rope across the entrance and marked the place they had stood behind it.

Tavin began to speak, then shut his mouth. Ragna gave him the finished sheet.

“Could you make a fair copy of this for Neri to check?”

He read it before he answered. “Yes.”

Outside, the warning bell sounded. It had caught the edge of a deliveryman's hat. Neri pushed back her bowl and went to free him, complaining about the angle he had approached from. Sella called after her that they wanted the man to return next week, and Ragna held the new drawing still while Tavin ruled a straight line beneath the words they could each stand behind.

Chapter Nine: The Abstract

The relief fund bought bread in the morning and had nothing left for coal.

Fenn counted the coins with Ragna and Sella watching. There were three knuts after he paid the baker. He pushed them into the middle of the cloth so that nobody would have to ask whether he had overlooked one.

“People can eat together tonight,” he said. “Two fires instead of seven.”

“People are already eating together,” Sella replied.

“Then one fire.”

Vessa came in carrying a sack of kindling. “Brann split this. He says it isn't much use for the lift, so perhaps we may keep it.”

It was clean scrap from a cart repair, paid for out of his own wages the previous month. He had brought the bill in case anyone asked. Ragna wanted to laugh and could not find a way to do it without hurting him.

They decided where the kindling would go. Vessa took the list. Before she left, she said a chain tester had been sent home from Blackwater for refusing to sign the attendance report.

“Paid?” Fenn asked.

“She wasn't told.”

“Tell her to bring her tally.”

“She hasn't got it. They kept it in the office.”

Ragna closed the empty purse. Another account to reconstruct, another person asked to remember exact hours after someone else had taken the record. She wrote the woman's name on the sheet headed agreed and disputed, then left the amount blank.

The meeting began at eleven. People came from the furnaces on their meal break and stood along the back wall. Brelk had work across the river and sent a message with Edda: he could not come, but he wanted to know what happened. She brought his message on the back of a bill.

Ragna read Harrow's answer first. She read it without comments. When she reached the sentence about missing materials, Neri said, “Say that again.”

Ragna did.

“They know where some of it went,” Neri said. “They wrote it down.”

“We have a clerk's statement and a dispatch copy,” Ragna replied. “We don't have the receiving record.”

“Then ask for that, in those words.”

She wrote it beneath the request already refused.

Issa's letter came next. People listened more quietly to that one. An examination of the agreed balances, no promise of payment, two partners required to sign. Ragna described what Arven had compared and certified. She showed the outside of the wrapper without opening the household pages.

“Why isn't Arven here?” someone asked.

“He's at work.”

“So are we.”

“He signed what he had checked. He hasn't agreed to speak for the claim.”

Fenn stood. “I have. As far as the copies agree with the dispatch I saw. Beyond that, don't put words in my mouth.”

Daniel Venn sat on the bench nearest the door. His aunt had come with him, wearing a hat whose ribbon had faded purple in the sun. He had asked her to stay away. She had asked whether he intended to pay her for advice and, when he said no, had come anyway.

He stood before Ragna could call on him.

“I changed the destination on a dispatch for twenty bars,” he said. “The instruction came through Mr Harrow's office. I knew no notice had been sent to the workshop. The altered record is mine. I kept a duplicate when the other copies were called in.”

A furnace worker at the back asked, “Did you know we were paying for it?”

“I knew whose material it was. I didn't know what had been charged.”

“You could have asked.”

“Yes.”

The worker waited. Venn did not offer anything else. After a while the man folded his arms and leaned against the wall again.

Ragna asked whether Venn had lodged his statement.

“Yesterday afternoon. They accepted a signed copy. I kept the dispatch original because I was told I might be required to produce it.”

“Who accepted it?”

“The receiving clerk. I have the receipt.”

He showed it to Fenn, who read out the date and reference. No one applauded. Venn sat down with his hands between his knees. His aunt touched his sleeve once, then let him be.

Sella asked that the family's account of the delivery be read next. Neri had written it herself. Twenty bars had arrived; she and Sella had counted them; the workshop had not authorised another destination. The statement did not claim that Dorrik had understood what he signed.

“Leave his name on it,” Sella said. “It is part of what happened. But don't say he saw things we cannot ask him about.”

They agreed to add the observed state of the rail separately. The date of the observation went at the top in large writing. Neri insisted on it. She did not want yesterday's drawing turned into a picture of the night he died.

Tavin had made a short abstract from the letters and the statements. It fit on one side of a sheet. He gave it to Ragna before he stood up.

“We can't give everybody all the papers,” he said. “This says what the claims are.”

Ragna read it. At first she was relieved. The household debts were absent. It described a disputed iron charge, a redirected consignment, a suspended wage payment and the request for a hearing. It named neither Venn's mother nor the people receiving relief. It named Dorrik because Sella had agreed.

It also included the dispatch reference.

“Why put that in?” she asked.

“So they know it's a real dispatch.”

“Venn agreed to use of the facts, not public display of his name.”

“His name isn't there.”

“It can tell his office which paper we're using.”

“His office has his statement.”

Venn looked up. “It does.”

“Knowing isn't the same as seeing it on a door,” Ragna said.

Tavin pressed his palms against the table. “Everybody here has been asked for names and signatures. The people who took the book keep sending letters without names. When do we get to say what we're asking for?”

“You can say it now.”

“To the same room.”

Fenn took the abstract. He read it twice, then handed it to Sella.

“We should say it outside the room,” he said. “But it ought to be a claim, not a verdict.”

The meeting changed three sentences. “Stolen” became “charged without evidence of delivery”. Harrow's inquiry was described as refusing a separate hearing, not refusing every possible hearing. The financial advance was left out because Ilva had not yet made her statement to the partners. The abstract said further records had been requested.

Ragna asked Venn about the dispatch reference. He rubbed his chin, leaving a pale mark where his fingers pressed.

“Use the number,” he said at last. “It's the instruction I changed.”

“Not your name?”

“Not on a wall. Not yet.”

Tavin wrote the dispatch number on the fair copy. The nib caught, leaving a blot at the end of the line.

They agreed that the statement should go with the partners' request. Copies for the workshops would follow after the bank meeting the next morning. A man from the furnaces wanted them out at once. Sella argued for giving the partners a chance to examine the balances without having to speak over a crowd. Edda said the furnaces needed an answer before the next shift.

“There may not be an answer tomorrow,” Ragna said.

“Then why wait?”

Nobody had a satisfying answer. In the end the room agreed to a delay because Issa had offered something specific and Harrow had not. Ragna wrote the decision

at the bottom of the meeting sheet.

People went back to work or to the hunt for it. Sella took the food list. Fenn went with Vessa to distribute the kindling. The empty room smelled of damp coats and the cold ashes from its little stove.

Venn stayed behind while his aunt found her gloves.

“My sister sent a note,” he said to Ragna. “Mother wants the blue footstool. She says she forgot it because we all hurried her.”

“Did you?”

“Yes.”

He smiled for the first time. It barely moved his mouth.

“I can take it tonight,” he said. “Ruth doesn't live far.”

“Will you be at the bank meeting?”

“If they're taking statements.”

“They have agreed to examine wages. I don't know what else they'll hear.”

“Then I'll bring the dispatch and ask.”

He went out with his aunt. Ragna gathered the consented papers and left the room locked behind her.

The afternoon brought a small success. Arven had found the withdrawal slip that explained the doubtful advance on one of Tavin's balances. The amount was smaller than the household remembered. Ragna went with Tavin to compare it against the worker's tally. The man checked his own figures, swore, and signed a correction. He had added one week twice.

“You'd think I could remember taking money,” he said.

“I remembered entering a delivery,” Ragna replied. “We both had to look again.”

They walked back through the market. A basket seller was folding up his stall. At the far end, beside the public pump, six people stood around a sheet fastened to a post.

Ragna recognised the heading before she could read the words.

Tavin stopped beside her.

“How many?” she asked.

“Six.”

“Where?”

“Here. The two furnace gates. The carrier's yard. The lower market. Hirk took one.”

Ragna looked at him. He did not look away.

“We agreed tomorrow.”

“Edda was going to tell the shift anyway. She asked for the words. I gave them to her.”

“And the others?”

“I copied them.”

“You made a decision for everyone who waited.”

“I gave them what they agreed to say.”

“After the bank meeting.”

“They have an office, Ragna. They can change what they do before breakfast. We have a meal break and a room

people can only come to if they miss work.”

She wanted a quick answer. He was right about the meal break and the room. Her anger could do nothing with that.

“They chose the delay,” she said. “You don't get to decide their reason wasn't good enough.”

He looked towards the post. “I know.”

“Do you?”

“I know what I did.”

People were beginning to notice them. She let the apology wait.

The abstract had drawn a correction in someone else's hand: WHO WILL READ THE COPY IF THEY TAKE THIS TOO? Below it a second person had written: MAKE ANOTHER.

Ragna read Tavin's text from beginning to end. The room's words, every one of them. He had changed no fact, added no private name. She read the last line again before speaking.

“Leave this one,” she said when he reached towards it.

He lowered his hand.

“We can't call it private now. Go and tell Sella exactly where they are.”

“And you?”

“I am going to tell Venn.”

She found him at the baker's door with the blue footstool under his arm. He listened without interrupting. When

she finished, he looked down the street towards the Ministry court.

“They would know the number,” he said. “Whether there was a copy outside or not.”

“Yes.”

“Will it help?”

“I don't know.”

“Nor do I.”

He put the footstool back inside the door. “I'd better come with you.”

“We can meet tomorrow.”

“I don't want to wait in an empty house tonight.”

At the weigh house, Sella had returned to count the food receipts. Tavin stood beside her. She was not speaking to him, but she had given him figures to add. Ragna could not tell whether that was forgiveness or simply work that needed doing.

Fenn arrived soon after, carrying a copy of the abstract from the lower market. Someone had read it aloud at the furnace gate. The late shift wanted to send four people to hear the partners' answer in the morning. By the time the others heard this, two more workshops had asked the same thing.

“Not everybody in the court,” Sella said.

“Tell them,” Fenn replied. “They've waited a week.”

There was a knock at the outer door. Tavin moved to open it. Before he reached the latch, a voice called

Daniel Venn's name.

Venn stood up. His aunt was not with him now. He put a hand inside his coat, where the dispatch duplicate lay.

Pell came in with Harrow behind him. Two more wizards waited in the doorway. Harrow carried a flat black case, smaller than the one Merrok had brought with the relief money.

“Mr Venn,” he said. “You have retained an official record after being directed to surrender it.”

“I have offered it to the inquiry.”

“You will accompany us and produce it.”

Sella rose from the table. Ragna put the receipt from the receiving office beside the food list, where Harrow could see it.

“He lodged a statement. The record is available to be examined here.”

Harrow looked at the sheet fastened to the wall. It was another copy of the abstract. Someone had brought it in from the rain.

“This is not an examination room,” he said.

Outside, footsteps stopped on the stone. Ragna heard someone ask whether the meeting had started again. More people were arriving, called by the light in the windows and the sight of four wizards at the door.

Tavin stood beside the latch. He had not moved back to his seat.

Chapter Ten: The Doorway

Sella moved the food list away from Harrow's hand.

“There are names on that which have nothing to do with you.”

“I have not asked for it.”

“Then you won't need to see it.”

She folded it and put it inside her coat. Ragna saw Pell watching the movement. He had his wand out already, held low against his leg.

Venn took the dispatch from its envelope. He laid it on the table with the receiving office's receipt beside it.

“This is the original I have retained. You may examine it. I want its receipt witnessed.”

Harrow opened the black case.

“Come here,” he said.

Venn stayed where he was. “May I have the receipt?”

“You will have an acknowledgement at the office.”

“Which office?” Ragna asked.

“The inquiry office.”

“Here, or at Blackwater?”

“You are not being asked to accompany us.”

“His family will ask where he is.”

Harrow looked at her at last. The room had grown quiet enough that she heard water running from a gutter outside.

“Blackwater,” he said. “For the time being.”

“Write it down.”

Pell stepped forward. The movement brought him close to Fenn, who was still standing beside the table. Fenn backed away, caught a stool with his heel and righted himself with a hand on the weighing beam's upright.

“We are not preventing you taking a record,” he said. “We have asked for a receipt.”

“You have been given an answer,” Pell said.

At the door someone called, “What have they done?”

Tavin turned. “Stand back. There's no room.”

The younger wizard in the entrance put an arm across it. He had freckles and a wet collar. “You heard him. Keep the doorway clear.”

Ragna could see two faces over his shoulder. Edda was one. She had come with her mended lantern, its new pane catching the light from the room.

Venn picked up the dispatch and held it out. Harrow took it with two fingers, glanced at the initials and put it into the case.

“Pell. His wand.”

Venn looked at him. “I've given you the record.”

“And you have been directed to accompany us.”

“Am I being detained?”

“You are required for questioning about the retention and alteration of official material.”

“I told you I altered it. I gave the instruction reference.”

“Your wand.”

Pell held out his hand. Venn slowly unfastened the pocket inside his coat. His fingers caught on the button. He tried twice before he freed the wand and laid it in Pell's palm.

The furnace worker at the door said something Ragna did not hear. Edda replied sharply. The younger wizard raised his voice.

“Move away from the entrance.”

“We are moving,” somebody said.

But they were not. People behind were still arriving, stopping when they saw those in front. The man beside Edda turned sideways and tried to push back. His shoulder struck the door. It swung into the young wizard's arm.

“Reed,” Harrow said.

The wizard turned with his wand raised. A pale force struck the wall beside the opening. Ragna heard a crack of wood and a scream. The people nearest the doorway were thrown backwards into the crowd. The opening cleared.

Fenn let go of the upright and went towards the door.

“Don't,” Ragna said, too late.

The man who had been beside Edda stumbled into the room, one arm across his face. He collided with Fenn. The table lurched. A chair overturned. Fenn put a hand out to break his fall, and Ragna heard the short, dry sound from his wrist.

Tavin dropped beside him.

“Back,” he said to the stumbling man. “You're on his foot.”

Pell caught Venn by the arm. Sella stepped away from the table as the hanging pan swung through the place where her head had been. It struck a lamp bracket. The lamp fell, went out, and hit the floor with a hollow metal sound.

Someone outside shouted that a wand had been drawn. Another voice shouted that they were taking people. Instructions rang from the weighing pans, too loud and tangled to follow.

Ragna went to the side door. She remembered it opening into the carrier's lane, but there was a plank set across the bolts. She pulled at it. One end lifted; the other had swollen in its socket.

“Sella.”

Sella was beside her at once. She put two fingers against the iron catch and pressed. The catch warmed against Ragna's hand, shifted enough for the plank to lift. Together they dragged it away and drew the bolts.

The door opened onto rain and a wall of stacked baskets.

“Put them outside,” Ragna said to a woman who had come around the building. “Clear the door.”

She turned back. Fenn was on his knees, his right arm held against his stomach. Tavin had one hand under his left elbow and the other on the back of his coat. They moved towards the new opening a step at a time.

Behind them the man who had stumbled in grabbed Pell's sleeve.

“Let him stand,” he shouted. “There isn't room.”

Pell twisted free and struck him in the chest with a burst from his wand. The man flew backwards against the upright. This time Ragna saw the wand and the light. She saw him hit the wood. She did not see what his hand had been doing before he grabbed the sleeve.

The beam rocked. Its chain swung down towards Fenn's head.

Tavin shoved Fenn sideways and caught the pan with his shoulder. Metal struck metal. Fenn fell again, this time against the open door. Ragna reached for his coat and pulled him clear.

“Out,” she told him. “Go out.”

He could not straighten. A woman outside took his uninjured arm.

Tavin was still under the pan. Pell had turned towards him, wand level with his face.

“He's hurt,” Tavin said. “We were getting him out.”

“Stay where you are.”

Tavin looked towards Fenn. He lifted one hand, palm open, and moved to follow.

Pell made a short movement with his wand. Cord whipped around Tavin's wrists and pulled them together so sharply that he cried out.

Ragna started towards him. Harrow stepped into her path.

“He has obstructed officers carrying out their duties.”

“He helped a man who fell.”

“Stand aside.”

Pell pulled Tavin upright. One cord caught around the broken clasp of his sleeve, pinching the skin beneath. Tavin twisted his hands to ease it.

“Give me his name,” Harrow said.

“You know his name.”

“Then he may give it.”

Tavin was looking at her. He was trying to keep his face still. His mouth trembled.

“Tavin,” he said, and gave the rest of it quietly enough that Ragna could not hear over the voices outside.

Reed had come into the room. Blood ran from a cut at his hairline. He looked at Fenn through the side door, then at the man slumped beneath the upright.

“That one needs help,” he said.

“Then call it,” Harrow replied.

“Sir.”

“Now.”

The fourth wizard went out. Reed stayed beside the injured man and crouched to speak to him. Ragna saw the careful distance he kept between his hand and the man's chest. She would have to include that, too, when she told what she had seen.

Harrow took Venn by the upper arm. Venn's face was white. He had not resisted, and it seemed not to matter.

“Please tell my aunt,” he said to Ragna.

“I will.”

“Not my mother by herself.”

“I understand.”

Pell brought Tavin after him. Ragna followed to the front door. Outside, the crowd had spread into the road. Edda sat on the low wall with her lantern in pieces beside her. She was holding a cloth against her cheek. A carrier stood beside his cart, staring at the shaft of one wheel as if it had betrayed him.

Harrow ordered him to bring the cart forward.

“It's hired,” the man said.

“It will be paid for.”

Ragna almost laughed. The sound caught in her throat and hurt.

Venn climbed onto the cart without being pushed. Tavin had difficulty with the step because his hands were bound. Pell put a hand under his elbow; Tavin jerked away from him, nearly fell, and had to accept the hand on the second attempt.

Ragna went to the side of the cart.

“Look at me,” she said.

Tavin did.

“I am telling your mother where you are. We will ask to see you.”

He swallowed. “Fenn?”

“Outside. He's with Sella.”

“His hand.”

“I know.”

Harrow closed the cart's little rear gate. Pell sat beside the driver. The black case rested on Harrow's knees. Ragna looked from it to Venn and then to Tavin, trying to hold all three places in her mind.

As the cart moved, Tavin twisted to see past Harrow. Ragna walked beside it until the wheel struck a rut and splashed mud over her coat. Then the horse found its pace, and she had to stop.

The fourth wizard came back with a witch carrying a leather medical bag. They passed Ragna without speaking. She followed them into the weigh house.

A splinter from the doorframe had cut her jaw. She found it when she touched the wet place beneath her ear. The witch told her to sit down. Ragna shook her head and went through the side door to Fenn.

He was on an upturned basket with Sella beside him. His wrist had begun to swell above his cuff. He held it very carefully, his mouth open a little as if he were listening to a distant sound.

“He thinks he can mend it himself,” Sella said.

“I said the glass in the lantern,” Fenn replied. “Not my wrist.”

Edda had come around the building. She held the lantern frame, bent now at one corner, with a useless stubbornness Ragna recognised.

“Leave it,” Fenn said.

She put it on the ground at last.

The witch came to examine his hand. Ragna gave her room. Inside the building Reed was talking to the injured man, who had begun to answer. The witch asked for a clear table. Sella went to find one.

Ragna stood in the carrier's lane with the remaining papers under one arm. She could not remember picking them up. The receiving receipt was crumpled against the other papers. One corner was wet.

A woman asked her what had happened.

Ragna started to say that they had come for a record. She stopped. The woman was looking at the side door, the injured people and the broken lamp somebody had brought out into the lane.

“I saw them take Daniel Venn and Tavin,” she said. “I saw Pell bind Tavin after he helped Fenn. I didn't see the first movement at the front door clearly.”

“Somebody said a knife.”

“I saw no knife.”

“Somebody said a man hit an officer.”

“I saw a man grab Pell's sleeve.”

The woman nodded, unsatisfied. Ragna wanted a whole account to give her. She had only pieces, some of them very clear.

Reed came through the side door holding a slate. The cut at his hairline had stopped bleeding. He asked the witch for the injured man's name.

“Ask him,” she said.

“He isn't answering me.”

“Then wait.”

Reed looked at the people in the lane. Nobody offered to help him fill the silence. At last he put the slate under his arm and went back inside.

The witch told Fenn that his wrist needed further attention in her rooms. He asked how long before he could use the hand.

“I haven't finished looking at it.”

“I work glass.”

“I know what you do. At present you are making it harder for me to do what I do.”

He shut his mouth. Sella gave the witch his workshop address for the bill. When Ragna began to say the fund had no money left, Sella stopped her with a look.

“We will deal with that later,” she said.

The witch pressed a small warmed pad into Fenn's uninjured hand and told him to hold it against the bandage. He did as he was asked, staring at his own thick fingers. Ragna had seen those fingers sort coins, check dispatch copies and carry flour. She could not remember seeing them idle until now.

Neri arrived while the witch was binding Fenn's wrist. She had run from the workshop and was carrying her apron in one hand. Sella told her Orren was still with the neighbour. Neri nodded, bent to pick up Edda's lantern and put it out of the way so nobody would step on it.

“Who was taken?” she asked.

Ragna told her.

“Where?”

“Blackwater. Harrow said Blackwater.”

Neri looked at the road. The cart was long gone.

“Tell his mother,” she said.

“I will.”

“Now. Before somebody else does.”

Ragna gave her the papers. She checked that Sella had seen the handover, then went to do the thing she had promised Tavin she would do.

Chapter Eleven: The Package

Tavin's mother opened the door with a needle between her fingers.

She had been repairing a carrier's cover. It lay across the floor behind her, heavy brown canvas patched with lighter squares. Brann was helping her hold a seam straight. Vessa sat by the stove rubbing oil into her stiff left hand.

Ragna had imagined asking to speak to Hedra alone. In front of the open door, it seemed a cruel little preparation. She said, “Tavin has been taken to Blackwater.”

The needle stayed in Hedra's hand.

“Taken by whom?”

“Harrow. Pell bound his hands. He was helping Fenn after a fall.”

“Is he hurt?”

“I saw the cord catch his sleeve. I didn't see an injury beyond that. He spoke to me before the cart left.”

“What did he say?”

“He asked about Fenn.”

Hedra looked over her shoulder at the room, then back at Ragna. “Where is Fenn?”

“With a healer. His wrist is hurt.”

“Come in.”

She took the needle out of the seam and pushed it into a cork. Ragna watched the needle enter the cork. She would have known what to do with shouting.

Hedra folded the canvas away from the doorway and cleared a chair. Brann rose but remained beside the stove.

“Tell it from when he was at the meeting,” she said.

Ragna began with Venn, the original dispatch and the request for a receipt. She described where Tavin stood, the movement in the doorway, the spell against the wall. At the places she had not seen clearly, she said so. When she came to Fenn falling, Hedra put a hand on the back of the chair.

“And my son?”

“He got him away from the weighing pan. He was trying to bring him through the side door. I had Fenn by then. Tavin moved to follow, and Pell bound him.”

“What did he have in his hands?”

“Nothing.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

Hedra sat. She was still wearing the thimble on her finger. She twisted it once before taking it off.

“He put those papers up,” she said.

Ragna nodded.

“You'd told him not to?”

“We had agreed to wait until after the bank meeting.”

“And you think that is why?”

“I don't know. Harrow had Venn's statement already. The copies brought people to the room.”

“Did my son hit anyone?”

“I saw him help Fenn. I saw no blow.”

Hedra looked at Brann. He lowered his eyes.

“You weren't there,” she said to him.

“No.”

“Then don't make that face at me. I know who wasn't there.”

She stood and opened a chest beside the bed. From it she took a clean shirt, stockings and an old wool coat. The coat had been mended at the elbows in a different colour. Tavin had worn it when he first came to the counting house. Ragna remembered thinking he would have to replace it before the winter.

“Will they let us see him?” Hedra asked.

“We can ask.”

“They can say no.”

“Yes.”

She put the stockings inside the shirt and folded both into the coat. Vessa fetched paper from the shelf. Hedra wrapped the bundle, tied it with canvas thread and wrote Tavin's name on the outside.

“You're not going alone,” Brann said.

Hedra stopped tying.

“Neither are you,” Vessa told him.

No one moved towards the door. Ragna looked at the two blankets folded on the guest bed. Brann and Vessa had arrived with a chest of plates less than a week ago. If they left now to avoid being found here, Hedra would see the empty space all night.

“I'll go with her,” Ragna said. “You decide what you need to do.”

Hedra finished the knot. “They may stay. There's no rule about my beds that changes because one is empty.”

Brann sat down slowly. Vessa picked up the oilcloth and wrapped it around the package so it would not get wet on the road.

They hired a place on a carrier's cart. This time Ragna paid. The money came from what she had kept for food. Hedra held the bundle in her lap and asked only once how long the journey was.

At Blackwater the gatekeeper stood inside the closed gate with a lamp. He recognised Ragna, then looked at Hedra's package.

“We are asking to see Tavin,” Ragna said. “From the counting house. And Daniel Venn.”

“No visitors tonight.”

“Are they here?”

He glanced towards the yard office. “Yes.”

“Both?”

“Yes.”

Hedra took a breath so deep it moved the bundle on her knees.

“Give him this.”

“I can't take things in without permission.”

“Then ask.”

He held the lamp higher. It lit the gate's new latch, the one Neri had fitted. The latch knew his hand now. His thumb rested on Neri's metalwork, and Ragna wondered if he remembered who had been meant to fit it.

“Wait here,” he said.

They waited. The carrier shifted in his seat and told them he had another delivery. Ragna paid him to leave the cart and come back on his way out. Hedra did not object to the expense.

A light moved across the office window. Someone inside laughed. Hedra shifted the package on her knees.

Pell came to the gate without his coat. His shirtsleeve was stained at the cuff. He looked tired and angry about being seen tired.

“They are being questioned.”

“We want to see them,” Hedra said.

“That isn't possible tonight.”

“What has my son been told?”

“He has been told the reason for his detention.”

“Tell me.”

“Obstruction.”

“Write it on a paper. His name. The place. The reason.”

Pell looked at Ragna. “Does nobody in your counting house accept a spoken answer?”

“She doesn't work in my counting house,” Ragna said.

Hedra held the package against the bars. “Clean clothes. No metal. No tools. You may open it in front of me.”

Pell took it and turned it over. The knot was awkward; he cut it with his wand rather than untie it. Hedra made a movement with her hand, then stopped. He shook out the shirt, checked the pockets and put everything back badly.

“I'll have it delivered.”

“Sign for it.”

“You are not at a shop.”

“No. At a shop I might be able to come back tomorrow and ask the same person.”

Ragna took out a sheet she had brought. She wrote that the package contained clothes and had been accepted at Blackwater for Tavin. She left space for a signature.

Pell read it. After a while he took the pen.

He did not let them see either prisoner. He would not take a letter. He did confirm both names in writing beneath the package receipt, with the words held pending inquiry. The paper was a miserable thing to bring back instead of a son, but Hedra held it as carefully as if the journey might tear it apart.

On the return cart she said, “He'll have the coat.”

Ragna did not say yes. She said, “Pell has signed for it.”

Hedra turned the paper over in the dark. “That's what we have, then.”

At the workshop, Sella had gathered the people who needed to decide what happened next. Not another public meeting. The table held the preserved papers, a fresh lamp and four bowls of broth. Neri had taken Ragna's copied dispatch and Ilva's statement to the far shelf, away from the food. The original ledger fragment remained in Sella's cash book.

Fenn had been taken to the healer's rooms. He had sent back instructions about the fund through Vessa: keep his name on the list of trustees, but let someone else count the coins while he could not. He wanted to hear any decision that changed the use of the money. He did not want visitors before morning.

There was also a bill. Sella put it under a cup until they had eaten.

Brann stood at the workbench, reading his own statement. The signature had dried days ago. He ran a finger beside it without touching the ink.

“I don't want this copied outside,” he said.

“It hasn't been,” Ragna replied.

“It went with the petition.”

“Yes. We cannot take that copy back.”

“I know. I want you to know I'm not agreeing to more.”

Sella nodded. “You don't have to.”

“I still found him. I'm not saying I didn't.”

“No one here has asked you to change it.”

He folded the sheet along its old crease. Vessa stood beside him but did not speak for him. Ragna wanted to tell him that more witnesses would make them safer. She could not prove that, and Tavin was at Blackwater.

Neri said, “Use mine. The one about what we saw.”

“It's your account,” Sella said. “Ragna saw it too.”

“Yes. I want it used.”

“With the date of observation,” Ragna added.

Neri looked at her. “I put it there.”

Ragna gave Sella the clean copy to read once more.

A carrier's wife came to ask whether the fund would pay for the man struck against the upright. His name was Dask. He had been taken home after the healer saw him, and his wife had gone to look for someone who knew why he had entered the weigh house.

“He says he saw a stool thrown,” she told Ragna.

“Before the first spell?”

“He isn't sure.”

“I saw a stool fall. I couldn't see the whole doorway.”

“He won't say it was the wizards if he doesn't know.”

“He shouldn't.”

The woman looked at her, surprised. She had come prepared to argue. She put the cloth she was carrying on the table and untied it. Inside were Dask's broken spectacles. One lens had gone; the wire at the bridge had been twisted flat.

“He earns by checking loads. He can't read a label without these.”

Sella fetched an empty envelope and slid the pieces into it. She wrote Fenn's workshop on the front, then crossed it out.

“There is another glassworker in the upper market,” she said. “We can ask.”

“What about the healer?”

Ragna opened the fund purse and showed the three coins. The woman looked at them without reaching for any.

“We haven't agreed what we can do about bills,” Ragna said. “There is no money for them now. Give us a copy. Keep the original.”

The woman put her hands in her lap. “I thought there would be money because you had a meeting.”

“So did some of us,” Sella said.

They gave her a bowl of broth and a place by the stove. She would not agree to Dask's name being added to another petition without asking him. Ragna put the account under private requests and wrote no public circulation across the top.

The stationer arrived after dark. She had closed her shop early and come without her hat. Ragna told her what Venn had said from the cart, then showed her the receipt confirming where he was held.

“I have sent word to Ruth,” she said. “I told her to speak to her mother herself. Neither of them is coming here

tonight.”

Ragna nodded. “I'm glad they heard it from you.”

The stationer rubbed a hand over her forehead. “They'll have questions I can't answer.”

She sat beside Sella and asked to see the copy Venn had signed. Ragna laid it in front of her. The woman checked his signature, then put a small square of clean paper over the address on her own shop bill.

“Use the paper,” she said. “Don't send people to my counter to ask where my sister lives.”

They stayed long enough to agree three things. The record copies would be kept in more than one place. No additional private names would go into a public statement without permission. The partners would be asked to examine the wage evidence in a workshop, where the people whose earnings were involved could answer questions.

“Not in the court,” Sella said. “If people gather there after tonight, they will bring wands again.”

Ilva arrived as they were separating the bundles. She saw the empty chair where Tavin had sat and did not ask the question Ragna had expected.

“Is he at Blackwater?”

“Pell has confirmed it.”

Ilva put a hand on the back of the chair. “Merrok has told the partners there was violence at an unlawful gathering.”

“He wasn't there,” Neri said. “Tell them what we saw.”

Ilva looked at the piles of paper. “Issa still intends to examine the balances. Halrik arrived this evening.”

“Here,” Sella said. “If they want to ask whether I received money, they may come to the table where I counted it.”

“I can ask.”

“Ask.”

Ilva stood a moment longer, then took the request. She left the chair untouched when she went out.

Ragna helped Sella put the tools back on the bench. She had to move Tavin's fair copy of Neri's statement first. He had ruled the bottom line with such care that the paper held a faint dent beneath the ink. Ragna placed it inside the wrapper without smoothing the dent away.

Chapter Twelve: The Agreed Balance

Ragna read the first name twice and still said it wrong.

“Tesh,” Sella corrected. “Not Tersh.”

Ragna put a finger under the letters. For years the rope-maker had brought little coils to twist while he waited at the counting house. She had entered his name hundreds of times.

“Give me the other frame,” she said.

Neither the frame nor her lenses had changed. She had slept for an hour in Sella's chair, with her coat over her knees, and woken when Orren came in asking whether everyone was going to stay for breakfast.

Neri fetched the frame anyway. Ragna put it beside the first and did not use it.

Issa arrived at nine with Halrik and a bank clerk carrying a locked cash case. They had agreed to the workshop because Sella's supporting books were there, Fenn could not come to the bank house, and Ragna had put both reasons in writing. The clerk waited for a place to set the case. Neri cleared a tray of hinges.

Issa took off her gloves. She was a small goblin with a broad forehead and a habit of reading the signature on a page before she read its contents. Halrik was younger and wore the plain coat of someone who expected it to be damaged. He checked the leg of the rocking stool before sitting, then put a folded scrap of leather beneath it.

The letterhead they brought said THE WORKS BANK. Ragna had spent eleven years beneath the same name. The bank held the pooled reserves of the district's workshops and settled many of their metal purchases through its London accounts. Merrok managed those accounts. It had never made the deposited money his.

Issa laid out the terms of the examination.

“We can authorise advances with two reserve signatures. We will not certify a balance because a room wants us to. We will not wait for the iron inquiry before looking at wages that have nothing to do with it.”

“There are also wages that do,” Sella said.

“Then we look at what is disputed and what is not.”

Ragna opened the first packet. Tavin had put red thread around it. She untied the knot carefully, keeping the little loop intact.

They began with Tesh's rope workshop. His day tallies agreed with the wage book. Two withdrawals had matching signatures. A third had been entered twice in the household copy and once in the bank slip; he had already signed the correction. No disputed metal charge touched that account.

Halrik asked who had compared the bank slips.

“Arven,” Ragna said.

“Where are the originals?”

“At the counting house. In his custody.”

“And these?”

“Working copies, compared and signed in front of two clerks.”

Halrik sent the bank clerk to ask Arven to bring the originals. Ragna pressed her palms against the table.

“He signed them.”

“Yes,” Halrik said. “I want to see what he signed them against.”

She looked at the copy. Three days earlier she would have asked the same question. She put it down and let the clerk go.

Hedra came at half past nine. She had made no repair to the carrier's cover since Ragna left her the night before. She held the package receipt in a pocket and touched it when she sat down.

“Any word?” Ragna asked.

“No.”

“I haven't had any either.”

“Then don't stand up every time the door opens.”

Ragna sat. She had not known she was doing it.

Fenn came in a hired chair carried by two of the fitters, complaining that his legs worked. The healer had told him to keep the hand still and avoid jarring it. Sella gave the men money from the household purse, not the relief fund. Fenn saw it and began to object.

“Later,” she said.

His right wrist lay in a rigid support beneath his coat. He could not get his left sleeve off without help. Neri

helped and said nothing about how carefully he had once checked a pane of glass for her.

Issa asked whether he needed to be there.

“Yes,” he said.

She moved the papers so he could read without leaning on the injured arm.

Arven arrived with the bank clerk and the original slips. He had put on his better coat. It made him look as if he expected to be accused of something requiring respectability.

The examination took the rest of the morning. Receipts agreed with tallies; names appeared where they should. Payments remembered but never written down went in the disputed column. Issa would not let Ragna treat memory as proof simply because she liked the person remembering. She also would not let Halrik treat an unsigned scrap as worthless when three independent books recorded the same payment.

At noon they had three balances they were willing to stand behind: Tesh's household, Fenn's workshop earnings, and Edda's furnace share. Edda's previous conditional payment had to be credited. She brought its receipt, angry at the sight of it but determined not to be paid twice for the same days.

“What about my aunt?” she asked.

“The registered allowance is not part of the wages we are examining,” Issa said. “I will look at that decision separately.”

“Today?”

“I cannot promise today.”

Edda sat back. She did not thank her for a promise she had not made.

Sella's account remained open. The school payment had reached her directly after the quarter closed; it did not settle what the bank already owed. Her household books supported the work and the withdrawals. The material deductions were still tied to the seized ledger.

“Pay what cannot be disputed,” she said.

Halrik drew her wage total towards him and wrote the price of forty bars beneath it. “If we set the second charge aside entirely, the first signed charge still leaves no positive balance on the figures we have verified.”

“Twenty bars reached me, not forty.”

“I have your stock book and the dispatch copy. The note your husband signed records a release, and the receiving record for the other load is missing. I am not prepared to decide where that load went on a copy alone.”

Sella took the pencil from him. She crossed out his forty and wrote twenty. Under that figure there was money to pay. She left the paper between them.

Halrik looked at the authority for the separate forty-bar purchase. “This may concern money moved from the reserve. It does not by itself show which household entry received the debit.”

“Ilva has signed that she checked it,” Ragna replied.

“We need to hear her.”

“She has been asked to come.”

“And the supplier's voucher?”

“Requested.”

He put the authority back. “Then this part is not finished.”

Sella's hand closed on the table edge. She let go before anyone asked her to.

Issa turned to the three agreed balances. The advances would cover the verified net earnings, less withdrawals and conditional relief already received. Gifts from the fund would not be deducted. Each receipt reserved every disputed claim against the bank and the Ministry.

Ragna read that sentence aloud. Edda made her read it again.

“The cash comes from the partners' working reserve,” Issa added. “Not from a fresh charge against another workshop. These three advances will be entered separately, with these receipts attached. Any further recovery is the bank's business. Nobody here is being paid to abandon a claim.”

Both partners signed. The bank clerk opened the cash case.

Tesh counted his money, then gave the clerk one coin back.

“One too many,” he said.

The clerk checked, reddened and corrected the count. Tesh put the rest into his coat and went to pay the people waiting at his workshop. He did not stay to hear

what happened to anyone else's balance.

Edda took the amount remaining after her earlier payment. It was not enough to remedy the excluded allowance, but it was hers. She wrapped it in a cloth and tucked it inside the repaired lantern frame, which she had brought without the broken glass. Fenn could not sign with his right hand. He made a mark with his left, had it witnessed, and asked Sella to count the coins again before she put them in his purse.

He would have trusted his own fingers yesterday. Today he watched hers.

Hedra stayed in her chair. Her son's release was not among the things the cash case could provide.

Merrok arrived as the last receipt was being signed.

He stood in the doorway until Issa looked up. Behind him was Ilva, carrying her control book against her chest.

“I would have attended,” he said, “if I had known payments were to be made.”

“You knew an examination was offered,” Issa replied.

“An examination is not an instruction to advance cash on uncertified accounts.”

“Then you will be relieved that we examined them first.”

He did not take the chair Neri set out. He looked at the three receipts and at Fenn's supported wrist.

“I have lodged my concern about the violence surrounding these claims.”

“They are wages,” Fenn said. “My wrist hasn't changed which days I worked.”

“The bank must consider the circumstances.”

“Consider them after you've counted.”

Ragna watched Issa. The partner had put her gloves beside the signed instructions. She did not move them.

Merrok turned towards Ilva.

“The control book is bank property. It should be in the examiner's file.”

Ilva went past him to the table. “I have brought it for examination.”

“By whom?”

“Two reserve partners.”

She set it in front of Issa. For a moment her hand remained on the cover. Then she lifted it away.

The room had become very quiet. Even Orren, working on his rivets at the far bench, had stopped making small metal sounds.

Issa read the advance entry and the transfer. She looked at Ilva's tick, then at the copy Ragna held.

“You certified this?”

“Yes.”

“You will make a full account of what you certified and the instruction under which you did it.”

“I have made one.”

“I want it to the partners.”

Ilva took the folded statement from her case. Her fingers shook enough that she had to place the sheet flat before pushing it across.

Merrok said, “We should discuss this in the bank house.”

“The figures are here,” Issa replied.

“So are people without any duty of confidence towards the bank.”

Sella looked at the control book. “I seem to have contributed money without being trusted to see where it went.”

Halrik put a clean sheet over the unrelated entries. “The other accounts remain private. This one will be examined.”

Merrok sat at last. He had given up trying to stop the room and would now try to make a different use of it.

“The advance was made to secure a Ministry undertaking,” he said. “A temporary arrangement. It was never intended as a permanent charge on the contributing workshops.”

“Yet their balances were closed against it,” Issa said.

“They were not closed.”

“Their wages were stopped.”

“The record was seized.”

“With your signature,” Ragna said.

He looked at her. “After an order I could not refuse.”

“You signed before you asked us for totals.”

“Because I was trying to protect the rest of the bank.”

Hedra rose so abruptly that everyone turned.

“I'm going to ask at Blackwater again,” she said. “Anyone who wants to protect something may finish before I come back.”

Vessa went with her. Sella found food to put in the bag. For a minute all the elaborate accounts had to wait while Hedra checked that it was something Tavin would eat.

When they had gone, Merrok asked to speak to Ragna in the passage. She looked at Sella, who said, “We'll be here.”

Outside he stood well away from the door.

“I can have the disputed balance examined separately,” he said. “And your suspension reconsidered. You know the books. The bank still needs someone who knows them.”

“Then let me finish with the partners.”

“There is a simpler account. A temporary posting was carried forward when it should have been reversed. An examiner misunderstood an instruction. The loss can be remedied.”

“And the iron that never arrived?”

“Another account.”

“And Dorrik?”

“I did not put him at the shaft.”

“No. But you are asking me to stop where your responsibility stops.”

“I am asking you to help secure a payment. You have seen how slowly this proceeds when every correction becomes an accusation.”

Through the door came the scrape of Issa's pen. Ragna could smell the onions Sella had put in the soup. She wanted to sit down, to be told how much would be paid and when, to go back to an office where she could finish a task without somebody being taken away for it.

“Put the offer in writing,” she said.

“You know what I mean.” His voice had lost its force.

“Yes. Put it in writing.”

He left her in the passage.

Inside, Issa had taken custody of the control book for the partners' examination and given Ilva a signed receipt. Halrik was copying the procurement reference. Neither had authorised the disputed iron balance. Both had agreed that the Ministry advance required a separate accounting to the contributing workshops.

Ragna sat beside Sella. In the advance authority the supplier's name stood above the purchase reference. It had been there every time she read the paper. The bank held one bill, but the supplier would have kept another.

She wrote the name on a clean sheet and asked Neri where the road to the foundry left the river.

Chapter Thirteen: The Maker's Mark

Marian Lorne brought paper before breakfast.

Venn's aunt had wrapped it in a shop invoice with the price crossed out. She put it on Sella's bench and asked whether anyone had news of her nephew. Ragna had none. Hedra's second visit had produced a promise to pass on the food and no conversation with either prisoner.

Marian looked at the paper she had brought. “He used to spoil sheets learning his capitals. Now I should like to know if they'll let him have one.”

“You can ask for writing materials with the next package,” Sella said.

“I will.”

She stayed to drink tea standing by the door. The cups were all in use. Orren offered her his, and she told him to finish first. He drank so fast that Sella took it away before he could scald himself.

Issa's letter to the supplier was six lines long. It confirmed the purchase reference, identified Ragna as someone authorised to obtain a copy for the reserve examination, and asked for the supplier's own record of the sale and payment. It restored none of Ragna's old duties. She read it twice anyway, then put it with the advance authority.

Neri carried an empty tool roll. If the foundry had repair work, she meant to ask for it.

“Have you slept?” Sella asked Ragna.

“Yes.”

“Long enough to read a name?”

“Long enough.”

Sella let it pass. She packed bread, a piece of cheese and two apples. Neri took the bag and put the softer apple on top.

Mere Foundry lay upriver, where the water narrowed between wooded banks. They went on foot to save the carrier's fare. Neri knew these Derbyshire lanes from fitting jobs with her father. She took the shorter path past a ruined kiln, then stopped at a new barrier across the track.

Two wizards were checking a charcoal cart. The driver, a goblin in a wide-brimmed hat, had tipped out a sack at their feet. Charcoal dust blew into the hedge.

“It's fuel,” he said. “I've told you. We burn it.”

“You require a stores permit for bulk supplies.”

“Bulk metal. Read the notice.”

The younger wizard read it. He touched the older one's sleeve and pointed to a line. The older man shook him off, then looked at the spilled charcoal again.

“Reload it.”

“Will you hold the sack?”

“Reload it and move on.”

Neri set her bag down. She helped the driver scoop the charcoal from the road. Ragna held the mouth of the

sack while he brushed in the last pieces with his hat.

“What is this for?” she asked the younger wizard.

“Movement of restricted stores. After the trouble in the north.”

“What trouble?”

He looked at his companion, then at the two women. “You may proceed on foot.”

The driver tied his sack shut, leaving charcoal in the ditch and an hour of his morning on the road. When Neri offered to help lift it, he said, “No, no. My back's not gone yet,” with a smile that failed halfway across his face.

They went around the cart. Beyond the barrier a notice required carriers of iron to declare their destination and customer before entering the works district. The empty space for a countersignature had been filled by Harrow's office.

Neri waited until they were out of earshot. “He'll put that hour on the delivery bill.”

“He has to eat it somewhere,” Ragna said.

“So do we.”

The road rose above the river, then dipped into the smell of charcoal. Ragna could hear the foundry before she could see it: the steady beat of a hammer and the higher, irregular sound of someone teaching another person to strike in time.

The yard was open to the road. A woman stood on a platform beside a furnace, arguing with a goblin below

about the shape of a mould. They both looked up when Neri called.

“Office,” the woman said, pointing with her hammer. “If you want the office, it's there.”

“We need the owner.”

“You've found her. Do you want her to put this down?”

Neri looked at the hot metal waiting in the mould.

“No.”

They waited by a stack of empty frames. The woman and the goblin finished the pour without another word. He moved a lever with both hands; she watched the flow. When the metal settled, he stepped back and made a little bow so mocking that the woman laughed.

Joan Mere washed her hands at the trough before she took Issa's letter.

“What have they done now?” she asked.

Ragna described the separate forty-bar purchase and the missing voucher. She kept the household's other debts out of it.

Mere read the letter again. “They have my receipt. Why don't they show you that?”

“It has been requested. We haven't received it.”

“Have they been paid?” Neri asked.

“The bars? Yes.”

“By whom?”

Mere looked at her. “Who are you?”

Neri gave the workshop name and her own. She did not mention Dorrik until Mere asked whether the older fitter was still doing the gates.

“He's dead.”

Mere lowered the letter. Behind her the hammer kept its slow beat.

“When?”

Neri told her.

“At Blackwater?”

“Yes.”

Mere folded the letter along its crease. “Come in.”

Her office was a room above the store shed. A window looked over the yard, and every impact below came through the floor. The desk held a balance, a bowl of bent nails and three account books bound in different colours. There was a wand in a clay pot beside two quills. Mere used the quill first.

“I will show you this purchase,” she said. “I won't show you my other customers or their prices. Whatever the partners think of one another, they are not getting my trading book copied into their quarrel.”

“That is all we asked.”

“People often ask for one thing and take a look at another while the book is open.”

She put two blank sheets over the adjoining pages before she turned the book towards them.

The invoice was for forty bars. It carried the reference Venn had given and the name of the Works Bank as paying agent. The intended recipient was described as Ministry security stores, via Blackwater lift. Beneath the total was Mere's receipt of payment, dated before the consignment left.

“Cash?” Ragna asked.

“Bank payment order, settled in full. That is the settlement entry.”

“Do you retain the order?”

“The paid one went with the receipt. I keep the counter-entry and the order reference. You can ask the settling office to match them.”

Ragna copied the references with the amount, pausing for Mere to check each one.

“This shows you were paid by the bank,” Ragna said. “It doesn't show which reserve the bank charged.”

“No. That is their account, not mine.”

“And the bars went to Blackwater?”

Mere turned to the dispatch page. “Forty. Weighed here, loaded here. Accepted there.”

The receipt at Blackwater carried a name Ragna did not know: Kelm. Neri leaned over the page.

“The loading foreman,” she said. “He came to see the gate fittings with my father.”

Mere called out of the window. The goblin who had worked the mould looked up. She asked him to come upstairs.

While they waited, Ragna compared the advance authority with the supplier's entry. The purchase, quantity, price and payment reference agreed. The supplier had received the bank's money and sent the bars; that much no longer depended on Ilva's word.

What she could not see was where those bars had gone after the lift.

The goblin came in wiping his hands on a rag. Mere introduced him as Hask, who supervised the bar stock. He examined the dispatch page, then nodded.

“I counted them out.”

“Can you identify them?” Ragna asked.

“If you haven't melted them.”

“What mark?”

He took a small offcut from the shelf. At one end a circle enclosed an M. Beside it were a number and two short cuts crossing at an angle.

“The M is the foundry. The rest is the batch. Don't go looking for any M you fancy and call it this sale.”

Neri took the offcut and turned it in the light. The number was shallow but clean.

“Every bar?”

“Every full bar. On this lot. I was paid to mark it and count it twice.”

“Who asked?”

“The order. Security stock. They wanted to know if somebody changed the iron.”

Ragna copied the exact mark. Hask corrected the angle of one cut. She asked whether the mark could be forged.

“Anything can be copied by somebody who takes enough trouble,” he said. “You'd need to look at the bar, not worship the stamp.”

Neri smiled slightly. It was the first time she had looked at ease since the road.

Mere made a copy of the invoice and the payment entry, covering the other accounts herself. She signed it, and Hask signed a statement identifying the stock he had counted. She would not let Ragna remove the original page.

“I have been paid,” she said. “I still need to prove that if somebody decides I haven't.”

“Will you show it to the partners?”

“If they come here. Or if they pay someone to stand over this yard while I leave it.”

Ragna wrote the condition beside the attestation.

Neri asked about the last part of the journey.

“Did your cart go on from Blackwater?”

“One did,” Mere said. “To Thorn. The load was transferred, but they wanted our narrow cart for the depot passage. They sent an undertaking to return it. I'm still waiting.”

“Your driver?”

“Borr. He came back on the carrier's wagon. They wouldn't let him wait.”

“Did he see the bars arrive?”

“He saw them taken through the gate. He did not count them inside.”

“Can we ask him?”

Mere looked towards the window. “He's gone downriver with another load. He'll be back when he is back.”

Another witness out of reach, another trip. Ragna nearly asked why he hadn't waited, then remembered he had work to do.

“Could you ask him to write what he saw when he returns?”

“I can ask. He may not want his name in it.”

“Then let him decide.”

Mere opened a drawer. “I have permission to collect the cart tomorrow. I was going to send Hask. They say its brake is damaged.”

Neri looked at the sheet she drew out. “Then he should take a fitter.”

Hask stared at her. “You haven't seen the brake.”

“No. Have you?”

“No.”

“Then neither of us knows what we'll need.”

Mere read the collection authority again. It admitted two persons to collect one vehicle from the outer stores. No weapons, no removal of any Ministry material, attendance to be recorded at the gate.

Ragna saw the place name and the thought arrived whole, unpleasantly tempting. A receiving office. A cart. Somewhere beyond it, the record they were not being allowed to inspect.

“We need to see Thorn's receipt,” she said.

“They won't hand you the books with the cart.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Mere put down the authority and looked at her until Ragna felt the lack of sleep behind her eyes.

“This is a foundry, not a cause. People eat because I sell what we make. If you use my cart to carry out Ministry stock, they will close the road to my buyers.”

“We are trying to find a receiving record.”

“Which is Ministry property as well.”

Ragna could not answer that by changing the noun.

Neri set the offcut on the desk. “We can fix the brake. We can look at where the cart is and ask for the record. We won't promise to see nothing. We won't pretend we have permission to take something.”

“And when they say no?”

“We decide what to do then,” Neri said.

Mere leaned back. “You make it sound so easy.”

“It doesn't sound easy to me.”

Hask picked up the collection authority. “The brake wants doing whether they go or I go.”

Mere let out a breath through her nose. She crossed out his name, wrote Neri's and left the second space blank.

“Who else?”

Ragna looked at Neri. The work, the record, her father: she could not tell which had brought Neri this far.

“Me,” Ragna said.

Mere wrote her name.

“You collect the cart. If the brake is beyond repair, you send a message. You do not pledge my foundry, my workers or my family to anything else.”

They agreed. She signed the amended names and gave them a note confirming Neri was engaged to assess the brake. The payment for the job would be small and hers to keep, whether or not the inquiry learned anything from it.

They ate the bread and cheese on the riverbank before walking home. Neri cut her apple with the small knife from her tool roll. Ragna's had softened on one side. She ate the other half and wrapped the rest for later.

“Did you want to say yes before she asked?” Neri said.

“Yes.”

“So did I.”

A boat moved slowly upriver, the man at its stern working against the current. On the bank opposite, two boys were dragging a branch out of the water. Ragna watched them until the branch came free and they both fell backwards, laughing.

“We should tell your mother,” she said.

“I'm going to.”

“I meant what we may be choosing. Not just the repair.”

Neri wiped the knife and folded it away. “So did I.”

Ragna put the supplier's attested copy between two dry boards in her bag. Beneath it lay the collection authority for Thorn, the two new names still darker than the rest of the ink.

Chapter Fourteen: The Outer Stores

Neri counted her tools at the gate of Thorn.

She laid them on the board the guard provided: two hammers, three small files, a rule, pliers, a punch, spare pins and a folding knife. He wrote each down. When she pointed out that he had counted the pliers as two things, he told her to put everything away.

Ragna gave him the collection authority. The guard checked their names against the amendments on his own sheet. Mere had sent confirmation with the morning carrier. Without it, he said, they would have been turned back.

The supplier's attested invoice was at Sella's workshop, not in Ragna's bag. Ilva's statement and the advance copies were there as well. Ragna carried only the authority, a few blank sheets and food enough to avoid having to ask the depot for it.

“What work do you do?” the guard asked.

“Accounts.”

“Bank?”

“I am here to help collect a cart.”

He looked at her for another moment, then wrote clerk beside her name.

Thorn had been a mill before the Ministry took its lease. The wheel was gone, but the cut that had fed it still ran beside the lower wall. A brick office stood to the right of

the main gate. Beyond it, the yard sloped down to a long vehicle shed and a pair of storehouses. A covered loading lane ran between the buildings towards a lower gate at the river. Ragna could see the towpath through its bars.

Two ways out, with open ground between them. Since the weigh house, Ragna looked for doors before chairs.

A porter led them to the vehicle shed. He wore a Ministry badge over a patched jersey and carried a ring of keys that struck his thigh as he walked.

“Mr Dole wants the receipt signed before you move it.”

“What receipt?” Neri asked.

“Vehicle returned as held.”

“Let me see the vehicle.”

He stopped, looked back and said, “That's where we're going.”

“Then good.”

He gave her a puzzled glance, then led them on.

The narrow cart stood beneath the shed's open side. Its shafts rested on a block. One wheel had been chocked with a piece of stone, and the brake lever was tied back with wire. Mere's initials had been painted on the rear crosspiece in fading white.

Neri put down her sack and went to the wheel. She crouched, felt the bracket and worked the lever carefully. It moved halfway and stopped.

“Somebody forced it with the brake on.”

The porter scratched his chin. “They said it came in like that.”

“It couldn't have come down this slope like that.”

“I wasn't here when it came.”

“Then you needn't sign that it did.”

She took out her knife and cut the wire. The lever dropped. The bracket remained crooked against the wheel rim.

Ragna stood at the back of the cart. Across the yard a storehouse door was open. Inside, several bundles of iron rested on low racks. One bundle had been unstrapped. The ends of the bars were turned towards the light.

She could see an M in a circle on the nearest one. She could not make out the batch number.

“Don't wander,” the porter said.

“I haven't.”

He followed her gaze to the bars, then went to fetch Mr Dole.

Neri tapped the bracket with her small hammer, listened, and put the hammer down.

“The pin is bent as well. I can do it. I need a little heat for the bracket, not enough to spoil it.”

“Will they allow it?”

“They asked for a fitter. Now they'll find out what one does.”

Mr Dole arrived carrying the receipt book. He was a wizard with a thick neck, ink on his smallest finger and a manner that suggested every minute spent away from the office would have to be made up later.

Neri showed him the brake. He did not pretend to understand it. He asked what she needed and how long she meant to take.

“An hour if nothing else has been damaged.”

“What else could be?”

“I'll tell you if I find it.”

He looked at the receipt. “You sign that the vehicle has been returned.”

“When it moves.”

“And the condition?”

“I'll write the condition I see. I won't write when it happened.”

Ragna expected an argument. Dole shrugged.

“Fine. Write it in the margin. I'm not putting a paragraph in the heading.”

He sent the porter for a brazier and a worker to tend it. Then he held the receipt book for Ragna to see.

The cart was listed against a consignment reference. It was the forty-bar order. In the column beside it, cargo received was marked complete.

“May I copy the reference?”

“You've brought a copy of it.”

“The reference on your return book.”

He sighed and turned the book so she could read. She copied the date and the whole string of numbers, including the final letter.

“Who received the cargo?”

“That is not the vehicle return.”

“I am authorised by the bank to obtain the supplier's record of the purchase.”

“Then go to the supplier.”

“We have. We need the depot receipt.”

Dole closed the book. “You have authority to collect a cart. If you want something else, write to the office.”

She had already written. She did not tell him again. Across the yard the storehouse worker lifted a cloth over the open bundle of bars. The M disappeared beneath it.

“Can we have the copy of this return receipt when we leave?” she asked.

“Yes. When you leave.”

The worker brought a small brazier on a trolley. He was a goblin, heavy through the shoulders, with grey hair cropped close to his scalp. He pushed the trolley slowly because one wheel dragged. The porter told him where to put it and went back towards the gate.

Neri had the brake pin in her hand. She looked up at the worker and stopped moving.

“Kelm?”

The man lowered his head. “Keep on with it.”

“What are you doing here?”

“I said keep on.”

Ragna went to the cart's other side. From there she could see Dole return to the office. The guard at the main gate was examining another delivery. The porter had stopped to talk to a driver by the river lane.

“Kelm signed the Blackwater receipt,” Neri said quietly.

The man put his hands over the brazier, though it was not yet hot. The skin across one knuckle had split.

“I signed a receipt for forty bars at Blackwater. That's all it said.”

“We know,” Ragna replied.

“No, you don't.”

His voice rose enough that all three looked towards the office. Nobody came out.

Neri turned the bent pin in her pliers. “My father came to ask about the other load.”

Kelm stared into the unlit brazier.

“I know who your father was.”

“I know you do.”

Ragna took the kindling from the trolley and began laying it in the brazier. She needed something to do that did not look like standing over him. Neri had brought a little packet of fire chips from the workshop. She set one under the wood and touched it until a low flame took hold.

For a while the only sound was Kelm breathing and the first crackle of the fire.

“Are you employed here?” Ragna asked.

“No.”

“Can you leave?”

He looked at her then. His eyes were bloodshot, and there was a line of dirt in the crease below his lower lip.

“They say when the loading account is settled. They say I'm assisting the inquiry. They have my works pass and the departure chit for the cart.”

“Have you asked to go?”

“Three times.”

“What was the answer?”

“Dole says Harrow will tell him when I'm finished. Harrow says I ought to remember how the rail looked.”

Neri set down the pliers.

Ragna looked towards the porter. He was still talking. She asked, “What do you remember?”

Kelm shook his head. “Not here.”

“Then don't say it here.”

He looked surprised. She kept her hands busy with the bracket.

She took the bracket from Neri and held it above the low heat while Neri checked the wheel. The cart had been dragged with the brake applied. A strip of the rim had been scored, but the axle turned cleanly. Neri could make it safe to move, though Mere would need to decide how much further work was worth paying for.

Kelm held the brazier steady. He could have walked away and left them with it. Instead he waited until Neri needed a second pair of pliers and fetched one from the trolley.

In the lower lane a gate opened. Two carts carrying covered crates came through towards the road. A wizard checked each driver's paper at the top of the slope. Behind them, through the bars at the river, a man led a horse along the towpath. The depot gate stayed open while a porter rolled an empty barrel inside.

Ragna watched until it shut. A means of moving things. Not an easy way out.

Kelm said, “They bring the coal through there. It's wider than the mill door.”

“Do they lock it at night?”

“Yes. And the shed.”

“The shed?”

He kept his eyes on the brazier. “I sleep in the back. I'm not chained. They are careful to tell me that.”

Neri's pliers slipped. The bracket struck the cart with a sharp knock. She swore and picked it up. Her face had changed.

“Leave it another minute,” Kelm said. “You don't want to bend it cold.”

“I know.”

“I know you know. Your father told me you were better with that work.”

Neri stared at him. For a moment Ragna thought she would ask the question none of them could safely answer here. Instead she put the bracket back over the heat.

Dole came out to ask how long they would be. Neri showed him the damaged pin and said it would need replacing. She had a spare of the right size; she wanted the replacement noted on the return receipt.

Dole looked annoyed but wrote it in the margin.

“Don't leave that brazier unattended,” he told Kelm.

“No.”

“And no talk about the inquiry.”

Kelm looked down. Neri looked up.

“He was telling me how the brake had been used,” she said.

“Then he can tell me.”

Dole held her gaze for a moment, then went back to his office. Ragna could feel the hour closing around them.

Kelm waited until the office door shut.

“I have a counterfoil,” he said.

Ragna kept her hands on the cart. “For what?”

“The forty. Received here. They gave me the carrier's part to return with the vehicle. Then the vehicle wasn't released and neither was I.”

“Where is it?”

“In my jacket. They took the pass, not the jacket. It's not a secret weapon. It's a receipt.”

He gave a short, ugly laugh.

“Does it show the earlier twenty?”

“No. Why would it? Different load. I saw that entry in the receiving book when they were settling mine. I don't have it.”

“Can you tell us who signed?”

“Dole signed mine. Someone else signed the twenty. There's a name in the book. I didn't read it for you.”

“I understand.”

“I'm not sure you do.”

He took the warmed bracket from Neri and laid it on the block so she could work it. She struck twice, tested the fit, then struck again. The metal settled into place.

A bell sounded from the office. The porter came to take the brazier's spare fuel back to the store. He put a heel of bread beside Kelm's hand without looking at him.

“Dinner,” he said.

“It's not dinner.”

“It's what there is.”

The porter went away. Kelm broke the bread and put half in his pocket. Neri watched the movement, then looked down at their own bag beneath the cart. She pushed it towards him with her foot.

He shook his head.

“It's only cheese,” she said. “You needn't owe us for it.”

He took the bag. Ragna looked away while he ate. Near the office, a clerk stretched and yawned in the sun. The

porter had brought bread. The clerk had a stiff back. Neither would have to do anything more for Kelm to sleep behind the locked shed door again that night.

“I don't want to stay here,” Kelm said.

Neri stopped with the hammer raised. She lowered it to the ground.

Ragna looked at the main gate, the guard, the covered lane down to the river. They had come as two named people. There would be three if Kelm left with them. Their authority would not explain him or make the guard forget he had seen him all week.

“Do you want us to ask again?” she said.

“I want to leave.”

He said it as quietly as before.

Neri picked up the bracket, put it against the wheel and looked at Ragna across the body of the cart.

Chapter Fifteen: The Lower Gate

Ragna put the repaired pin through the brake arm and waited for Neri to secure it.

“Can it move?” she asked.

“Yes. Slowly. The rim wants work when Mere has it back.”

Kelm took a folded sheet from his jacket. He held it for a moment before giving it to Ragna. The folds were soft, the paper stained where it had rubbed against his shirt.

“Carrier's counterfoil,” he said. “It goes back with the vehicle. I am not taking their book.”

Ragna opened it. Forty bars, received at Thorn. The order reference matched the supplier's invoice. Beside the quantity were a stores number and Dole's signature. The batch mark was written out below, with a correction initialled by the receiver.

“Did you see them counted here?”

“Yes.”

“All forty?”

“I counted with him. That's why he put the wrong mark right. I told him it was wrong.”

She read the correction again. A receiving count, a named receiver and a batch that could be checked: evidence the bars had arrived, not merely been paid for. She put the counterfoil inside the collection authority so the old folds would not tear.

“It doesn't say anything about the twenty,” Kelm said.

“I know.”

“You keep asking about them.”

“We will have to ask someone else.”

He rubbed the empty place inside his jacket. She could see how exposed he felt without the paper, though it had done nothing to keep him safe here.

“If you want it back, say so,” she said.

“Give it to Mere. She owns the cart.”

Neri gathered her tools. She counted them once, stopped at the spare pin she had used, and took the bent one in its place. Then she rolled the cloth and tied it.

“We can ask Dole together,” Ragna said to Kelm. “We can tell him you have asked to leave and we will say where you are going. I won't tell you he will let you.”

“What if he doesn't?”

“I don't know yet.”

Neri lifted the sack onto the cart.

“Did you take the rail out?” she asked.

Kelm looked up sharply.

“Yes.”

“Before the load moved?”

“Yes.”

Ragna saw Neri's fingers close on the sack. She did not loosen them.

“My father knew?”

“He told me not to run it. I was told to keep it running.”

“By whom?”

Kelm glanced towards the office. “Harrow.”

A cart rattled in at the main gate. The sound came between them, hard wheels over stone. Ragna kept her eyes on Neri.

“Does that change what you want?” she asked her quietly.

Neri looked as if she might strike him. She had the hammer near her hand and did not pick it up.

“I want him outside,” she said. “I want to hear the rest where he can't keep looking at that door.”

Kelm swallowed. “If I don't say what you want?”

“You've said something I don't want already.”

“Neri,” Ragna said.

“No. I want him to understand. I am not forgiving him to get him through the gate.”

Ragna turned to Kelm. “You can ask to leave without agreeing to a statement. We will still have questions.”

He nodded once. Neri kept her eyes on the brake.

They lifted the cart's shafts and brought it out of the shed. Ragna and Neri took the front; Kelm steadied the rear crosspiece. The repaired brake caught when Neri pressed it. She tested it twice on the slope, then turned towards the office.

Dole came out with the return book.

“Finished?”

“Safe to move,” Neri said. “Rim damaged. Bracket straightened, pin replaced. Write that.”

He wrote it, holding the book against the wall. Ragna signed for the vehicle in that condition. Dole tore out the return receipt and gave it to her.

Kelm stepped beside the shafts.

“I'm leaving with them.”

Dole stared at him, then shut the book.

“You are required here.”

“I have asked to go. I have a room and work at Blackwater. If there are questions, tell me when to come.”

“Mr Harrow has not concluded his examination.”

“Then he can conclude it with me living somewhere else.”

Dole glanced at the guard by the main gate. He had not called him yet.

“Don't make this difficult.”

Kelm let go of the cart. “I have been sleeping in a shed.”

“You were given quarters.”

“A shed. With a bolt on the outside.”

Ragna set down her shaft. “Has he been detained under an order?”

“He is assisting an inquiry.”

“He no longer agrees to sleep here.”

“Nor does he agree to what happened at the lift, apparently.”

Neri took a breath so sharply that Ragna heard it. Dole looked at her, then away.

“I didn't mean that.”

“What did you mean?”

“I mean there is an account to be settled. I cannot let people come and go while the investigator is asking for them.”

“Ask him now,” Ragna said. “We can wait while you ask.”

Dole hesitated, then called the porter. He told him to hold the cart and went inside. Through the office window Ragna saw him kneel at the hearth. Green light rose against the wall.

Kelm took a step backwards.

“He'll tell him to keep me.”

“He hasn't answered yet,” Ragna said.

“You heard him at the shaft?”

“No.”

“I did.”

The porter stood beside them with his keys in his hand. Neri asked him whether he had an order to keep Kelm.

“I work the stores,” he said.

“That's not an answer.”

“It's the answer I've got.”

From the lower lane came the creak of a loaded wagon. The river gate opened. A goblin in a wide-brimmed hat led his horse up the slope, pulling a load of charcoal. Neri recognised him at the same moment Ragna did. He was the carrier from the checkpoint, the one whose sack they had helped refill.

The porter waved him towards the storehouse. The lower gate remained open while another man brought the first barrow out to unload.

Kelm picked up the rear crosspiece.

“I am going,” he said.

Ragna looked at Neri. They had agreed on no signal, no way to do this safely. Neri turned the shafts away from the office and faced down the slope.

“Then help with the brake,” she told Kelm.

The porter stepped in front of the wheel.

“Don't do this.”

“I have signed for the cart,” Ragna said. “We are taking it out.”

“There are three of you.”

“Yes.”

He looked from her to Kelm. For a moment she thought he would reach for the wheel. Instead he took his hand off the wood and called Dole's name.

They moved slowly. The cart was light, but the slope pulled at it. Neri kept one hand on the brake arm. Ragna pulled to the left so they would not strike the charcoal wagon. Kelm leaned his weight against the rear

crosspiece, his boots slipping once on the stones.

The guard shouted from the main gate.

“Stop there.”

Ragna looked back. His wand was out. The office door opened behind him.

“Stop the vehicle,” Dole called.

Something struck the right wheel. The shaft jerked out of Ragna's hand. The cart slewed sideways, and its crosspiece hit Neri above the ankle. She went down on one knee with a sound Ragna had never heard her make.

Kelm caught the brake arm. The repaired pin held. The cart stopped across the slope, one wheel lifted from the ground.

“Leave it,” Ragna said.

Neri reached towards her tool sack.

“Leave it.”

The charcoal horse threw its head up at the noise. Its driver pulled the reins and swore. The wagon moved broadside across the lane. The barrow man dropped his handles and went to the animal's head.

Dole shouted, “Not at the horse. Put it down.”

Ragna did not know whether he meant the wand or the vehicle. She had one hand beneath Neri's arm. Kelm took the other. Neri tried to stand, set weight on the injured foot and folded again.

“My tools,” she said.

“They're on the cart.”

“I know where they are.”

Ragna could reach the sack if she let go. She looked at the wheel hanging over the slope, the guard moving towards them, the narrow gap behind the charcoal wagon.

“We have to move.”

Neri shut her eyes. When she opened them, she nodded.

They took her between them, one arm over each shoulder. Behind the wagon, the driver looked down from his seat. He saw Ragna's face, Neri's foot dragging, Kelm's grey head.

“Hold the horse,” he told the barrow man.

“I am.”

“Then hold him another moment.”

He kept the reins tight. The wagon stayed across the lane. There was room behind it for people, not another vehicle.

Ragna and Kelm brought Neri through the gap and down towards the river. The gate porter took a step into their path.

“Collection chit.”

Ragna pulled the folded return receipt from her pocket and thrust it towards him. She did not stop long enough to see whether he took it. The sheet fluttered, caught on his coat and fell.

“We've got to get her home,” she said.

“There's another man.”

“I am going home,” Kelm said.

The porter caught his sleeve. Kelm twisted free. The cloth tore from shoulder to elbow. For an instant all three lost their balance. Neri cried out and gripped Ragna's collar. They stumbled through the open gate onto the towpath.

A man leading a packhorse stopped in front of them. He was a Muggle; Ragna knew it by his uncomprehending stare at the Ministry badge and the wand lifted behind the bars.

“What's happened?” he asked.

“She's hurt,” Ragna said. “Give us room.”

He drew his horse aside. From within the depot Dole called to the guard again. Ragna heard the words people on the path. No spell followed them across the open ground.

Ragna kept looking back.

They turned beneath the old mill wall, where the path bent out of sight of the gate. Kelm's breath came harshly. He had eaten badly and worked too long; his strength was not what the breadth of his shoulders promised. Neri tried to hop, then swore when the movement jarred her leg.

“Put me down.”

“Not here,” Ragna said.

“There are steps ahead.”

Neri was right. A short flight rose from the towpath towards the wooded bank. Ragna had not seen it. The

first steps were worn hollow and slippery with moss.

They stopped long enough to change their grip. Kelm went behind Neri, taking most of her weight. Ragna went in front, holding her hands while she pushed herself up one step at a time. Halfway, Neri began to shake. She was furious about it and could do nothing to stop.

At the top lay the kiln path they had taken yesterday. Ragna knew the broken wall, the bed of nettles and the turn behind the coppice. She looked back. Nobody was visible on the lower steps. A voice called from the river, too distant to distinguish.

“Keep going,” Neri said.

They went into the trees.

The ruined kiln gave them cover from the path. Its round wall rose shoulder-high on the sheltered side. Kelm lowered Neri onto dry leaves and sat down so suddenly that Ragna thought his legs had failed.

“Only a minute,” he said.

Neri pulled her coat aside to look at the ankle. It was already swelling. Ragna knelt beside her, afraid to touch it.

“We need the healer.”

“And Mere,” Neri said.

Ragna looked at her.

“Her cart. We left it.”

“I know.”

“My tools.”

“I know.”

The collection authority had torn at one corner. The carrier's counterfoil was still inside it, protected by the folded oilcloth in Ragna's pouch. She took it out just long enough to see that Dole's signature and the forty-bar entry were dry.

Kelm watched her. “You got it?”

“Yes.”

He leaned his head against the old kiln wall.

Ragna wanted to ask him about the rail, about the order, about where Dorrik had stood. She looked instead at his split sleeve and Neri's hand clenched around a handful of leaves.

She put the papers away and began working out who could reach the road to ask for help without leaving the others unprotected.

“I can go,” Kelm said.

“You need to sit.”

“So do you.”

Ragna looked at the path beyond the broken wall. If he went alone, he could keep going. He knew where they were, and they had no way of making him return.

“There's a carrier's turn below the kiln,” Neri said. “Not the river path. Tell them we need a cart that takes a passenger lying down.”

Kelm got to his feet. “Which healer?”

Ragna gave him the name and address written on Fenn's bill. She had copied it before they left because she had meant to ask after him on the way home. She tore the little slip from her notebook and held it out.

He took it.

“Tell Sella where we are,” Neri said.

Kelm nodded. He waited until Ragna moved aside, then went through the gap in the wall. She listened to his footsteps until they faded into the ordinary sounds of the wood.

Chapter Sixteen: The Part Left Out

For a long time after Kelm left, Neri listened to the path.

Ragna sat with her back to the kiln wall. The stone held the cold. She had put her coat under Neri's injured leg and was trying not to watch the swelling above the boot.

“He may not come back,” Neri said.

“He may not.”

“He took the healer's address.”

“Yes.”

“If he goes to her, he has to say who he is.”

Ragna looked towards the gap in the wall. Kelm could disappear into the woods with no paper tying him to them. At the healer's address, he would have to explain where he had come from.

A jay called, then another. Neri shifted her leg and could not hide the pain quickly enough.

“Stop looking at it,” she said.

“I wasn't.”

“You were.”

Ragna looked at the ground. After a while Neri gave a small, unwilling laugh.

“My mother does that. Looks somewhere worse.”

They heard wheels before they heard voices. Kelm came through the trees carrying a folded blanket. The healer

followed him, then a carrier with a narrow stretcher. Sella was behind them. Her coat was unfastened and there was flour on one sleeve.

She went straight to her daughter.

“What can you move?”

“The rest of me.”

“Show the healer, not me.”

Neri tried to smile. Sella put a hand against the back of her head and held it there while the healer examined the leg.

Ragna got up too fast. The trees tilted. She caught the wall with both hands and waited until the path stopped shifting.

Kelm stood beside her without touching her.

“I told them where,” he said.

“I can see that.”

He nodded as if she had answered something else.

The healer said Neri must be moved without walking. She would examine the injury properly in her rooms. She was not promising to have Neri back at a bench tomorrow. Neri began to argue about the fitted orders; Sella stopped her with a word Ragna could not hear.

They carried her out. Kelm took one end of the stretcher until the path widened enough for the carrier to relieve him. Ragna walked behind with the papers.

At the healer's door, Sella asked for the receiving counterfoil.

“I'll take it home,” she said. “You stay until she says whether you need looking at too.”

Ragna handed over the original and the collection authority, then reached for the vehicle return copy. She stopped. She had thrown that receipt towards the gate porter.

“The return receipt is at Thorn,” she said. “I let it go at the gate.”

Sella checked what she actually held. “This is enough to list. We won't list what isn't here.”

She went inside to tell Neri before taking the papers away. Ragna stood on the step until she came back.

Mere arrived in the afternoon.

She had hired a light wagon because the cart they had gone to fetch was still at Thorn. She asked to see Neri, then was told the healer had put her to bed. Mere sat in the workshop and listened to Ragna's account instead.

When Ragna finished, Mere said, “So I have paid for a brake repair on a cart I do not possess.”

“I am sorry.”

“Are the tools still with it?”

“Neri's roll. Yes.”

“The one she needs to work with.”

“Yes.”

Mere took off her hat and put it on her knees. “I told you what I was authorising.”

“You did.”

“And you used the cart to bring another person out.”

“We tried. We left it when Neri was hurt.”

“I know. I am not asking you to go back and try the journey again.”

Ragna sat very still. She had expected anger, not a hire bill she could not pay.

“I will put what I saw in writing,” she said. “The guard struck the wheel. The brake pin held. I don't know the final damage.”

“Write the earlier damage too. Don't make me look as though I sent you a good cart.”

“I won't.”

Mere rubbed at the edge of her hat. “I'll claim against the depot. My cart was in their custody when the first damage happened, and at their gate when the second did. If they refuse, I will need another cart while I argue. Somebody pays for that.”

“I haven't money enough now.”

“I had gathered.”

“The fund isn't mine.”

“I am not asking for hungry people's bread.”

Ragna let out a breath she had been holding.

Mere continued, “I will give you the hire bill. Not the whole price of a new cart because I'm angry. The actual hire. We'll see what can be recovered. I am not forgiving the bill by waiting to present it.”

“I understand.”

“I hope you do. People keep saying that before they go away with something.”

Sella came in from the healer with news that Neri would stay there overnight. She must not put weight on the leg. The healer was more concerned about the crush than a simple twist. Sella said this in a level voice, then put a cup down so hard it cracked.

No one spoke until she fetched a cloth for the tea.

Mere put her hat on the table and helped wipe it up. When they had finished, she asked to see her carrier's counterfoil. Sella brought it from the cash book, separate from the ledger fragment. Mere compared the order number with her own copy of the invoice.

“All forty,” she said. Ragna nodded.

“Then I can answer for what was sold, paid for, counted and sent. What happened to the money at the bank is yours to establish.”

She made a copy for her claim and left the original with Sella by agreement. She would ask for it again if the depot disputed her account.

Kelm had been waiting by the back bench. Mere looked at him.

“Hask says he knew your father.”

“He knew him at the old furnace.”

“He has asked whether you need a room.”

Kelm looked at Ragna, then at Sella. “I can't pay for it tonight.”

“He didn't ask about tonight. There is a room at the foundry. You can speak to him about the rest.”

“Does he know what I've done?”

Mere's expression changed. “I know you signed for my bars and they arrived. If there is something else, don't make me discover it from a visitor at the gate.”

Kelm looked towards the door. It was unbarred.

“I took the corner rail out at Blackwater,” he said.

Sella stood beside the broken cup. Her face did not move.

“Say the rest.”

He stayed where he was. “If I tell it, will it be written?”

“If you agree,” Ragna said. “You may hear it read before anyone else takes a copy.”

“And if I want something changed?”

“You change your words. We won't change what we saw.”

He pulled out a stool. It scraped against the floor and caught at a seam. He lifted it over the seam, set it beside the open door and sat.

Dorrik had come at the end of the shift to ask about the twenty bars. Kelm had told him the second cart had been redirected. He had said he could not give him a receiving receipt because he did not have one.

“He said a release wasn't a delivery. I told him to take it up with the office.”

“Did he?” Sella asked.

“He waited. Harrow was there to see the later load. Forty from Mere, going through the lift and on to Thorn. Dorrik waited until I could fetch the first note.”

The load on the narrow cart would pass the lift entrance, but not turn easily between the post and the corner rail. Harrow had said the consignment could not wait for a different vehicle. Kelm had removed the four bolts and lifted the rail out of its sockets.

“Dorrik told me to put it back before I worked the lift.”

“Where was he?”

“Beside the winch. He was looking at the brake. I had asked him to look because the pawl was catching.”

The words came faster now. Ragna wrote what she could and left gaps rather than substitute something tidier.

“Harrow said keep it moving. I said the cart needed room. He said we'd made room, so what were we waiting for? I pulled the control. The near wheel caught the board at the lip. The load shifted to the open side.”

“Towards the missing rail?”

“Yes.”

“What did Dorrik do?”

“He reached for the shaft. I think to keep the cart from turning. I don't know. He didn't tell me what he was going to do.”

Sella gripped the edge of the bench.

“I saw his hand on it. His other hand went towards the brake. Then he was gone.”

Kelm stopped. Ragna's pen made one last stroke.

“Did the cart fall?” she asked.

“No. The wheel caught. I shut the control. We got it straight.”

“And Dorrik?”

“I couldn't see the bottom from where I stood. Brann was below. He called up.”

“What did he say?”

Kelm pressed the heels of his hands into his eyes. “I don't want to put words in his mouth.”

“Then don't.”

“He said Dorrik was there. I knew what he meant.”

Ragna wrote Kelm's words exactly.

Harrow had asked who ordered the rail removed. Kelm had said he had removed it to move the load. Later he was shown an account stating that the barrier was in place and Dorrik had gone into the closed working area after the bell.

“I said that wasn't what happened.”

“Who showed it to you?”

“Pell. Not that night. At Thorn, when I was still waiting to go home.”

“Did you sign it?”

“No.”

“Have you signed any account of the fall?”

“No.”

Mere had sat down without Ragna noticing. She was looking at Kelm's hands.

Sella asked, “Why did you keep the lift moving after he told you not to?”

Kelm looked at her for the first time since he began.

“Because I was told to. Because I thought I could do it. I've done worse turns with heavier loads. That is what I thought.”

“Not because you didn't know.”

“No.”

Sella took a step towards the door, stopped and went to the stove instead. She did not offer him absolution or ask Ragna to make the answer easier.

Ragna read the whole account aloud. Kelm corrected the side on which he had stood. He insisted on the gaps where he had not seen the fall's end. He did not remove the sentence saying he thought he could do it.

He signed each page. Mere and Sella witnessed the signature, each noting that she had not seen the fall. The receiving counterfoil remained a separate sheet.

Before Mere took Kelm to the foundry, Sella said, “Neri has to hear it.”

“She will,” Ragna said.

“All of it.”

“Yes.”

Kelm stood by the door. “I can tell her.”

Sella looked at him for a long time. “She decides that.”

Ragna went to the healer's rooms before they closed for the night. Neri lay in a narrow bed behind a curtain, with one boot on the floor and the other nowhere Ragna could see. Her foot had been wrapped and supported. She looked younger without the apron.

“He came back,” she said.

“He did. With help.”

“Did he say it?”

Ragna set the folded account on the chair beside the bed. “He signed what he remembers. Your mother heard it.”

Neri watched the paper.

“Was my father alone?”

“No.”

“Read that part.”

Ragna read from Dorrik's arrival to the point where Kelm asked him to look at the brake. When she reached the rail, Neri turned her face towards the curtain.

“Not now.”

Ragna stopped. A door shut somewhere along the passage. The healer asked someone to move a bucket before she tripped over it.

“With my mother,” Neri said. “When she comes tomorrow.”

“All right.”

“Can I have water?”

Ragna poured it. Neri took the cup herself, both hands around it, and drank in small sips. Ragna moved the signed account from the chair to her bag so she could sit beside the bed without holding it between them.

After a while Neri asked whether the foundry had sent a bill.

“It will.”

“My little file has a chipped handle. They'll throw it away if they don't know it is mine.”

“I'll put that in the request for the tools.”

Neri nodded. She looked at the empty place where the paper had been and let Ragna stay until the lamp in the passage was lowered.

Chapter Seventeen: A Visit Allowed

The note from Blackwater arrived with a basket of turnips.

Hedra read it in the passage outside the counting house. She held the basket on one hip and the paper close to her face. When she had finished, she gave the note to Ragna without speaking.

Tavin was permitted one visitor that afternoon. The visitor was to present the note at the gate and submit to a search. No papers were to be carried inside. The signature was Pell's.

“He asked for me?” Hedra said.

“It doesn't say.”

“No. It doesn't.”

She took the note back and folded it. Ragna watched her thumb press the fold flat. The canvas mending had left a small black stain beside her nail.

“Are you going?”

“Yes. But I won't go as far as the gate and be told it was for someone else.”

Ragna went with her to the Ministry court. The clerk who had accepted the petition took the note and asked them to wait. Behind the door's green glass panel, his shadow paused beside a taller one. He returned alone.

“The visit is for Miss Ragna.”

Hedra kept her hands on the basket. “Why?”

“I don't have that information.”

“Is my son ill?”

“I don't have that information either.”

The clerk looked at the turnips as if he expected them to help. Hedra set the basket on his counter.

“Watch these while I take a chair,” she said. “They're for the healer, and I don't want someone deciding they belong to the inquiry.”

She sat in the only chair. The clerk moved the basket out of the way of his papers. Ragna stood beside her, angry at the invitation and more angry that she meant to accept it.

“I'll tell you everything he lets me see,” she said.

“Tell me what you see. He may not let you do anything.”

Hedra stayed in the chair while Ragna arranged the cart. When the driver came, Hedra took the basket and asked him to stop at the healer's. If Sella was still at Neri's bedside, there was no use delivering their turnips to an empty workshop.

They rode together to the end of the lane. Hedra got down there. She did not kiss Ragna or wish her luck. She checked the position of the sun, told the driver she would wait in the shelter by the ruined wall, and paid half the fare.

At the gate Pell searched Ragna's coat and pouch. He kept her penknife, her pencil and the paper in which Sella had wrapped two pieces of cheese. He left her the

cheese after she showed him she could carry it in her hand.

“Is that for him?” he asked.

“If you allow it.”

“I'll decide.”

He took her into the yard. The lift was out of use. A board lay over part of the opening, and the beam Neri had seen against the wall was gone. Ragna wanted to look for the bolt holes. Pell had her by the elbow before she had turned her head properly.

“Inside.”

He led her through a door beside the boiler shed. There were three rooms in the short passage. Tavin sat at a table in the middle one, with his hands free and a cup in front of him. The cup was empty. When he saw her, he stood so quickly that his chair toppled.

“Mother?”

“Outside the gate. She wasn't allowed in.”

He looked past Ragna at Pell, then righted the chair. There was a mark on his wrist where the binding had cut him. Ragna could see a strip of clean linen beneath his sleeve.

“Are you hurt?”

“Not much.” He touched the linen. “They looked at it.”

“Have you seen Venn?”

“Through the door. Yesterday. He asked if his aunt knew.”

“She does. And Ruth. Your mother has a receipt for your clothes.”

“I got them.” He looked down at the mended coat. “I thought she would send the other one.”

She told him that Kelm had been held in a locked shed at Thorn and had left with Ragna and Neri. She did not try to give him Kelm's whole account while Pell stood within hearing.

Ragna put the cheese on the table. Pell removed one piece and broke the other open with his thumb. He put the broken half back.

“Five minutes,” he said.

He left the door open and stood in the passage. Tavin waited until his steps had moved away from the threshold.

“I didn't ask for you,” he said.

“I know.”

“Did they tell you why?”

“No.”

He sat, and she took the other chair. A dark ring marked the table, its grain raised by damp. Tavin traced it once with a fingertip.

“They keep asking who told us to put the papers up.”

“What have you said?”

“That I did it.”

“Do they believe you?”

“They want a name they can put above mine.” He broke the cheese into two pieces. “I told them I used the ladder at the lower market. Pell asked who lent it to me. I said I didn't ask. It was leaning against the wall.”

Ragna nearly warned him against saying even that. But he had spent longer with their questions than she had.

“They say Fenn threw something,” he said.

“I saw a stool fall. I didn't see the whole doorway.”

“They told me he had a knife.”

“I saw no knife.”

“Did anyone?”

“Dask remembers a stool being thrown, but he isn't certain when. His wife didn't agree to his name being used.”

Tavin nodded. “Then don't use it.”

The door moved. Harrow stood behind Pell, carrying the black case. He did not sit.

“Mr Tavin has given us a very incomplete account,” he said. “I hope you can help him understand the difficulty.”

“I came to see him.”

“And you have.” Harrow put the case on the table. “The record Mr Venn retained is here. We have other materials belonging to the Ministry. One of them appears to have left Thorn with you.”

Ragna felt Tavin look at her. She kept her attention on Harrow.

“Mere's carrier's counterfoil was given to me by the carrier responsible for it.”

“Mr Kelm was not free to dispose of it.”

“Was he free to leave?”

“He was assisting an inquiry.”

“He asked to leave three times.”

Harrow opened the case. Venn's dispatch lay inside, protected by a sheet of blotting paper. Beside it was a second document bearing the Ministry seal. Harrow left it face down.

“I can release Mr Tavin today,” he said. “I can also permit Mr Venn to return to his work, provided he gives an undertaking to submit his papers to the inquiry. In return, the counterfoil comes back to Thorn. Miss Ilva withdraws her statement while the examination is conducted. There will be no public circulation of the accounts.”

Tavin pushed his chair away from the table. “You told me I was here for obstruction.”

“You are. The circumstances can be reconsidered.”

“Are you offering me a bargain or telling her what to do?”

Harrow turned the sealed paper over. It was a release form with spaces for two names. Ragna could see the word undertaking at the bottom. The pen beside it had a silver band at the grip.

“Mr Venn altered an official record,” Harrow said. “You interfered with officers. I am prepared to take a

practical view.”

“Show me the other undertaking,” Ragna said.

“It will be prepared when you agree.”

“I want to know what Ilva must withdraw.”

“Her unverified allegations.”

“She certified the advance herself. Two partners have the book.”

“They may examine it privately.”

“And the workers?”

“Will be paid what is established as due.”

Tavin picked up the torn cheese, put it down again and wiped his fingers on the table.

“If she gives it to you,” he said, “does Kelm go back to the shed?”

“Mr Kelm is required to complete his account.”

“That isn't an answer.”

Harrow looked at Ragna. “You see the problem.”

“Yes,” she said. “I do.”

She thought of Hedra waiting by the wall and of the coat she had packed. She thought of Neri asking for the part of Kelm's statement she could bear to hear, then asking for water. Sella held the counterfoil for the foundry's claim. Ilva had made her own statement. Ragna could surrender neither.

“I can't give you their papers,” she said.

“You can bring them here.”

“I can ask them. I cannot agree for them.”

Tavin leaned forward. “I won't sign it.”

Harrow's expression changed very little. “You have not read it.”

“I can read the word undertaking. I can hear what you're asking her to do.”

“You could be home this evening.”

“I want to go home.” Tavin's voice rose, then he pressed his hands between his knees. “I want my mother to stop waiting by gates. But if you're holding me until she gives you a paper that isn't hers, write that down too.”

Pell took a step into the room. Harrow closed the case.

“Think about it,” he told Ragna. “The offer will not improve.”

He went out. Pell followed him, leaving the door open again. Tavin remained seated. Ragna could see that his hands were trembling. He put them flat on the table until they stopped.

“I shouldn't have put the papers up early,” he said.

She had imagined him saying it many times. It gave her no pleasure now.

“You should have asked the room to change its decision.”

“I thought they wouldn't.”

“They might not have.”

He looked at the empty cup. “I don't know if that brought him to the door.”

“Neither do I.”

He picked up the cheese again. This time he ate a little.

“Mother will ask if I'm eating.”

“I'll tell her I saw you eat cheese.”

“She'll say it isn't a meal.”

“She'll be right.”

Pell returned before either of them had anything else to say. He held out his hand for the remaining cheese and seemed disappointed when Tavin put it in his mouth instead.

Ragna stood. Tavin did not ask her to stay. At the door he said, “Tell her about the coat.”

“What about it?”

“That I know why she sent this one.”

Outside, the light had shifted across the yard. The gatekeeper gave Ragna her pencil and knife. He did not return the paper that had wrapped the cheese.

Hedra was waiting by the ruined wall. She stood as soon as the cart appeared. Ragna got down before the driver had stopped.

“He's wearing the coat,” she said. “He has a bandage on one wrist. He says they looked at it. I saw him eat cheese.”

Hedra's mouth opened, then closed. She sat down on the low wall and put both hands over her face. Ragna waited until she could speak.

“What did he say about the coat?”

“He knows why you sent it.”

“He always liked the other one better.”

“What is it about this one?”

Hedra pulled her hands away. “The lining. I put a pocket in it when he was small. He used to hide things there when he thought I wasn't looking.”

“What things?”

“Anything he didn't want his sister to find. Buttons. A dead beetle once.” She looked up. “Did you see the pocket?”

“No.”

“Good. Perhaps they didn't either.”

She got into the cart. Ragna sat beside her and told her about Harrow's offer, including what she had not been able to read. Hedra listened without interrupting.

“It's his decision about his name,” she said when Ragna finished. “Ilva's about hers. And Venn ought to hear what's being offered for him.”

“I couldn't speak to him.”

“Then we keep asking.”

They passed the checkpoint on the road home. The notice about metal had been replaced by a longer one. A carrier stood reading it while the guard waited, one hand on his wand. Ragna could not see the words from the cart. She saw the carrier fold his own delivery order and put it back in his pocket before turning away.

Chapter Eighteen: The Second Cart

Borr came back downriver on a Thursday, with a split lip and a load of damaged buckets.

Mere sent word to Sella's workshop. The message reached Ragna at the healer's, where Neri was sitting in a chair with her injured leg on a stool. A wooden splint held the foot still. The healer had told her the bones might be sound, but the swelling made it too early to be certain.

Neri read the message and handed it back. “Ask him about the first load as well.”

“The forty?”

“The twenty before it. He drove for Mere. People drive other people's carts when there's work.”

“You know he did?”

“I know he has. Don't put that in your account as an answer.”

Ragna smiled despite herself. Neri had a file and a small piece of brass in her lap, borrowed from the healer's husband. She had dropped the file twice and now gripped it too tightly.

“Give it here,” Sella said.

“No.”

“I'm not taking it away. I'm holding the brass.”

Neri let her. Ragna left them arguing about which side needed filing.

At Mere Foundry the charcoal pile had been covered with a tarpaulin. Hask was trying to repair the hinge of a furnace door with a pin that was too short. He showed Ragna the gap without being asked.

“Mere would like a word about the cart,” he said. “I would like a word about the fitter's tools. They are still at Thorn, and this pin will not grow because I swear at it.”

“I've written for them.”

“Write again. Use larger letters.”

Mere was in the yard with Borr. He sat on an overturned bucket, pressing a damp rag to his lip. His coat was torn under one arm. A horse stood beside him, eating from a sack hung around its neck.

“The checkpoint?” Ragna asked.

“Another carrier's elbow,” he said. “We both wanted the dry side of a doorway. He got it.”

Mere handed him a cup. “This is Ragna. She wants to ask about Blackwater and Thorn.”

“She's got a mouth. Let her.”

Ragna told him which journey concerned her. He remembered the forty bars and the narrow cart. He had waited at the upper gate while it was taken through, then been sent back without the vehicle. He could identify the driver from Blackwater; he had not seen the count inside Thorn.

“Kelm obtained the counterfoil,” Ragna said. “Dole signed it.”

“Then he's got more than I have.”

“Do you know who brought the earlier twenty?”

Borr put the rag down. “Earlier than the forty?”

“A fortnight before. There were two loads released under a workshop note.”

He looked at Mere. “That's the one I told you about.”

“You told me there was a load that paid badly.”

“It did.” He turned to Ragna. “I took twenty from Blackwater to Thorn. I didn't load them there. A second driver brought them to the yard, and I took them from her.”

“Who was the second driver?”

“Rell. She works the upper road when she can get it.”

“Where is she now?”

“Ask at the stables by the east bridge. If she isn't there, ask her horse. It knows where the food is.”

Mere took the rag from him and looked at his lip. He pulled away.

“Did Thorn give you a receipt?” Ragna asked.

“They gave me a chit for the empty cart. I gave it back to the man who lent me the cart.”

“Who received the iron?”

“A clerk called Sorn. Small man. Ink on his cuffs and a cough that made the pen jump. He counted while I held

the tailboard.”

“You saw him count twenty?”

“I helped him. A bar had rolled under the canvas. He wanted to mark nineteen and I wouldn't let him.”

“Did you see what he wrote?”

“No. He turned the book away.”

Ragna took out her pencil. Borr watched it.

“Will you put my name on a wall?”

“No.”

“Where, then?”

She put the pencil down. “If you agree, I would like a statement for the partners and the inquiry. We would ask you before sending it anywhere else. They may still ask you to speak for yourself.”

“Can they make me?”

“I don't know what they will do. They have taken two people to Blackwater.”

Borr touched the torn seam of his coat. “Rell has children. Don't send anyone to her door saying I told you to.”

“I won't.”

He stood and took the horse's sack away. The animal lifted its head and followed him towards the shed. Ragna thought he had finished. At the door he called back, “You can write it. I want to see the words before you take them.”

She followed with the paper. He corrected her twice. Once because she had written that Sorn signed a receipt, when Borr had only seen him writing in the book. Once because she had described the iron as belonging to Sella's workshop.

“I didn't know whose it was,” he said. “I knew where it had come from.”

He put his name below the statement after Mere read it to him. She signed as witness to his signature. He kept one copy and let Ragna take the other to the partners.

At the east bridge stables, Rell was cleaning a harness. She listened without putting down the brush. She remembered taking a load from Blackwater to the riverside yard, but would not say where it had gone after Borr took it.

“Did it come under a note for Sella's workshop?” Ragna asked.

“I had a load number. I didn't have the workshop note.”

“Would you show it to me?”

“No.”

Ragna waited.

Rell hung the harness on a peg. “My son is due back from the north. The men at the road have been opening carts and making people tell them who gave them work. I don't know which answer is going to bring them to my house.”

“I can come back.”

“You can. I may tell you the same thing.”

She went on brushing the harness. Ragna left her to it.

On the road to the bank house she passed a wagon carrying three empty cages. Each was large enough for a person. A wizard walked beside the wagon with a list, counting the cages whenever the wheels crossed a rut. The driver stopped at the new notice and waited while the wizard checked it against the list. Neither paid attention to Ragna.

She stood a little too long. The wizard looked up.

“Is this the road to the court?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“Good. They sent us round the wrong bridge.”

He thanked her and went on. The last cage had a latch with a bent pin. Neri would have noticed it at once.

Issa received Ragna in the bank house rather than the counting room. There was a fire, though the afternoon was mild. A pair of boots stood beside it, one on its side.

“Halrik's,” Issa said when Ragna looked. “He went out in the rain and refused to put them back on until they dried.”

She read Borr's statement beside the supplier's attested invoice and the copy of Venn's dispatch. She did not ask for Kelm's original counterfoil. Ragna explained that Mere had an interest in it and Sella held it by agreement.

“Will he come here?” Issa asked.

“Borr agreed to be asked. I won't promise he will come.”

“I can accept a signed account for the examination. If Halrik wants to question him, he can travel.”

“That will not prove what was entered in the receiving book.”

“No. It gives me a carrier, a date, a destination and a person who counted with him. More than I had this morning.”

She put the papers in separate wrappers. Ragna knew that care with wrappers. She had once taken more comfort in it.

“Will you pay Sella?” she asked.

“I can put the first twenty aside as disputed. With Borr's statement and Venn's dispatch, I will ask Halrik to agree that a payment can be made without waiting for Dole's book.”

“When?”

“This afternoon.”

Ragna sat down. She had meant to ask about Tavin first. She had followed the figures to their end before asking after him.

Issa noticed. “I heard they allowed you to see him.”

“They allowed Harrow to make an offer.”

Ragna described it. Issa listened without taking notes. When Ragna came to Ilva's statement, the partner opened the drawer beside the fire and took out a small ledger of her own.

“His authority over the London accounts is under review,” she said. “I cannot remove it alone.”

“Halrik can sign with you.”

“He can. He has not agreed yet. He thinks Merrok can recover the Ministry advance if he stays in place.”

“And if he doesn't?”

“Then he thinks we may have to meet the loss ourselves.”

“It's already been met. By people who were charged for it.”

“I know.” Issa closed the ledger. “Bring me proof that the charge was transferred, and I can ask him to choose which loss he prefers.”

“Ilva checked the transfer.”

“She checked a transfer to the ledger. The reconciliation names the household posting, and Harrow has it.”

Ragna looked at the wrapper holding Borr's statement. It placed twenty bars at Thorn, but left the hidden page out of reach.

“Can you require the ledger back?”

“I have asked. Merrok says Harrow means to move it to the Ministry archive.”

“When?”

“He says he doesn't know. He says the ledger is sealed and the Ministry expects a comparison against the inventory before accepting it into the archive.”

“Do you believe him?”

Issa put Halrik's fallen boot upright. “I believe he would tell me if the date helped him.”

Ragna left with the promise of a meeting that afternoon. At the door a messenger arrived carrying a sealed Ministry order for Issa. He waited while she opened it. She read the first page and asked him to stay for an answer.

Ragna was halfway down the steps when she heard the door open behind her.

“Miss Ragna.”

Issa held the order out. The seal had been broken cleanly. The Ministry required the bank to surrender the remaining records of its workshop reserve for examination. The originals Arven had protected were among those listed.

“It says tomorrow at noon,” Issa said.

Ragna read the list twice. The agreed balances, the disputed balances, the withdrawal slips and the reserve book. Enough to reconstruct what the iron ledger had held. Enough, too, to tell the Ministry which families owed money and to whom.

“Will you give them up?”

“I have not decided.” Issa held out her hand for the order. “I'm going to find Halrik before he puts his boots back on.”

Ragna gave it to her. On the road below, the wagon of empty cages had stopped at the court. Two men were carrying the first one inside.

Chapter Nineteen: What They Can Stop

That afternoon, Halrik arrived at the workshop without his coat. The rain had soaked the shoulders of his shirt, and he had brought the wrong boot on his left foot.

“I put it on in the dark,” he said when Sella looked at it. “My brother has the other one. He was less amused than I was.”

He accepted a cloth for his hair and read Borr's statement at the bench. Issa stood beside him. She had brought the Ministry order and laid it face up for everyone to see.

“Arven has the originals,” she said. “He has been told to prepare them for collection.”

“Has he?” Ragna asked.

“He has boxed them and made a list of the contents. He wants two people to witness the count.”

Sella put down the piece of brass she had been holding for Neri. “At the counting house?”

“At the bank house. The counting room is too small for the boxes.”

Neri sat beside the stove, her foot supported on a stool. She had come home that morning in a hired cart. The healer had given her instructions that Sella had written out and fastened above the bench. Neri had already moved the paper so she did not have to look at it.

“Will they let us keep copies?” she asked.

“The order says copies made for the examination may remain with the bank.”

“That doesn't say the workshops can have them.”

“No,” Issa said.

Halrik read Borr's last correction and turned the sheet over. “He saw the twenty arrive at Thorn. He counted with a clerk. He hasn't seen the entry.”

“We have Venn's dispatch,” Ragna said.

“And the household's stock book.” He rubbed a hand across his wet hair. “I will accept that the twenty are disputed. The forty charged a second time is still a different question.”

“How much can you pay?” Sella asked.

They worked it out on the back of an old delivery bill. It took longer than Ragna expected because Halrik insisted on checking the rate against the original note, and Issa insisted on checking the withdrawals against Arven's certified copies. The result was a positive balance. The partners agreed to advance half now and retain the rest against the unresolved duplicate charge. Sella could pay part of the wages that had waited since the quarter closed, but the next order of moulding sand would still have to wait.

“Today?” Sella asked.

“After we have the original slips,” Issa said. “At the bank house.”

“And the remaining charge?”

“Still open.”

Sella nodded once. She did not say thank you. She went to the drawer and took out the tally sticks, checking each bundle against the list she had made when she thought the wait might last two days.

Ragna took Issa aside while Halrik helped Neri lower her foot from the stool.

“What will you do with the order?”

“I will obey it unless the partners agree to challenge it.”

“Merrok won't.”

“Vale is the Ministry officer assigned to supervise the collection. She can suspend a transfer while an incident is examined, and ask for the detention records. I have sent her our objection. She has not promised to intervene. Merrok says refusing will close every account we hold in London.”

“Do you believe him?”

“I believe he can make it difficult. That's different.” Issa looked towards Sella. “He also says the people at the weigh house have threatened bank property.”

“Who?”

“He didn't give a name.”

“Then ask him for one.”

“I have. He said you would not give him the names of the people who put up the notices.”

Ragna thought of Tavin insisting there had been no one above him. Merrok was making a conspiracy out of a decision she had been angry with Tavin for taking alone.

“Tell him the notices were the room's words,” she said. “The timing was Tavin's.”

Issa folded the order. “Will you tell the room that?”

“Yes.”

The meeting was held at the weigh house, though the broken lamp bracket had not been replaced. The side door was open, and the baskets that had blocked it were stacked in a neighbour's yard. Fenn came on foot with Vessa, his right hand held in a sling. He had tried to lift a sheet of glass that morning and had dropped it. He reported this before anyone could ask.

“I won't try again tomorrow,” he said.

“Will you have work?” Edda asked.

“I have work. I don't know who will do it.”

Brelk had brought his son. The boy sat on a stool near the door, wrapped in a blanket, with a cup of water between his knees. His cough was less frequent than before, but each bout took Brelk's attention away from the room.

Ragna read the Ministry order. She did not read the names on the private records. She told them Issa and Halrik could pay part of Sella's balance that afternoon, and that the remaining charge was still disputed.

“That will put food on a table,” Hirk said. “It won't keep my records out of a box.”

“No,” Ragna agreed.

A fitter from the furnace wanted to take the boxes before Arven could give them up. Another said they

should burn the ledgers, since nobody could seize ashes.

“My wages are in them,” Edda said.

“So are mine,” the fitter replied. “I'd rather lose the figures than have them carry my aunt's name to the court.”

“Ask your aunt,” Vessa said.

The fitter turned to her. “She's dead.”

“Then ask the people still on the page.”

The room went quiet. Vessa looked as if she wanted to take the words back. The fitter sat down before she could.

Ragna put the order on the table. “We can ask Arven to separate the records by household. We can make certified copies for the people named in them. It will take more than a morning.”

“They come at noon,” Fenn said.

“Yes.”

“Then what do we do at noon?”

Brann had not stood at a public meeting since Tavin was taken. He rose now with his cap in his hands. His sister shifted to make space but did not touch him.

“The lift at Blackwater needs the chain tested before the Ministry moves a load,” he said. “Vessa's team does it. If they don't test, the foreman has to sign the lift fit himself.”

“Can he?” someone asked.

“He can put his name down. Whether he will is another matter.”

Vessa looked at him. “You didn't ask me.”

“I know.”

“I won't test it. But the other two decide for themselves.”

One of those workers, a woman called Tola, stood near the door. She had missed a day's wages after refusing an attendance report. She said she would not test the chain. The other tester was not at the meeting. Vessa would ask him before the morning shift.

Neri wanted to go to Blackwater. Sella told her she could not walk to the door, let alone the works. Neri argued for a while and then asked for a slate. She began listing the repairs scheduled for Ministry vehicles, including the work Mere had expected to do herself. Hask had already said he would not release new fittings to Thorn until Mere's cart was returned or paid for.

Hirk said she would still deliver sand to the school workshop. Brelk said he could not stop work at the forge that paid his son's room, but he could carry messages after his shift. The carters at the meeting agreed to ask the drivers hired for the bank-house transfer to refuse the load until the detainees were accounted for. They could not commit drivers who were not present; those who refused might lose their Ministry work. Edda said she would stop her furnace on the morning run if the other operator agreed; she would not shut it down with someone inside the lower chamber.

No one voted on a general strike. They wrote down what each person could withhold, whom it would affect, and when they had to decide. The Ministry could still walk through the doors. But supplies might wait at Blackwater, and the reserve boxes might stay at the bank house, if the workers and carters held to their decisions.

Ragna told them about Harrow's offer. She gave the terms as she understood them and said she had not seen the undertaking. She told them Tavin would not sign a promise he had not read, and that Venn had not been consulted.

“Would you have given him the counterfoil?” Sella asked.

Ragna could have said no. The answer would have been clean and false.

“I wanted to,” she said. “For a moment.”

Sella looked down at her hands. “So did I when you told me.”

Mere had come late, carrying the bill for the hired cart. She laid it on the table without asking anyone to pay it immediately.

“I want my cart back,” she said. “I want Neri's tools back. I also want the receipt returned when the partners have finished with it. If you put it in front of Harrow, I want to be there.”

“You may need it for your claim,” Ragna said.

“I do. You need it for yours. There is no reason one of us has to pretend otherwise.”

They agreed to make two attested copies. Mere would hold the original unless she authorised its use at the bank house. Sella gave it to her across the table, with the invoice beside it. Ragna watched the transfer and wrote the date on the wrapper.

By the time the meeting ended, the room had a list of work that would stop and a second list of work that would continue. It had no promise that the Ministry would wait. Fenn took the first list to Vessa to check. Brelk took the second, so the school would know its repairs could still be made.

At the bank house Arven had opened every box. He had laid the books out in order and marked the private household files with strips of white cloth. Issa and Halrik watched while Sella checked the totals on her balance. Ragna checked the arithmetic beside her. Neither partner asked Sella to sign a release.

The clerk counted the money twice. Sella counted it a third time and put it into two envelopes. One went to the workers who had accepted partial pay. The other she held for the fitter who had refused to lend his labour and had found work elsewhere. She sent Brelk to tell him it was ready.

Ragna carried no envelope home. The three paid days of her suspension had ended without a decision from Merrok, and she had spent the money for her reading lenses on food, fares and a healer's visit. When she told Sella she might have to ask the fund for coal, Sella wrote her name on the private list without commenting on it.

“Who will count it?” Ragna asked.

“Someone who isn't applying for it.”

“Fair.”

“Annoying, isn't it?”

Ragna laughed. It hurt her jaw. She touched the cut and found the edge of a scab.

Outside the bank house, a delivery cart waited with its horse untethered from the shafts. The driver sat on the pavement eating bread. He said he had been told there might be no one to test the lift in the morning and saw no reason to make the horse stand harnessed all night.

“Who told you?” Ragna asked.

“Someone at the furnace.”

“Was it a decision?”

“Sounded like one.” He tore off another piece of bread. “If they change their minds, they can find me at the inn.”

Ragna looked at the shafts resting on the ground. Tomorrow they would have to find the drivers before rumour made more promises in their names.

Chapter Twenty: The Transfer

The lift at Blackwater did not move that morning.

Vessa's two colleagues had made different decisions. Tola stayed away from the chain shed. The other tester went to work and examined the upper links, but refused to sign for the lower length without a second person. The foreman sent for Kelm, then remembered that Kelm was no longer there.

By ten, three carts carrying Ministry stores were waiting on the river road outside Blackwater. Officers could still reach the bank house; Harrow's supplies had to wait. A fourth cart turned back. The drivers left enough space between the vehicles for a horse to pass, and stood under the trees to keep out of the rain. One of them had brought a kettle. He refused to say who had lent it to him.

Ragna saw the carts from the carrier's wagon as she travelled to the bank house. Hedra sat opposite her, holding the receipt Pell had signed for Tavin's clothes. She had carried it every day since the visit.

“Don't give that to anyone,” Ragna said.

“I wasn't going to.”

“I know.”

“Then stop making me answer.”

Hedra leaned back against the wagon. Ragna left her to hold the receipt in peace.

At the bank house the boxes stood in the entrance hall. Arven had put a separate list on each lid. Halrik checked the contents with him while Issa watched the windows. The house had two doors, one to the street and a smaller one to the yard. Both were open. Fenn had insisted on seeing them opened before he sat down.

His arm was still supported. He had brought Edda to turn pages for him.

Mere arrived with the counterfoil in an oilcloth wrapper. Kelm came with her. His sleeve had been mended badly where the porter tore it. He stood in the yard until Sella arrived, and only then came into the hall.

Neri had wanted to attend. The healer had refused to let her travel in a cart over the rough road. She had sent her account of the rail, signed and dated, with Sella. There was a second sheet listing the tools left at Thorn and the condition of the cart when they had taken it from the shed.

“Give that one to Mere,” she had said. “Don't let it disappear in the important papers.”

Mere read it in the hall and put it beside her hire bill.

At eleven a Ministry clerk arrived to count the boxes. He had no power to change the order, he said, and was grateful when Arven gave him the lists. They counted together. The clerk found one missing withdrawal slip; Arven located it in the next box, where he had placed it with the household's other papers.

“Write the correction,” Arven said.

The clerk did. He initialled it and asked Arven to do the same.

Ragna watched from the stairs. She wanted to believe a count could keep the records safe. The count would establish what they handed over, not who opened it afterwards.

At half past eleven the clerk went to the window. A cart was approaching with two wizards on the seat. Another followed behind. Harrow stepped down from the first, carrying a case large enough to hold the iron ledger.

Merrok came in through the yard door at the same moment. His coat was dry. He had been waiting in the covered passage.

“The Ministry has agreed to compare the seized ledger with the reserve files here,” he told Issa. “It will make the transfer quicker.”

“Who agreed?” she asked.

“Harrow.”

“And who asked him?”

“I did. He promised the comparison would show the advance was a Ministry undertaking. I wanted you to see that before the boxes left.”

Harrow entered before she could answer. Pell came behind him. The second cart carried two more officers, one of whom remained with the horses. The other stationed himself at the street door.

“There are people on the road,” Pell said.

“They came to see their records counted,” Sella replied.

“They cannot all come in.”

“They haven't.”

Harrow put the case on the table Arven had cleared. He opened it and lifted out the ledger. It had returned to its full size; a dark mark crossed one corner of the cover. Ragna could not tell whether it had been damaged or merely left against something wet.

“I will compare the reserve schedule with the entries in this book,” he said. “The boxes can then be loaded.”

Issa placed Ilva's control book beside it. “Before you do, we require an explanation of the advance recorded here.”

“The inquiry is considering that matter.”

“The advance came from funds entrusted to this bank. We have supplier and receiving records for the purchase. We have an examiner's statement that a household charge was used to offset it.”

Harrow looked at Ilva. She had stood behind the partners, close enough to see the table but not close enough to touch it.

“Your statement is disputed.”

“By whom?” she asked.

“By the person responsible for the account.”

Merrok stepped forward. “The posting was temporary. It was to be reversed.”

“You checked it,” Issa said to Ilva. “Was that the instruction?”

“I was told it would be reversed when the Ministry paid.”

“Did the workshops agree to finance it?”

“No.”

Merrok's jaw moved. “You understood the risk if we refused the advance.”

“I understood the risk to the bank. I let the workshops carry it without telling them.”

The Ministry clerk stopped writing. Harrow told him to continue.

Mere unwrapped the carrier's counterfoil and put it on the table. “Forty bars. Sold by my foundry, paid for through the bank, received at Thorn. Kelm counted with the receiver.”

Harrow read the sheet. “This is a vehicle document.”

“It is also a receipt for the load.”

“It says nothing about the bank's internal posting.”

“No,” Ragna said. “The reconciliation does.”

Harrow's hand rested on the ledger cover. He did not open it.

Outside, someone called that the Blackwater lift was still idle. Another voice answered that the carts had nowhere else to go. The officer at the door went out to speak to them.

Halrik held out his hand. “The page, please.”

“The ledger is under Ministry seal.”

“It was brought here to be compared.”

“It will be compared by me.”

The Ministry clerk looked up from his list. “The transfer instruction requires the bank partners to witness the comparison. I must record whether the reconciliation was shown.”

Harrow held out his hand for the instruction. The clerk found the clause and pointed to it. Harrow read it, then looked at Merrok, who had asked for the comparison and was watching the clerk write. A refusal would go on the transfer record before the ledger reached the archive.

Issa put her own hand on the table. “This is our bank house. You have an order for the reserve records, not for the control book. I will not surrender it without a separate instruction.”

Harrow looked towards Merrok. Merrok was watching the yard door.

“Do you intend to let her obstruct the inquiry?” Harrow asked.

“I intend to find out why the Ministry has not paid the advance,” Issa said.

For the first time Harrow's attention left the ledger. He looked at the open boxes, the people in the hall, the clerks who had signed the count. His gaze moved from the open boxes to the clerk's pen.

“Mr Venn has been questioned,” he said. “His account is incomplete. Mr Tavin remains under investigation for obstruction.”

Hedra rose from her chair. “I have been to Blackwater every day. You can tell me what he's accused of without making his name part of your bargain.”

“He has been told.”

“Then tell me.”

Harrow did not answer her. He opened the ledger.

The pages moved beneath his hand. Ragna saw the familiar ruled columns, then the wages, then the edge of the page Ilva had covered. The two sheets had not been reattached. A narrow tear showed along the margin.

“There,” Ragna said.

Harrow turned the book towards himself. Halrik moved closer, holding out his hand for the reconciliation. The clerk was writing down every exchange, and the partners had already heard Ilva describe what the page contained. Harrow drew his wand and touched the page. A line of fire ran across the paper. For a moment it was so narrow Ragna thought he meant to underline an entry. Then the corner curled and the flame reached the leather.

“The seal has caught,” Harrow said. He made a quick motion as if to shut the cover, but the flame ran beneath it.

“Stop him,” Ilva said.

Pell stepped between her and the table. Halrik seized the control book. The Ministry clerk dropped his pen and backed into a box. A lid fell; withdrawal slips scattered over the floor.

Ragna went towards the ledger. Harrow raised his wand. She stopped, then moved sideways as Sella reached the table from the other end.

“Not the book,” Sella said. “The page.”

The fire had caught the binding. Ragna grabbed the iron cover. Heat struck her palm. She pulled back, and the book fell open against the edge of the table. The torn sheet came partly free.

Ilva pushed past Pell and took the loose margin. He caught her arm. She did not let go. The paper tore across the middle, leaving a strip in her hand. Ragna seized the part still attached and pulled. The binding resisted. Halrik knocked the ledger to the floor with the side of the cash box.

The lamp on the table fell. Oil spread in a bright line. Edda dragged a box away from it and shouted for water. The clerk fetched a jug, but Arven stopped him before he poured it onto the burning oil. He took a wool coat from the stand and dropped it over the flame.

In the confusion Harrow moved towards the yard door. Kelm held the door open and called to the people outside that the ledger was burning.

Two workshop owners came into the passage. Behind them Brann and Vessa appeared with a blanket from the waiting cart. Pell tried to close the door. Vessa caught the edge before it struck Kelm and held it long enough for Brann to pull the burning book clear of the oil.

Ragna had a piece of the page in her hand. Ilva held another. She could see the red figures on both. The book

itself was still burning. Brann had thrown the blanket over it, but flames pushed through where the wool did not cover the spine.

“The other end,” he called.

Ragna moved to help him. From the stair came a crash. The Ministry clerk was on the floor beneath a fallen box, his ankle twisted against the bottom step. Papers had spilled around him. Harrow had gone out into the yard; Pell was following.

The clerk tried to lift the box and could not. Ragna looked at the book, at the clerk, and at the open door through which more people were coming. She put the torn page inside her coat and went to the stairs.

“Don't pull,” she told him. “We'll lift it.”

Edda came to the other side. Together they raised the box while the clerk drew his leg free. He was crying with anger and embarrassment. Ragna gave him her shoulder and brought him through the street door.

By the time she returned, the fire in the hall was out. The ledger lay beneath the scorched blanket. Its covers had held their shape. Most of the pages had not.

Brann had burned two fingers. He was trying to hide them from Vessa, who took his hand and dipped it into the water jug before he could object. Ilva sat on the bottom step with a strip of parchment on her knee. The ink had blurred at one edge, but the signature remained visible.

Issa had kept the control book. Halrik had picked up the counterfoil and given it back to Mere. The clerk from the

Ministry asked for his count list. Arven found it beneath the fallen box, damp but legible.

Harrow stood in the yard with Pell. Beyond them the workmen who had come from the lift waited in the rain. Wands stayed lowered. The carts waited beyond the yard.

“You have destroyed a record held under seal,” Issa said to Harrow.

“The fire began during an attempt to obstruct an examination.”

“I saw you light the page,” Ilva said.

Merrok came out of the hall. Soot marked one side of his face. He looked at Harrow, then at Issa.

“The page was an internal reconciliation,” he said. “It was not necessary for the Ministry's transfer.”

“You signed it,” Ilva said.

He did not answer her.

The Ministry clerk appeared at the door, leaning on Edda. His ankle was swelling above his shoe. He had his count list in one hand.

“I saw the wand touch the book,” he said. “I didn't see what happened before that.”

“You saw him burn it,” Edda said.

“I saw the wand touch it. Then it caught.”

“Write what you saw,” Ragna said.

Harrow looked towards the street. More people had arrived. Some were there for their own records; others

had come from Blackwater when the lift stopped. Among them Ragna saw the charcoal carrier from Thorn. He stood beside his horse with a hand on the reins, looking at the smoke above the yard.

A woman in a travelling cloak pushed through the crowd. She carried a Ministry badge and a folder under her arm. Arven had asked the officer at the street door to send for the appointed supervisor as soon as the fire began. She listened to Harrow, then to Issa. She asked for the order and the list of boxes. She did not ask to see the torn page until Ilva offered it.

“My name is Vale,” she said. “I am responsible for the transfer.”

“Then your officer has burned the book he brought to compare,” Issa replied.

Vale looked at the blackened ledger. “I will require statements.”

“You will also require a new count,” Arven said. “One box fell. Several records are wet.”

She glanced at the people in the street. The horses had been moved aside, but the carts remained empty. From the road came the sound of someone calling that no lift would be signed until the injured man at the bank house had a healer.

Vale gave the clerk permission to leave for treatment. She asked another officer to take over his list. Then she told Harrow to give her his wand.

He stared at her. “On whose authority?”

“Mine, while I establish what has happened to a record in our custody.”

For a moment Ragna thought he would refuse. He handed it over. Vale put it in her folder rather than her pocket.

“This is not a judgment,” she said to Issa. “The reserve records remain subject to the order. They will stay here under seal until the count is complete.”

“And the people held at Blackwater?” Hedra asked.

“I have no instruction regarding them.”

“Then get one.”

Vale looked at the damaged hall, the empty carts and the people waiting. She asked Hedra for their names. Hedra gave them slowly, so the officer writing beside Vale would not have to ask twice.

Ragna unfolded the piece of page inside her coat. The household name was intact. Beside it was the later forty-bar charge, and beneath that a reference to the reserve advance. The figure at the end had burned away. Ilva's strip held Merrok's signature and the start of the matching entry. Neither piece was whole. Together, with the control book and the copies, they might be enough to show what had happened.

She took them to a dry table inside, where Ilva and Arven could compare the edges.

Chapter Twenty-One: Two Signatures

The torn edges did not quite meet.

A triangle of paper had burned away between the two pieces. Arven placed them on a board and held a ruler beside the surviving lines. The red ink on one piece ended with the first half of a reference; the other began with the final numbers. They matched the control book. The missing paper still left room for a challenge.

“Could there have been another entry between them?” Halrik asked.

“There isn't room for one,” Ilva said.

“Could the reference have been altered?”

“Anything could be altered.” Arven looked at him. “Do you want to know whether this was?”

“Yes.”

“Then I want the other copies.”

Ilva brought the statement she had signed at Sella's workshop. Ragna fetched the attested copy of the advance authority. Mere laid the receiving counterfoil beside the board, far enough from the damp edge that it would not be damaged. Borr's statement lay in a separate wrapper: evidence of the earlier twenty, not this purchase.

They worked in the back room while the Ministry officers counted the reserve boxes again. Vale had ordered the street door kept open. The people who had

come to see the transfer remained outside under umbrellas and pieces of canvas. Someone passed cups of hot water through the crowd. It was all the kitchen had left after the tea ran out.

Ilva put her fingertip beside the surviving part of Merrok's signature.

“I covered this page,” she said. “I saw the entry before I did it. The advance was forty bars at the supplier's rate. The recovery was posted as a second household charge for the same amount.”

“Did Merrok tell you to enter it?” Issa asked.

“He told me to conceal the reconciliation. He said the posting had been made under his instruction. I did not see who wrote the household entry.”

Merrok sat at the far end of the table. He had asked for a clean cloth and had wiped the soot from his face. The mark remained in the seam of his collar.

“You told me it would be reversed,” Ilva said to him.

“It was intended to be.”

“Did you instruct the charge?”

He looked at the torn page, then towards the yard where Harrow had claimed the fire began during an obstruction. “Yes. Harrow will leave the posting to me, won't he?”

Arven stopped moving the ruler. Halrik took up his pen.

“Write it exactly,” Merrok said. “I instructed a temporary posting against the household account. The first forty-bar release made a matching charge easier to

hide. The Ministry was to repay the advance.”

“Did the household consent?” Sella asked.

“No.”

“Did you tell them?”

“No.” He rubbed the edge of the table with a thumb. “I had a written undertaking from Harrow's office. I believed the money would return before the quarter closed.”

“And when it didn't?”

“The Ministry required the ledger.”

“You signed for it to go.”

“I signed because the order had already been made.”

Ragna had heard him invoke the order before. It existed; so did the duplicate charge and the page he had concealed. Now his own account connected them.

Halrik read back what he had written. Merrok corrected one phrase, replacing “payment promised” with “undertaking received”. He signed the correction and the statement beneath it. Ilva signed her own account. Arven and the Ministry clerk, returned from the healer with his ankle bound, witnessed both signatures.

“Now the wages,” Sella said.

Issa took the two surviving pieces of the reconciliation and placed them beside the control book. She did not touch the burned edges.

“The second charge should not have been made,” she said. “The earlier charge for twenty bars sent to Thorn is

supported by Venn's dispatch, Borr's account and the household books. We can authorise payment against those findings.”

Halrik looked at Merrok. “The Ministry owes the reserve for the forty.”

“Yes.”

“If it refuses?”

“We pursue the undertaking.”

“And until then?”

Merrok did not answer.

Halrik turned to Sella. “The bank must meet the balance from its working reserve. We will enter the Ministry claim separately. Your household will not carry it while we wait.”

Sella sat down. She had been standing since she brought the rail statement into the hall. Ragna drew the stool closer.

The calculation took another hour. The earlier twenty had been put aside when the partners paid Sella the previous afternoon. They now removed the second forty-bar charge from the household account. Halrik checked that the earlier partial payment was credited. Issa checked the remaining wages and withdrawals. Arven wrote a schedule showing what had been paid, what remained due and which claims were still open.

“And those who signed Merrok's relief form?” Edda asked.

Halrik read the form. “The payment is credited. The release says the bank's determination applies. The bank is determining that the charge was wrong.”

“Can you put that where the clerk who took my signature can see it?”

“I can put it on your receipt.”

“My aunt?”

“The allowance is a separate decision. I will examine the register and hear what she can show about when she moved in.”

Edda considered this. “She has a rent receipt. The roof leaked through it.”

“Bring what is left.”

Halrik and Issa signed the authorisation together. The clerk brought the working reserve case from the locked cabinet. There was not enough cash in it to pay every verified balance at once. The partners signed orders on their London account for the remainder and arranged for the first carrier to take them that evening. Arven read the dates aloud. A furnace worker asked what would happen if the carrier did not arrive.

“Then the bank still owes the money,” Issa said. “And you come to us.”

“Where?”

“Here.”

She gave the worker a copy of the signed schedule. He folded it and put it inside his shirt.

Outside, the rain had eased. Tola came from Blackwater with news that the second chain tester had agreed to stop work until the detainees were accounted for. A Ministry officer had offered to sign the lift himself; neither tester would certify the lower chain alone. At the bank house, the hired carters had separately refused to load the reserve boxes until the detainees were accounted for. One feared losing his Ministry contract and had asked his brother to seek other work for him. Vale could seek replacement drivers, but could not assemble them immediately.

Vale listened to the report without asking Tola to repeat it for the other officers.

“You are withholding work to influence a Ministry inquiry,” she said.

“Yes,” Tola replied.

“Are you preventing anyone else from entering the works?”

“No.”

Vale looked at the waiting carts. “I have sent to Blackwater for the detention records.”

“When?” Hedra asked.

“An hour ago.”

“And when will they come?”

“I cannot tell you.”

Hedra took her son's package receipt from her pocket. It had become soft at the folds. She laid it on the table in front of Vale.

“Pell signed this. It says my son is there. You can send another person if the first hasn't found the door.”

Vale read the receipt. She called the officer from the street and gave him a written instruction. He left on horseback.

Harrow had remained in the yard after surrendering his wand. When Vale came out, he asked to speak to her alone. She took him into the covered passage, where Ragna could see them but not hear. Merrok waited in the hall. Once, he began towards the passage; Issa told him to stay.

“You cannot suspend my authority on the word of a crowd,” he said.

“I am not doing it on their word.” She held up his signed statement. “You directed a charge against a household that did not consent. You concealed the Ministry debt from the contributors.”

“I told you why.”

“You did. We will include it.”

Halrik took the key to the London accounts from Merrok's chain. Merrok unfastened it himself. The chain left a red mark on his wrist. He put his hand over the mark and looked at the wall while Issa wrote the temporary removal of his signing authority.

“This is pending a full examination,” she said.

“I heard you.”

The horse returned before dusk. Vale read the message it carried, then sent the rider back with a second

instruction. Hedra stood beside Ragna while they watched him leave.

“What did it say?” she called.

Vale hesitated. “Mr Tavin is recorded as held for obstruction. Mr Venn for retention and alteration of an official record. Neither has been brought before the reviewing officer.”

“Bring them here,” Hedra said.

“I have ordered their release into the custody of the inquiry clerk while the allegations are reviewed.”

“Custody?”

“Accompanied here. They will not be kept at Blackwater.”

Hedra looked at Ragna. Neither of them knew whether the wording would permit the men to walk into the house or stop them at the door. Vale wrote another instruction, this time in Hedra's presence. It named both men and directed that they be brought to the bank house without bindings. It also directed that Venn's wand be returned to him unless an officer recorded a specific reason to retain it.

“Will you sign that?” Hedra asked.

Vale did.

They waited. Fenn went home with Vessa; he had been standing too long and his hand had begun to throb. Edda took a meal to her aunt. Sella stayed with Hedra, though Neri was alone at the workshop with a neighbour. Mere put the counterfoil back in its oilcloth and gave the

pieces of the reconciliation to Issa under a receipt. The bank would keep them with the control book. Arven made copies before the ink on the receipt dried.

At last a cart came up the road. It was not the cart that had taken Tavin. This one had a flat bed and no rear gate. Tavin sat beside the driver. Venn sat behind them with an officer, holding his wand in both hands as if he had forgotten where to put it.

Hedra reached the cart before it stopped. Tavin climbed down badly, his legs stiff. She caught him and held him so tightly that he made a noise into her coat. She loosened her grip, examined the bandage on his wrist and then held him again.

Marian Lorne came from the crowd. Venn got off the cart without help. He gave her the wand to hold while he put on his coat, then took it back and tucked it away.

Ragna stood a little distance from Tavin. She let the things she had prepared to say wait until he loosened his hold on his mother.

When he finally looked up, he said, “Did you get the book?”

“Parts of it.”

“Was anyone hurt?”

“Brann burned his fingers. The clerk's ankle. The healer has seen him.”

Tavin looked past her at the smoke mark over the doorway. “Did it work?”

“We have enough for the partners to pay the disputed charge. They signed.”

“And Venn?”

“He's here.”

“I can see that. What happens to him?”

Vale approached with the officer who had accompanied the cart. The allegations against both men remained open, she said. They were required to provide addresses where notices could reach them. They were free to leave the bank house and would receive a written summons if further questions were required.

Tavin gave Hedra's address. Venn gave Marian's shop, after asking her. She agreed and told the officer the hours when he could deliver a notice without blocking her customers.

Hedra took her son home. Marian went with Venn towards the baker's. The remaining workers began to discuss when the lift would be tested. Tola said she would return in the morning if she could examine the whole chain with another tester and if the foreman would stop calling the halt an act of sabotage. She would not promise on anyone else's behalf.

The carts for the reserve records stayed empty. Vale sealed the boxes in the bank house with Issa and Arven witnessing the inventory. She set a date for a new hearing on the transfer and the fire. The records remained under order. Their owners knew where they were and what each box held; Ragna had hoped to bring them back to the counting room.

As Ragna left, Sella caught up with her and put an envelope in her hand.

“What's this?”

“Your coal. From the fund.”

“I can pay it back when my wages come.”

“You can give to the fund when you have something to give.”

Ragna opened the envelope. Inside was a note naming a coal merchant and the amount the trustees had agreed. It was not enough for the whole winter. She folded it along its crease and put it in her pocket.

Chapter Twenty-Two: The Work of Keeping

The first person Sella went to pay was not at home.

Sella found him at his cousin's forge, working a bellows with his coat off. He saw the envelope in her hand and stopped. The fire sank behind him.

“I wasn't sure you'd want me coming here,” she said.

“I wasn't sure you'd pay me.”

She gave him the envelope. He counted the coins on a ledge, once, and then made her wait while he found his own record of the days. His cousin worked the bellows in his place.

“You've included the afternoon I left.”

“You showed Neri where the hinge would bind.”

“That took ten minutes.”

“It saved her more.”

He put the last coin into his purse. “Tell her the new pin wants filing on the inside edge. I forgot to say.”

Sella did not ask whether he would come back. She took his receipt and went to the next address on her list.

By noon the workshop table was covered with signed slips. A few people could not be found, and one disputed the number of hours Sella had recorded. They sat with the tally sticks between them until they found a day entered under the wrong week. Neither remembered who had made the mark. Sella paid the difference and

wrote the correction where both of them could see it.

Neri sat at the bench with her foot on a padded stool. The healer had allowed her to work if she kept it raised and stopped when the swelling returned. She had brought the broken warning bell to the bench and taken its little striker apart.

“It doesn't know the difference between a thief and a coat,” Orren said.

“It knows the difference between a coat and a door.”

“It caught the healer.”

“She walked into the door.”

Orren considered this. “Perhaps it should ask first.”

Neri put a spring in his hand. “Ask it how.”

Ragna arrived with Tavin. He was wearing the other coat, the one he preferred. The bandage on his wrist had been replaced with a smaller one, and he had eaten breakfast at home, though Hedra had sent bread with him in case he had lied.

He put the bread on the table. “My mother says it's for anyone who needs it.”

“Does she know you didn't eat it?” Sella asked.

“She watched me wrap it.”

“Then we may safely take it.”

He sat beside Ragna with the copied wage schedule. They had agreed to help Arven reconstruct the pages of the iron ledger that had burned. Some figures survived in workshop books, withdrawal slips and receipts.

Others did not. Arven had ruled a separate column for sums no one could yet prove. He had also left space beside each entry for the person affected to write a disagreement.

“It will make the book untidy,” he had said.

“Good,” Sella had replied.

The first disagreement came before lunch. A woman from the furnace believed she had repaid a small loan in winter. The bank slip showed only half the sum. Her brother remembered carrying the rest to the counting house, but could not remember which clerk had taken it.

Ragna found no receipt, and the brother had written no other record. The woman wanted the loan marked paid; the bank would not yet agree.

“What do you put there?” she asked, pointing to the new column.

“Both accounts,” Ragna said. “Yours and the bank's. With the dates we can establish.”

“And I still owe it?”

“The bank says you do. You say you don't. We haven't resolved that.”

The woman looked at the page. “Will it stop me taking my wages?”

“Not the wages already agreed. Issa has signed that.”

“Then write it.”

The woman read Ragna's entry aloud and changed one word: her brother had carried the money to the counting house. She could not name the clerk who took it.

When they had finished, Tavin took the sheet to Arven at the bank house. He had been offered his apprenticeship back, but not under Ragna. Merrok's suspension remained in place while the partners examined the accounts. Arven had asked Tavin to help with the reconstruction because he knew where the copies were kept. Tavin had agreed for one week. He had not agreed to say nothing about what happened after it.

Ragna's own employment ended with a letter delivered that afternoon. Issa had signed it. The bank could not retain her as an authorised examiner while she was a witness in the inquiry, the letter said. Her wages would be paid through the end of the month. There was a separate offer of six weeks' work advising the partners on reconstructed accounts. It paid by the day, gave her no authority to certify a balance and could be ended with a week's notice.

Sella read the letter after Ragna.

“Will you take it?”

“I don't know.”

“You don't have to answer today.”

“I know.”

Sella folded the letter and gave it back. This time she did not correct the answer.

Mere came the next morning with Neri's tool roll. The small file with the chipped handle was missing. The hammer and pliers were there, along with two pins that did not belong to Neri.

“The depot sent the cart back,” Mere said. “The rim is worse. They say they aren't paying for it.”

“Did you get that in writing?” Ragna asked.

Mere gave her a look. “Do you think I went there without paper?”

Neri untied the roll. She picked up the hammer, turned it and put it down. Then she counted the tools again.

“I can replace the file,” Sella said.

“I know.” Neri pushed the extra pins towards Orren. “These aren't ours.”

He did not take them. “Can we ask whose?”

“Yes. After I ask about my file.”

Mere had a second envelope. It contained a copy of the depot's refusal to cover the cart hire. She placed it beside the counterfoil, which had been returned to her after the partners' examination.

“I have a claim against Thorn. I mean to keep it separate from yours.”

“Of course,” Sella said.

“I didn't say I wouldn't show them together. I said they are separate.”

She stayed for tea. Kelm was working at her foundry under Hask's supervision. He had given Vale a statement about the lift, including his own decision to remove the rail and continue the work. Vale had taken a separate statement from Brann, who knew only what happened below. She had also asked Pell for the account Kelm said he had been shown at Thorn.

“Will there be a hearing?” Sella asked.

“They say there will.” Mere stirred her tea. “They asked Kelm whether he had anything to add. He said he would answer questions when they put them in writing.”

“Did Harrow give a statement?”

“I wasn't there.”

Sella looked at the table for a long time. “I want what we know about Dorrik put where people can read it. Not every detail. Enough that they stop saying he went below alone.”

Neri set down the bell striker. “Can I hear the rest first?”

Sella looked at her. “Yes.”

They went to the healer's room that evening because it was quiet and Neri could keep her foot supported there. Ragna came at Neri's request and brought Kelm's signed account. Sella sat on one side of the bed and held a cup of water. The healer closed the curtain and told them to call if they needed her.

Ragna read from the place where she had stopped before. She read how Kelm removed the rail, how Dorrik objected, how Harrow told them to continue and the load shifted. She read Kelm's uncertainty about what Dorrik intended when he reached for the cart. She read that Kelm had shut the control and that Brann had called from below.

Neri listened with her hands on the blanket. At the end she asked Ragna to read the sentence about the brake again.

“He asked my father to look at it.”

“Yes.”

“He didn't go down there by himself.”

“No.”

Neri took the water from Sella and drank. Then she asked for the account. Ragna gave it to her and waited while she read the pages herself. Her eyes stopped at Kelm's signature.

“Will he come if I ask?”

“I think so,” Sella said. “You don't have to ask.”

“I know.”

She handed the account back. “Not yet.”

They wrote the public notice two days later. Sella chose the words; Neri changed one sentence; Ragna checked the dates against the statements. It said that Dorrik had been at the lift while a load was being moved, that the corner rail had been removed, and that he had fallen after the load shifted. Kelm and Brann had each agreed to these limited descriptions before the notice was posted. It identified their roles without naming either witness: the foreman at the lift and the porter who found Dorrik below. It said the circumstances remained under inquiry. It did not claim that a court had decided responsibility.

Sella took the first copy to the workshop. Neri fastened it beside the brass plate with the four names. She could not stand for long, so Orren held the paper while she worked the pins into the wood.

“Is it straight?” he asked.

“No,” she said.

He moved his hand. “Now?”

“Close enough.”

The Ministry's reserve order had not been withdrawn. Vale returned to the bank house to take statements about the fire and the detention. Harrow was no longer directing that examination; Ragna heard he had been assigned elsewhere while his actions were reviewed. When people asked whether he had been dismissed, she said she hadn't heard.

Venn made his own statement about the altered dispatch. Marian went with him and waited outside the room. When he came out, she gave him a parcel of paper and told him it was not a gift. He paid her the following week, in two instalments, and she entered both in her shop book.

Ilva left her position at the bank. She gave Issa the keys to the examiner's cabinet and signed an inventory of what remained in it. She did not ask Ragna to speak for her. At the next meeting of the contributors she stood and described the advance, the second charge and the page she had concealed. Some wanted her barred from the room; others had more questions. She stayed to hear them all and accepted that the next meeting would decide whether she could return.

The news from outside the district came in pieces. A carrier reported a road closed farther north. A furnace worker said his brother's workshop had stopped a

Ministry order. The next day someone said the brother had gone back to work. By week's end, no one at Sella's table could say whether that workshop was working or idle.

Tavin wanted to print the district's account of the affair. Ragna wanted to wait until the hearing had taken evidence from Kelm and Brann. They argued in the workshop while Neri sorted the returned tools.

“If we wait for every official to finish asking, they'll write the only account people have,” Tavin said.

“If you publish a witness's name before he agrees, you may make him unable to give the account at all.”

“I didn't say I would.”

“You didn't ask yet.”

He set the sheet on the bench. “Then come with me when I ask.”

She looked at the sheet. It named the bank, the Ministry order, the duplicate charge and the payments. There were blank spaces where he had intended to add the witness accounts. At the bottom he had written that the inquiry remained open.

“All right,” she said.

They went first to Mere's foundry. Kelm was working beside Hask, carrying finished fittings to a rack. He listened to the request and asked to read the sheet. He kept it until the end of the shift. When he returned it, he had crossed out his own name and written a sentence that identified his role without giving his address.

“You can use that,” he said. “If the hearing asks for me, I'll answer for myself.”

Brann agreed to a shorter description of what he had seen at the bottom of the shaft. Vessa read it over before he signed. Borr did not agree to publish his name, but allowed the account to say that a carrier had brought twenty bars to Thorn. Rell still refused to show her load number. Tavin left that part blank.

They printed the sheet at Marian's shop. She charged for the paper and allowed them to use the press after closing. Ragna fed the pages while Tavin took them from the other side. The first three came out crooked. Marian made them stop, adjust the guide and begin again. She did not offer to do the work herself.

When they had finished, Tavin set one copy aside for the bank house and another for the school. He took six for the furnace gates, then looked at Ragna.

“Tomorrow?”

“What did the meeting agree?”

“Tomorrow, after the people named have seen it.”

“Then tomorrow.”

He put the six copies back on the table. There was ink on the side of his hand. He tried to wipe it away and only spread it.

The following morning Ragna went to Sella's workshop with the last of the reconstructed wage entries for the week. The warning bell sounded as she came in, then stopped before it caught her coat. Neri had fitted a smaller spring. Orren stood beneath it with the wooden

boat, watching for another failure.

“It worked,” he said.

“For her,” Neri replied. “We haven't tried it on you.”

He went out and came back through the door three times. On the third attempt the bell gave a short, offended note. He looked pleased.

Sella cleared a place at the table. Ragna laid down the entries, including the disputed loan. Beside them she put a copy of Tavin's account, now marked with the permissions each witness had given. Sella read the loan entry first.

“We'll need another page,” she said. “There isn't room for the woman's reply.”

Ragna fetched one from her bag. She had started carrying loose paper again. The pencil was shorter than it had been at the beginning of the quarter, and she had wrapped thread around the end to make it easier to hold.

Outside, a cart stopped in the yard. Someone called for a hinge to be examined. Neri told Orren to ask which door it belonged to before bringing it inside. He went up the passage with the boat still in his hand.

Ragna turned to the clean page and wrote the woman's name. Then she left enough space for the answer.